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Government of Haryana

Viksit Bharat – Viksit Haryana

Flagging-off of India's first Hydrogen Train between Jind and Sonipat

Fully indigenous and based on hydrogen fuel cell technology, in which the train runs on electricity generated from hydrogen and oxygen (drawn from air), emitting only water vapour

World's most powerful hydrogen train, with 3,200 horsepower

World's longest hydrogen train, with 10 coaches

World's highest passenger-capacity hydrogen train, with a capacity of 2,600 passengers

along with

Dedication to the Nation and Foundation Stone Laying for Development Projects worth about ₹15,000 crore

Delhi - Amritsar - Katra Expressway (Cost: approx. ₹9,700 crore)
- Delhi to Katra journey made easier - now takes just 6 hours instead of 14 hours
- Haryana's Jhajjar, Sonipat, Jind and Kaithal districts connected to the expressway

Ambala - Kala Amb National Highway (Cost: approx. ₹1,200 crore)
- Stronger connectivity between Haryana and Himachal Pradesh
- Reduced transport time and logistics costs for industries
- Safer travel for the public, new momentum for trade

Pandit Neki Ram Sharma Government Medical College (Cost: approx. ₹600 crore)
- Bhiwani district hospital upgraded into a medical college
- 630-bedded hospital
- Classes begun following admission to 100 MBBS seats

Jind - Gohana National Highway (Cost: approx. ₹1,600 crore)
- Jind-to-Gohana travel time reduced from 2 hours to just 40 minutes
- To help farmers reach agricultural produce markets more easily
- Better connectivity to Rohtak–Panipat–Delhi NCR

Kurukshetra Elevated Railway Track (Cost: approx. ₹400 crore)
- Smoother traffic flow
- Five railway level crossings in highly populated areas removed
- Relief to public from traffic congestion

Maharishi Chyawan Medical College (Cost: approx. ₹900 crore)
- Treatment capacity increased with a 650-bedded hospital
- Admissions to 100 MBBS seats
- OPD facility started

Sikh Museum, Kurukshetra (Cost: approx. ₹160 crore)
- Inspiring younger generation with the heritage, life, and cultural significance of the Sikh Gurus

Hansi - Barwala National Highway (Cost: approx. ₹140 crore)
- Better road connectivity between Hisar and Panchkula
- More economical agricultural production and local freight transport
- Boost to local employment and economic activity

by

Sh. Narendra Modi

Prime Minister

August Presence

Prof. Ashim Kumar Ghosh — Governor, Haryana

Sh. Nayab Singh Saini — Chief Minister, Haryana

Sh. Nitin Jairam Gadkari — Union Minister for Road Transport & Highways

Sh. Ashwini Vaishnaw — Union Minister for Railways

Date: 17 July, 2026 | Time: 9:00 AM

Venue:- HSVP Ground, Sector - 9, Jind, Haryana

DD NEWS Live broadcast on DD News

You are cordially invited

Information, Public Relations & Languages Department, Haryana | www.prharyana.gov.in | Follow us on @diprharyana

IRAN RETALIATED WITH MISSILE AND DRONE FIRE TARGETING US ALLIES

US expands strikes into north Iran, disables ship trying to run blockade

DUBAI: The United States intensified its strikes on Iran early Thursday, hitting targets further north as American forces also fired into a ship the US accused of trying to break its naval blockade on the Islamic Republic. Iran retaliated with missile and drone fire targeting US allies in the region before dawn and warned its attacks may escalate.

Days of back-and-forth strikes by the US and Iran across the Middle East — and renewed threats to the Strait of Hormuz — have shredded the interim deal to end the Iran war and could tip the region back into all-out war. Already, Iranian officials say US strikes have killed more than 35 people and wounded over 300 others.

Strikes also reached into areas around Iran's capital, Tehran, for the first time in this latest round of violence, showing a widening set of targets for the Americans.

When the US and Israel launched the war on Iran on February 28, Tehran effectively closed the strait to shipping traffic, a move that sent the price of oil, fertiliser and many other goods soaring far beyond the region and gave Iran major leverage in negotiations.

Col. Ebrahim Zolfaghari, a spokesperson for the Iranian military's Khatam al-Anbiya Central Headquarters, threatened that Iran could launch widespread attacks on regional infrastructure if the US acts on President Donald Trump's repeated warnings that America could hit Iranian bridges and power plants.

"All the infrastructure in the region will be crushed under the steel blows of the powerful armed forces of the Islamic Republic of Iran" should Trump's threat be carried out, Zolfaghari said.

"Under no circumstances and in no way will we allow America, as a foreign and extra-regional country, to interfere in the Strait of Hormuz," he added. "This is Iran's invincible red line."

The US strikes early Thursday hit around Tehran, state media reported. It also reported that American attacks targeted Semnan province, home to Iran's ballistic missile production and space program.

Iranian media also reported strikes Thursday morning around the provinces of Hamedan, Hormozgan, Khuzestan, Lorestan, Markazi, and Sistan and Baluchistan.

On Wednesday, the US resumed striking Iran during daylight, further showing the increasing tempo of the attacks. An attack on Greater Tunb Island, a strategic point in the Strait of Hormuz, targeted Iranian defence and missile sites, Central Command said.

Meanwhile, the US military said it opened fire on the Curacao-flagged oil tanker Belma sailing toward Kharg Island, Iran's main oil export terminal in the Persian Gulf. AGENCIES

Highlights

- Iranian officials say US strikes have killed more than 35 people and injured over 300 others
- Strikes also reached into areas around Iran's capital, Tehran, for the first time in this latest round of violence
- It also reported that American attacks targeted Semnan province, home to Iran's ballistic missile production and space program

REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

Radical left unique evil, need to crush it forever: Rubio

WASHINGTON: The United States on Thursday launched a global effort to counter far-left political terrorism, with Secretary of State Marco Rubio terming it as a "distinctive and unique evil" that needs to be dismantled to defend civilisation.

Inaugurating the international ministerial on 'The Resurgence of Political Terrorism' here, Rubio said many people in positions of power have repeatedly dismissed acts of violence and terrorism as legitimate forms of political expression, so long as they served a left-wing cause.

"We can and we must identify and map this threat and rebuild our counter-terrorism architecture to defeat it," Rubio said while addressing representatives and diplomats from several countries.

The Trump administration's 2026 counter-terrorism strategy identifies three primary threats: "Islamist terrorism", "narco-terrorism" and "violent left-wing extremists, including Anarchists and Anti-Fascists".

White House Deputy Chief of Staff Stephen Miller and Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent also addressed the inaugural session of the meeting.

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio

'We can and we must identify and map this threat and rebuild our counter-terrorism architecture to defeat it'

Rubio said that over the past several years, left-wing violence was not just excused, but treated as sacrosanct and a protected class unto itself.

"That era has to end…t can no longer be denied. And it can no longer be ignored. Because it is time to crush this evil forever," Rubio said.

He described radical leftism as "a distinctive and unique evil" that has always been driven by a hatred for civilisation itself.

"It is a revolt of the worst against the best; of the weak and the cowardly against the strong and the good.

It is perpetrated by those who cannot build, cannot create, cannot achieve great things - and take their revenge upon the world for their own inadequacy by seeking to destroy those who can," Rubio said.

Some critics of the Trump administration's counterterrorism approach have claimed its focus on threats from the far left is misguided.

Analysis conducted by the Centre for Strategic and International Studies (CSIS) in 2025 found that while left-wing violence in the US has increased over the past decade, "it has risen from very low levels and remains much lower than historical levels of violence carried out by right-wing and jihadist attackers."

The CSIS report concluded it was "important to resource all dimensions of the terrorism threat." AGENCIES

Protesters rally in Kyiv as Zelenskyy moves to oust defence minister

The outgoing defence chief was seen as a modernizer

KYIV: President Volodymyr Zelenskyy shook up his wartime government, drawing hundreds of Ukrainians into the streets Thursday to protest the ouster of his youthful defence minister — seen as an innovator of the country's successful drone technology but who clashed with the traditional military establishment.

The personnel overhaul, which included replacing his prime minister, could become a test of Zelenskyy's political authority as Ukraine's fight against Russia's full-scale invasion approaches 4½ years. Zelenskyy has remained in office under martial law because wartime elections are prohibited but has periodically reshuffled his government.

The moves threw Ukraine's military leadership into an unwelcome crisis just as its actions against Russia were starting to bear fruit and came against a backdrop of Moscow's unrelenting aerial attacks. Two people were killed and five others were wounded, including a child, when Russian missiles hit the capital of Kyiv overnight, Ukraine's Emergency Service said. Zelenskyy cited friction between outgoing Defence Minister Mykhailo Fedorov and Gen. Oleksandr Syrskyi, the commander of Ukraine's armed forces.

"I'm just showing that if the sides can't resolve an issue, I will have to resolve it," Zelenskyy said at a news conference.

Fedorov, 35, is considered to be a vigorous modernizer whose technological expertise is credited in part with significantly improving Ukraine's military performance in recent months against Russia's bigger army. AGENCIES

"I'M JUST SHOWING THAT IF THE SIDES CAN'T RESOLVE AN ISSUE, I WILL HAVE TO RESOLVE IT"

Pak urges US, Iran to resume talks amid renewed strike

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan on Thursday urged the US and Iran to end hostilities and resume negotiations, as renewed military strikes between the two sides threatened to derail their interim peace arrangement and further destabilise the region.

Addressing the weekly media briefing, Foreign Office spokesperson Tahir Andrabi acknowledged the challenges facing the interim peace deal.

The Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding (MoU), signed last month, had led to the launch of technical-level talks aimed at reaching a permanent peace agreement within 60 days.

However, the process stalled after the US and Iran resumed attacks last week.

Andrabi said as hostilities have continued over the past week, "Pakistan reiterates its call on all parties to exercise maximum restraint and refrain from any actions that would further undermine peace and stability".

"Pakistan will continue to encourage all sides to end violence and resume technical-level talks in accordance. We hope all parties will remain committed to the path of dialogue and diplomacy in resolving their outstanding issues," he said. Reiterating Islamabad's position, Andrabi said that there was no alternative to sustained engagement, dialogue, and diplomacy in pursuit of lasting peace, stability, and progress.

The latest round of attacks came after the US expanded its military strikes on Iran, while Tehran responded with missile and drone attacks. AGENCIES

More than half of House Democrats vote to cut Israel aid in growing split

WASHINGTON: More than half the House Democrats have voted to strip USD 3.3 billion in US aid from Israel, the most substantial signal yet that once rock-solid bipartisan support for the country is disintegrating in the aftermath of its war in Gaza that has killed thousands of Palestinians.

Wednesday's vote tally, 104-314, was not enough to attach the amendment to a broader national security spending bill, but stands as a stark accounting of the shifting attitudes that are dividing the Democratic Party and the nation over Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's war strategy, now approaching its third year.

Israeli lawmakers in the Israeli parliament hold a discussion AP/PTI

The House's Democratic leadership split over the issue in what was largely seen as a test vote ahead of the US midterm elections that will determine control of Congress. More than 100 Democrats voted for the amendment to strip the foreign military aid money, and almost as many voted against. AGENCIES

Houthi leader in Yemen threatens escalation with Saudi Arabia

CAIRO: The leader of Iran-backed Houthi rebels in Yemen said Thursday that his group was ready to escalate its conflict with Saudi Arabia, after the two sides exchanged strikes on each other's airports.

In the most significant confrontation since a 2022 truce, Saudi warplanes struck Sanaa International Airport on Sunday.

In response, the Houthis launched missiles and drones at Saudi Arabia's Abha International Airport on Monday. There were no casualties reported.

Tensions flared earlier this month when the Houthis accused Saudi Arabia of trying to prevent the return of an Iranian plane carrying a Houthi delegation to Tehran for the funeral of Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei.

The plane was diverted after the Sanaa airport was bombed and landed safely in the city of Hodeida. Saudi officials did not respond to a request for comment about the airstrikes in Yemen.

Houthi leader Abdul Malik al-Houthi said the group's response to the strike on Sanaa airport was "modest" and that the "real equation would be Sanaa airport for Riyadh airport. AGENCIES

No radiation leak after 'contamination' events at Africa's only nuclear plant, says regulator

'Three separate contamination events on June 30, July 2 and 7 were contained inside station'

CAPE TOWN: South Africa's nuclear regulator said Thursday that no radioactive material leaked into the environment during three recent "contamination" events inside Africa's only nuclear power station.

The incidents involved "elevated airborne radioactive contamination" inside the Koeberg Power Station, on South Africa's west coast, when there was a loss of power to ventilation units during maintenance work, the National Nuclear Regulator said, adding there was no danger to the public.

It said the three separate contamination events on June 30, July 2 and July 7 were contained inside the station.

Key Points

- It is Africa's only commercial nuclear power station and was commissioned in the 1980s during apartheid
- It has two reactors which generate around 5 per cent of South Africa's electricity
- Its reactors were recently granted 20-year life extensions, clearing them to be operational until after 2040

Workers inside the power station who may have been exposed were screened and recorded radioactive contamination below the radioactivity a person is exposed to when they have a dental X-ray, the NNR said.

The regulator said that while it was conducting further inspections the recent events "did not meet the criteria for classification as a nuclear or radiological incident or emergency and did not result in any off-site radiological consequences."

The Koeberg plant is located around 40 km north of South Africa's second biggest city, Cape Town.

It is Africa's only commercial nuclear power station and was commissioned in the 1980s during apartheid. It has two reactors which generate around 5 per cent of South Africa's electricity, and is operated by the national electricity company, Eskom.

Its reactors were recently granted 20-year life extensions, clearing them to be operational until after 2040.

South Africa has plans to expend its commercial nuclear capability with new stations to support its unreliable and polluting energy supply, which is struggling to provide for a growing population and heavily based on burning coal.

Other countries are also turning more towards nuclear power to meet skyrocketing energy demands despite long-held safety fears from opponents of nuclear power citing disasters like Chernobyl and, more recently, Fukushima in Japan.

Several other African nations are advancing their own commercial nuclear plans, including Egypt, which is building its first nuclear power station with four large Russian reactors that it hopes will be operational around 2030 and generate around 10 per cent of the country's electricity, according to the World Nuclear Association. AGENCIES

GOVERNMENT OF MAHARASHTRA
Executive Engineer
P.W.Division, Palghar,
E-Tender Notice No. 15 for 2026-2027

Online Tenders (e-tender) in "B1" form for the work is invited by the Executive Engineer, P.W. Division, Palghar on Government of Maharashtra Electronic Tender Management System from the Registered Contractors in appropriate class of Public Works Department of Maharashtra State

This tender notice contains 04 (Four) work s and their details can also be viewed and downloaded online directly from the Government of Maharashtra e-tendering Portal https://mahatenders.gov.in and sub portal https://pwd.maharashtra.gov.in

Sr.No.	Name of Work	Estimated Cost (Excluding G.S.T.)	Fund Head	Class Of Contractor
1	CONSTRUCTION OF COMPOUND WALL, DRAIN, PAVER BLOCK AND OTHER AMENTIES FOR RTO OFFICE BUILDING AT GOKHIVARE TAL.VASAI DIST.PALGHAR.	Rs. 14749842/-	4059 Capital Expenditure on Public Works	Class 4 and Above
2	CONSTRUCTION OF MINOR BRIDGE ON POMAN SARJAPADA APPROACH ROAD VR-346 AT KM. 1/000 IN TAL.VASAI DIST.PALGHAR.	Rs. 18153976/-	5054 (04) Road And Bridge NABARD-31	Eligible and Competent
3	CONSTRUCTIONOF MINOR BRIDGE ON NAGALE DIVEKARPADA TO PHANASPADA ROAD VR-358 AT KM. 0/300 TAL.VASAI DIST.PALGHAR.	Rs. 9147307/-	5054 (04) Road And Bridge NABARD-31	Class 4 and Above
4	CONSTRUCTION OF COMPOUND WALL FOR GOVERNMENT ASHRAM SCHOOL UDHAWA TAL.TALASARI DIST.PALGHAR.	Rs. 7079360/-	Pradhan Mantri khanij Kshetra kalyan Yojana	Class 4-A & Above

The Executive Engineer P.W.Division, Palghar Reserves right to Accept or Reject any offer. Conditional offers will not be accepted.

All registered contractor should note.
Above E- Tender Available Date. 17/07/2026 to 24/07/2026.
Above This Work Sr. No. 02 Pre-Bid Conference, will be held at Thane on 20/07/2026 at 14:30 Hrs. in the office of the Superintending Engineer, Public Works Circle, Thane.
E- Tender Opening Date. 27/07/2026.

No. P.W./Palghar/Tender/4750
Office of the Executive
Engineer P.W. Division, Palghar,
Bandhkam Bhavan,Near Dhavle Hospital,
Boisar-Palghar Road,Tal.Dist.Palghar 401 404.
Date : 10/07/2026

(M.P.KINI)
Executive Engineer
P.W. Division, Palghar

Dgipr/2026-27/1746

FISHERIES RECEIVE 29% OF THE LOANS

China funds African farmers but not food processing and storage

PRETORIA: What and where is China investing in when it comes to agriculture?

China's agricultural funding mainly goes to farm development, fisheries, irrigation, mechanisation, agricultural technology and rural infrastructure. They invest less in agro-processing and storage.

Southern African countries (Angola, Zambia, Zimbabwe and Mozambique) receive the most in loans. They're followed by east Africa (Ethiopia, Kenya and Tanzania) and west Africa (Nigeria and Ghana). Chinese institutions also invest in agriculture in Egypt.

My study compared agricultural lending from Chinese institutions with lending to other sectors. It also looked at who received the loans, where the money went, and the kinds of farming projects that were funded.

I found that Chinese lending to agriculture has expanded across Africa. Between 2000 and 2024, Chinese lenders financed 41 agricultural loans worth approximately US$2.26 billion across Africa.

REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

Most agricultural finance supported farm schemes, production estates, fisheries, mechanisation and irrigation infrastructure.

Farm schemes accounted for almost 36% of agricultural lending.

Fisheries received 29% of the loans.

Investment in storage and cold-chain infrastructure made up only 3% of China's loans.

Loans for agro-processing facilities were less than 2%.

Larger loans were more frequently channelled through government-affiliated agencies and other non-sovereign entities rather than national governments.

Overall, agricultural funding is a relatively small part of China's much larger development finance portfolio. Transport, energy and other infrastructure sectors consistently received much larger commitments.

My study found that many investments improved farming infrastructure, such as irrigation systems and roads.

However, there was not enough investment in food processing, storage, transport and markets. These are needed to build strong agricultural industries. AGENCIES

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CITY: PG 5
Sewage push enters fast lane

NATION: PG 9
'Cong to corner Centre over Ram temple donations, edu

FILM: PG 14
'They don't make movies like Kal Ho Na Ho anymore'

NEET-UG results declared after re-test, 11.21 lakh candidates qualify

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Punjab's Aryan Gupta and Haryana's Panshul Bansal emerged as the joint toppers of NEET-UG 2026, scoring 715 out of 720, as the National Testing Agency (NTA) declared results on Thursday. A total of 11.21 lakh candidates qualified the medical entrance examination, compared with 12.36 lakh last year, although the qualification rate remained around 56 per cent as fewer candidates appeared. More than 58 per cent of the successful candidates were women.

The exam, held on May 9, was cancelled three days later over paper leak allegations and was conducted again on June 21. The CBI is investigating the case. The Centre has since announced that future NEET-UG exams will be conducted in computer-based mode.

NTA said 19 candidates scored 700, while 1,492 secured 650 or above. Uttar Pradesh recorded the highest number of qualifiers at over 1.7 lakh. See P6

Monsoon Session of Parl to see five new Bills, two pending ones

Govt lists Bills to amend FCRA Act, introduce Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act

VINAY KUMAR

NEW DELHI: As the government prepares for the coming Monsoon session of Parliament which begins on July 20, it is likely to bring five new Bills and two pending ones before the House during the session. The government will explain the Bills to political parties during the customary all-party meeting.

Though there has been speculation that the government may bring the Constitution Amendment Bill only if it is sure of securing a two-thirds majority in the Lok Sabha, the Bill, however, does not appear in the tentative agenda for the Monsoon session. Of the five new Bills in addition to those previously introduced, two will replace ordinances announced before.

A Bill to make any insult or obstruction to the singing of the National Song Vande Matram a punishable offence and another Bill seeking to make "delayed registration" of birth and death more stringent have been listed by the government for introduction in the Lok Sabha during the session.

The Lok Sabha secretariat said that the government has also listed the consideration and passing of the contentious Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026.

This Bill was introduced in the Lok Sabha during the Budget session but did not come up for consideration and passage, ostensibly due to opposition from certain quarters in Kerala, where assembly elections were due around that time.

A bulletin issued by the Lok Sabha secretariat said the Prevention Continued on P6

KEY POINTS

- Constitution Amendment Bill is absent from the tentative Monsoon session agenda
- Two proposed Bills will replace ordinances issued before the session
- Vande Mataram insult Bill proposes punishment for insult or obstruction during singing
- Bill amends the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971
- Births and Deaths Amendment Bill tightens delayed registration provisions
- FCRA Amendment Bill, 2026 returns for consideration after Budget session delay

LS admits resolution opposing ordinance to hike number of judges in SC

NEW DELHI: The Centre is expected to introduce a bill during the Monsoon session of Parliament to replace an ordinance that raised the sanctioned strength of the Supreme Court from 34 to 38 judges, including the Chief Justice of India.

A Lok Sabha bulletin issued on Wednesday said the House has admitted a statutory resolution moved by Opposition members against the Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Ordinance, 2026. The resolution states, "This House disapproves of Continued on P6

Delhi HC orders daily health monitoring of Sonam Wangchuk

AAP national convenor Arvind Kejriwal interacts with climate activist Sonam Wangchuk during his hunger strike at Jantar Mantar

Doctors warn of critical condition

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Thursday directed authorities to monitor activist Sonam Wangchuk's health every day and provide immediate medical intervention if his condition worsens, as doctors warned that his prolonged hunger strike had entered a critical phase with the risk of organ damage. The order came while the court was hearing a public interest litigation (PIL) expressing concern over Wangchuk's deteriorating health. Even as political leaders, legal bodies, public figures and supporters urged him to end his indefinite fast, Wangchuk said he would not withdraw the protest without a response from the government, arguing that doing so would send the wrong message. Instead, he called on people to strengthen the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) planned Parliament march on July 20.

A bench comprising Chief Justice D K Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia observed that the life of every citizen was precious and directed government doctors to clinically monitor Wangchuk's condition on a daily basis. The court said authorities should provide whatever medical intervention was required if doctors found his health deteriorating.

"We observe that life of any citizen is precious and all medical efforts ought to be made by government authorities to save the same," the bench said while disposing of the PIL.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for both the Centre and the Delhi government, told the court that there was no objection to regular medical examinations of Wangchuk. He said health checkups were already being carried out whenever Wangchuk permitted government doctors to examine him and that Continued on P6

HIGHLIGHTS

- Bench said every citizen's life is precious and must be protected
- Centre accepted regular medical examinations by government doctors
- Wangchuk has been on indefinite fast since June 28
- Doctors said Wangchuk has entered a critical stage of prolonged fasting
- Kejriwal, Dimple Yadav and Omar Abdullah backed Wangchuk's protest

SC suggests 3rd language from Class 5 or 6

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday expressed concern over the introduction of a third language from Class 9 under the CBSE curriculum, saying it could increase academic pressure on students. The court suggested that if a new language is to be introduced, it should begin in Class 5 or Class 6, when children are better placed to adapt.

A bench of Justices BV Nagarathna and R Mahadevan made the observations while hearing the Tamil Nadu government's plea against a Madras High Court order directing the establishment of Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalayas (JNVs) in every district of the state.

"Union of India please don't have a third language from Class 9 level. Continued on P6

Govt hikes windfall tax on diesel and ATF; cuts levy on exports of petrol

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Centre has increased the windfall tax on exports of diesel and aviation turbine fuel (ATF) while reducing the levy on petrol exports for the fortnight starting July 16.

According to a Finance Ministry notification, the Special Additional Excise Duty (SAED) on diesel exports has been raised to Rs 15.5 per litre from Rs 8.5 per litre. The duty on ATF exports has also been increased to Rs 14.5 per litre from Rs 7.5 per litre. At the same time, the export duty on petrol has been lowered to Rs 2.5 per litre from Rs 4 per litre.

The revised rates came into effect on July 16, the ministry said.

The government first imposed a windfall tax on diesel and ATF exports on March 27 after tensions in West Asia pushed up global crude oil prices. Since then, the export duty has been reviewed every fortnight. Petrol exports also came under the windfall tax from May 16.

The ministry said there is no change in the duty on petrol and diesel supplied for domestic consumption.

The windfall tax was introduced to improve the availability of petroleum products within the country and prevent exporters from benefiting from higher international prices during the West Asia conflict. Continued on P6

8 TO 9 LAKH DEVOTEES TOOK PART

Two die, several fall ill in crowd surge during Rath Yatra in Puri

MPOST BUREAU

PURI: Two devotees died and several others fell ill during the Rath Yatra celebrations in Odisha's temple town on Thursday as heavy rain, a temporary crowd surge and weather-related discomfort affected parts of the festival, the Chief Minister's Office (CMO) said.

According to the CMO, seven people became unwell during the event and were shifted to hospitals without delay. One devotee, a man aged over 60 years,

An ambulance stuck amid a temporary crowd surge during the 'Rath Yatra' festival procession, in Puri, Odisha, on Thursday PTI

US strike near Iran cancer hospital triggers evacuation of 211 patients, mostly children

TEHRAN: A specialised cancer hospital in Iran's southwestern city of Ahvaz was temporarily taken out of service after nearby US airstrikes forced the evacuation of 211 patients, including children receiving chemotherapy, according to Iranian state media. Officials said all patients were safely moved to other medical facilities and no casualties were reported.

The strikes took place late Wednesday near Shahid Baghaei Hospital, a haematology and oncology centre in Khuzestan province. Iranian authorities said the blasts sent shockwaves through the area, leading to the emergency evacuation "to protect the lives of patients," state-run IRNA reported.

A hospital staff member described the evacuation to Al Jazeera, saying, "Some people had children in their arms, some had IVs Continued on P6

BOATS LEFT MYANMAR'S RAKHINE STATE

Over 500 Rohingya refugees feared dead after two boats capsize in Bay of Bengal

SYDNEY: More than 500 people are feared dead after two boats carrying Rohingya refugees reportedly capsized in the Bay of Bengal, the International Organization for Migration (IOM) and the UN High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) said on Thursday.

According to the agencies, the boats left Myanmar's Rakhine state in late June with mostly Rohingya passengers, including some from refugee camps in Bangladesh.

> "WHILE THE INCIDENTS AND CASUALTY FIGURES HAVE YET TO BE OFFICIALLY CONFIRMED, UNHCR AND IOM ARE GRAVELY CONCERNED BY THE POTENTIALLY DEVASTATING LOSS OF LIFE"

One boat carrying about 250 people lost contact soon after departure, while another with around 280 people is believed to have sunk off Myanmar's Ayeyarwady coast on July 8.

"While the incidents and casualty figures have yet to be officially confirmed, UNHCR and IOM are gravely concerned by the potentially devastating loss of life," the agencies said. Continued on P6

CAFE-III

Govt proposes tighter fuel efficiency rules for passenger vehicles

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Ministry of Power has released the draft Corporate Average Fuel Economy (CAFE)-III norms for public consultation, proposing tougher fuel efficiency and carbon dioxide (CO2) emission standards for passenger vehicles from April 1, 2027. The proposed rules will apply to M1 category passenger vehicles manufactured or imported for sale in India between 2027-28 and 2031-32. The government has invited comments from automakers, industry stakeholders and the public until August 6, after which the final norms will be notified.

The proposed CAFE-III framework is intended to improve the fuel efficiency of passenger vehicles while lowering fleet-wide carbon emissions over the next five years. It will replace the existing CAFE-II norms, which are due to end on March 31, 2027.

Under the draft, fleet-average fuel consumption targets will become progressively stricter, reducing from 3.996 litres per 100 km, equivalent to 94.76 gCO2/km, in 2027-28 to 3.3273 litres per 100 km, or 78.90 gCO2/km, by 2031-32. The ministry said the phased approach is meant to give Continued on P6

TAKEAWAYS

- CAFE-III will replace existing CAFE-II norms after March 31, 2027
- Fuel consumption target tightens from 3.996 to 3.3273 litres per 100 km
- CO2 target falls from 94.76 to 78.90 gCO2/km by 2031-32
- Draft introduces Carbon Neutrality Factors for ethanol, biofuels and CBG

CRUSH ENGLAND'S HOPES AGAIN

Argentina stun England 2-1, set up 2026 World Cup final with Spain

ASSOCIATED PRESS

ATLANTA: No "Hand of God" this time. Argentina didn't need it.

Instead it was the hallowed feet of Lionel Messi and the unbreakable spirit of a team that has repeatedly fought back at this year's World Cup that is now one step away from back-to-back titles.

Trailing 1-0 going into the 85th minute, Argentina rallied for a 2-1 victory over England on Wednesday with goals from Enzo Fernandez and substitute Lautaro Martinez.

"I dreamed it, I swear. I told Alexis (Mac Allister) that I was going to score. I told him that I was going to come on and I was going to win it," Martinez said. "I can tell you this team keeps showing what it's made of."

At the final whistle, Messi fell to his knees in celebration while England players collapsed in disbelief — again.

Add 2026 to 1986 and 1998 on the list of games when Argentina has extinguished English hopes at the World Cup.

"I'm gutted for the team, the staff, the fans," England captain Harry Kane said. Continued on P6

England's Jude Bellingham celebrates after Enzo Fernandez scored their side's first goal during the World Cup semifinal soccer match between England and Argentina in Atlanta, on Wednesday AP/PTI

Govt tightens ISRO exit rules as over 100 scientists resign

Around 700 employees resigned between 2012 and 2024

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Department of Space (DoS) has tightened rules governing resignations and voluntary retirement at the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO), directing major centres not to routinely accept exit requests from scientists and engineers working on critical national missions, including the Gaganyaan human spaceflight programme. The move follows reports that more than 100 scientists have resigned from the space agency in recent months, prompting the government to centralise approval of such requests amid concerns over the impact on projects of national importance.

An internal memorandum dated July 14, issued to major ISRO centres including the U R Rao Satellite Centre (URSC) in Bengaluru and the Vikram Sarabhai Space Centre (VSSC) in Thiruvananthapuram, said there had been a "spate of requests" for resignation and voluntary retirement from Group 'A' scientific and technical personnel.

> Under the revised procedure, resignation and voluntary retirement requests from scientists and engineers associated with Gaganyaan and other important missions will no longer be accepted

"It is noticed that there has been a spate of requests for voluntary retirement and resignation from Group 'A' scientific/technical personnel including those associated with prestigious Gaganyaan and other important missions/projects, severely impacting implementation of projects of national importance," the memorandum said.

Under the revised procedure, resignation and voluntary retirement requests from scientists and engineers associated with Gaganyaan and other important missions will no longer be accepted as a matter of routine. Instead, ISRO centre directors must forward all such cases to the Department of Space, along with their recommendations, for a final decision. Continued on P6

Burari: Man kills lover and dies by suicide; police recover pistol

Probe points to distress after woman reportedly ended the relationship after 6 months

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 26-year-old man allegedly shot his girlfriend and then died by suicide in a rented house in Burari on Thursday, after she reportedly called him earlier in the day to end their six-month relationship because he was unemployed, an officer said.

Police said they received a PCR call about two people lying dead in a flat, rushed to the spot, and launched an investigation.

They said the woman's younger sister, Nishangini, a teacher at a school, discovered the bodies around 3:30 pm when she returned home from work in north Delhi. After finding the door locked from the inside, she alerted the landlord. Together, they forced the door open, police said, adding that they found both occupants lying inside with gunshot injuries and immediately informed police.

Police said they are ascertaining the exact sequence of events and the circumstances leading to the deaths.

"It has emerged that Shivangini had reportedly called Nikhil earlier in the day to end the relationship, allegedly due to his unemployment. Rest teams are verifying the details," the officer said.

Investigators said the woman, identified as Shivangini (26), originally from Raebareli in Uttar Pradesh and employed with NIC in Delhi, lived in the rented accommodation with her sister. The man, Nikhil (26), originally from Pinana village in Sonipat in Haryana, was unemployed and had worked with the Delhi Development Authority on a contractual basis and used to visit her house on and off, police said.

"Preliminary investigation suggests the two had been in a relationship for the past few months. We are waiting for the crime and forensic teams for further details," a senior police officer said.

"We received information on Thursday afternoon about the bodies of a man and a woman inside a rented house in Burari. A police team reached the spot and found that both had sustained gunshot injuries and were dead," Deputy Commissioner of Police (North) Raja Banthia said.

The investigation indicated that the man first allegedly shot the woman and then turned the weapon on himself. The two had been in a relationship for the past six to eight months.

"Initially, we learned that the relationship was not progressing as the man expected, which appears to have caused him distress," the DCP said.

However, police said the exact motive is yet to be established and all aspects are being examined.

Police said before the incident, the man sent text messages to his family members explaining the reasons for his distress and the personal issues he had been facing.

Police have recovered the messages and are examining them as part of the investigation.

Police visited the scene, conducted a forensic examination, and initiated further legal proceedings. The DCP said family members' statements are being recorded and the investigation is underway.

Deceased Nikhil's sister informed police that he had shared a message along with his live location in the family social media messaging group shortly before the incident. Police said teams recovered one pistol and two empty cartridges from the crime scene.

CLOSER LOOK

- They said the woman's younger sister, Nishangini, a teacher at a school, discovered the bodies around 3:30 pm when she returned home from work
- After finding the door locked from the inside, she alerted the landlord. Together, they forced the door open, police said
- They found both occupants lying inside with gunshot injuries and immediately informed the cops

DELHI SIR

4 held; BLO alleges obstruction of duty

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A teacher deployed as a booth-level officer (BLO) for the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise, allegedly faced abuse and obstruction while performing official duty in central Delhi's Chandni Mahal area, with police arresting four persons in this connection, an official said on Thursday.

The incident allegedly took place July 5 at Fatak Telian in Chandni Mahal area when the complainant, a Post Graduate Teacher (Special Education), was carrying out SIR-related work, a senior police officer said.

According to the complaint, one of the accused allegedly placed the BLO register on the teacher's lap and signed it despite her objection. She further alleged that several persons present at the spot abused her, refused to accept SIR forms and behaved in a manner that humiliated her and obstructed her from discharging official duties. Police said the matter came to their notice on Wednesday after the complainant approached the additional district magistrate (ADM), Old Delhi, who informed police authorities.

The complainant told police that the delay in reporting the incident was due to consultations with her senior officers regarding the appropriate course of action, the officer said.

Following verification of the complaint and examination of available material, an FIR was registered at Chandni Mahal police station under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

All four accused named in the complaint have been arrested, police said.

The accused have been identified as Mohammad Sabreen (44), Ateeq ur Rehman (58), Mohammad Asif (50) and Mohammad Aftab (44), all residents of Turkman Gate area.

46 arrested, 19 illegal pistols recovered in anti-crime op

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A district-wide crackdown against illegal arms, organised crime and street criminals in Delhi's Rohini has led to the arrest of 46 people and the recovery of 19 country-made pistols, 26 live cartridges and nine knives over the past two days, police said on Thursday.

Officials said so far this year, police in Rohini have recovered 155 illegal firearms and 287 live cartridges — the highest firearm recovery among all Delhi Police districts and units.

The two-day drive, 'Operation Shastra', was conducted across Rohini district on July 14 and 15 as part of a special enforcement campaign targeting illegal possession of arms, organised criminal networks and habitual offenders, they said.

Police said 24 cases under the Arms Act, five under the Excise Act, two under the NDPS Act and three under the Gambling Act were registered during the operation.

According to the police, 15 teams comprising 210 personnel conducted searches and raids at 106 locations across the district.

"During the drive, 101 parks were checked, black films were removed from 60 vehicles, around 400 historysheeters were verified, while eight active historysheeters and one proclaimed offender were arrested," Deputy Commissioner of Police (Rohini) Shashank Jaiswal said.

Besides the 46 arrests made during the operation, 23 people were also bound down under preventive provisions of law and a motorcycle was also recovered, police said.

Police arrested 46 people in cases under the Arms, Excise, NDPS and Gambling Acts, recovering 36 illegal firearms, illicit liquor, narcotics, house-breaking tools, a stolen motorcycle and a car.

Man arrested after encounter for murder of missing 3-year-old

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 37-year-old man was arrested after a brief exchange of fire with the police for allegedly murdering a three-year-old girl, who had gone missing from southwest Delhi's Kapashera area, an officer said on Thursday.

Chandan Kumar, a native of Ballia in Uttar Pradesh, allegedly confessed to the crime during preliminary interrogation, police said.

The three-year-old girl had gone missing on the evening of July 10, following which an FIR was registered at Kapashera police station and an investigation was launched.

"During the intervening night of July 14 and 15, police recovered the body of a child from the Kapashera drain near FIMT College. The body was identified as that of the missing girl," a senior police officer said.

A crime team inspected the spot and the postmortem report confirmed that the child had been murdered before her body was dumped in the drain, police said.

During the investigation, police analysed CCTV footage and identified Chandan Kumar, who lived in the same building as the victim's family, as a suspect after finding his movements suspicious.

Police said a raid was conducted at his hideout in Kapashera on Thursday.

When the team attempted to apprehend him, he allegedly opened fire. In retaliatory firing carried out in the exercise of the right of private defence and to effect his arrest, the accused sustained a bullet injury in his left leg and was overpowered.

A country-made pistol and one live cartridge were recovered from his possession.

The accused, a tailor by profession, is married, and his wife and five-year-old son live in his native village in Ballia, police said.

Police said efforts are underway to ascertain the motive behind the murder, while further investigation in the case is underway.

Man shot during road rage incident

NEW DELHI: A 24-year-old man was injured after a road rage incident between occupants of two cars escalated into firing near the Azadpur Mandi entry gate in northwest Delhi early on July 16, police said. The clash reportedly began over rash driving before turning into a physical altercation. During the scuffle, one of the accused's associates allegedly opened fire, injuring the victim. A traffic police constable on duty apprehended one suspect at the scene despite the firing. Police have registered an FIR and launched a search for the remaining accused. MPOST

School teacher killed in Rohini after fall from bike taxi into path of truck

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 46-year-old school teacher was killed after she allegedly fell from a bike taxi on her way to school and was run over by a truck on Kanjhawala Road in Rohini on Thursday, police said.

The victim, Priyanka, a resident of Rama Vihar, worked as a teacher in the MCD School in K-Block, Mangolpuri.

According to police, a PCR call regarding the road accident was received on Thursday morning, following which

a police team reached the spot and found a truck, loaded with bajri (sand), stationed on the road, while the woman was found crushed under its left rear wheel. Police said she succumbed to her injuries by the time they arrived, and they are investigating the exact sequence of events leading to her falling onto the road.

> **"Cops contacted the offending truck's owner and are working to trace and arrest the absconding driver"**

"The body was shifted to Sanjay Gandhi Memorial Hospital, where it was preserved in the mortuary after medico-legal formalities," the officer said. Police said the crime team inspected the scene, documented evidence and registered a case under sections 281 (rash or negligent driving) and 106 (causing death by negligence) of the BNS.

Police said they contacted the offending truck's owner and are working to trace and arrest the absconding driver.

Police said they are also examining the rider's role, if any, as part of the ongoing investigation.

Son on the run after shooting father dead over property dispute

DIPIKA KIROLA

GHAZIABAD: A dispute over alcohol consumption and a long-running family property row allegedly ended in murder after a 32-year-old man shot his father dead inside their home in Uttar Pradesh's Modinagar on Wednesday night, police said.

The accused, identified as Nikhil Kumar, is absconding after allegedly firing three rounds from a country-made pistol at his father, Hariom (55), a farmer from Budana village. Police have registered a murder case and formed five teams to trace him.

According to police, Hariom had finished dinner and was resting when Nikhil returned home at around 11 pm in an allegedly intoxicated state. His father objected to his drinking in front of family members, triggering an argument that soon shifted to an ongoing dispute over the family's assets, estimated to be worth more than Rs 150 crore.

In her complaint, Hariom's wife, Meenakshi (50), alleged that Nikhil opened fire during the heated exchange.

KEY POINTS

- 'My husband questioned Nikhil about coming home drunk. The argument soon turned into a dispute over the property. Nikhil then took out a pistol and shot him with the intention of killing him,' she told police
- She said she witnessed the attack and saw three shots being fired. Hariom sustained bullet injuries to his head and abdomen. He was rushed to a nearby pvt hospital

"My husband questioned Nikhil about coming home drunk. The argument soon turned into a dispute over the property. Nikhil then took out a pistol and shot him with the intention of killing him," she told police.

She said she witnessed the attack and saw three shots being fired. Hariom sustained bullet injuries to his head and abdomen. Family members and neighbours rushed him to a nearby private hospital, where doctors declared him brought dead. Police said the family owns around 75 bighas of agricultural land, including parcels near the Delhi-Meerut Expressway, besides three commercial shops in Modinagar.

Relatives told police that Hariom had proposed dividing the property into three shares but had delayed completing the legal transfer. Nikhil allegedly wanted the process expedited, while Hariom refused to transfer his share before his son's marriage, citing concerns over his drinking habits and the company he kept.

Hariom is survived by his wife and two sons — Nikhil and Nishu (27).

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Rural) Surendra Nath Tiwari said an FIR has been registered under Section 103 (murder) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita. He added that a preliminary inquiry revealed Nikhil had allegedly shot and injured his younger brother during another dispute in 2018, though no police complaint was filed at the time.

Police said efforts are underway to arrest the accused.

Undertrials extorted for 'safety, comfort' inside Capital's jails; 7 prison officials among 11 held

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Eleven persons, including an assistant superintendent, six jail warders, two advocates and two others, have been arrested for allegedly running a bribery racket inside Delhi prisons, an Anti-Corruption Branch (ACB) official said on Thursday.

The accused allegedly coerced families of undertrial prisoners to pay money for their safety, protection, preferential treatment and other unauthorised facilities inside jails, the official said.

According to an official statement, a case was registered on February 9 this year after ACB received a complaint from a man alleging that he was being forced to make regular payments for the "safety" and "comfort" of his father and brother, lodged as undertrials in Rohini Jail.

Based on the complaint, the ACB registered an FIR. Subsequently, a team was formed to investigate the allegations, which laid a trap to nab the accused.

> **Officials allegedly caught members of the syndicate accepting a bribe of Rs 1 lakh: Singh**

"During the operation, officials allegedly caught members of the syndicate accepting a bribe of Rs 1 lakh," joint commissioner of police and ACB chief Vikramjit Singh said in the statement.

The agency initially arrested six persons -- warders Dinesh Dabas, Pankaj Kumar and Ravi Kumar, all posted at Rohini Jail; Jogender, a head warder posted at Tihar Jail; advocate Manish of Faridabad and Ashish Rana, a private person from Delhi, the statement said.

During the investigation, the ACB uncovered a larger criminal conspiracy involving jail officials, inmates, advocates and private persons operating as an organised syndicate.

"Teams analysed bank accounts, financial transactions, digital evidence and mobile phone data, which revealed that illegal payments collected from families of prisoners were routed through multiple bank accounts before being withdrawn in cash and distributed among members of the network," the statement read. Based on the evidence, the ACB arrested five more accused -- Sunil Kumar, an assistant superintendent posted at Rohini Jail; Yogesh, a head warder at Rohini Jail; Jagbir, a warder at Rohini Jail; Harender Bansal, an advocate from Uttar Pradesh's Baghpat; and Viplove Khari, a private person from Delhi.

"With these arrests, the total number of accused held in the case has risen to 11. The arrested persons comprise one assistant superintendent, six jail warders, two advocates and two private persons," the statement read.

The ACB said further investigation is underway to identify other persons linked with the alleged network, trace the complete money trail and ascertain the full extent of the conspiracy.

FIRST CSAS ALLOCATION

Over 93K candidates allotted DU UG seats

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: More than 93,000 candidates were offered seats in the first round of undergraduate admissions at Delhi University, with an overall allocation rate of 86.1 per cent under the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS) for the 2026-27 academic session.

The university, on Thursday, announced the first allocation list for admissions to 221 undergraduate programmes across 67 colleges, covering 1,393 programme-college combinations.

According to the university, 93,033 candidates received seat allocations, including 42,019 male and 51,014 female candidates.

The first round of allocations was made from 2,08,043 candidates who had successfully completed Phase II of the admission process by submitting their programme and college preferences. Overall, 2,18,284 candidates completed registration

on the CSAS portal.

A total of 15,942,385 unique college-programme preferences were considered during the allocation process, the university said in a notification.

Among special category admissions, 1,243 single girl child candidates and 242 orphan candidates, including 109 male and 133 female applicants, received allocations.

The university said the fill rate for category-wise allocations stood at 99.9 per cent for the unreserved category, 96 per cent for OBC, 95.2 per cent for Scheduled Castes, 92.7 per cent for Economically Weaker Sections (EWS), 67.3 per cent for Scheduled Tribes and 23 per cent for Persons with Benchmark Disabilities (PwBD).

Candidates allotted seats in the first round must accept them by 11.59 pm on July 18. Colleges will verify and approve applications thereafter, following which candidates must complete fee payment.

The university advised candidates to exercise the "upgrade" option, if they wish to be considered for a higher preference in subsequent rounds. Those opting for an upgrade can reorder their higher preferences multiple times until the notified deadline for the round.

Admissions are being conducted on the basis of CUET-UG 2026 scores, subject to programme-specific eligibility criteria. The second allocation list is scheduled to be released on July 25.

The university said admissions to postgraduate programmes are also underway.

Following the completion of the third allocation round, a total of 10,240 candidates have been admitted to the two-year postgraduate programmes.

Traffic head constable killed in Singhu hit-and-run; 2 caught

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Police nabbed two men for a hit-and-run that killed a traffic head constable at the Singhu border in outer-north Delhi, officials said.

The incident took place at around 6 pm on Wednesday when Head Constable Amit, posted with the traffic unit at Singhu border, was regulating traffic, police said.

The speeding vehicle which rammed into the traffic policeman has been seized, they said.

Head Constable Amit, a resident of Sonipat in neighbouring Haryana, was immediately rushed by his colleagues to Narela's Satyawadi Raja Harish Chandra Hospital (SRHC), where doctors declared him brought dead on arrival, an officer said.

An FIR has been registered at Alipur Police Station under sections 281 (rash driving) and 106(1) (causing death by negligence) of the BNS. Kuldeep alias Karan and Neeraj have been apprehended in the case.

"It is with deep regret that Head Constable Amit, posted in the Traffic Unit at Singhu Border, has passed away in a hit-and-run incident. He is survived by his wife and two children," Delhi Police had said in a statement.

Under Child Safety Awareness Month campaign, Delhi Police is conducting discussions using digital comics to raise awareness MPOST

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Sewage push enters fast lane

Delhi govt to award contracts for all 29 decentralised STPs this month

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government is set to award contracts for all 29 decentralised sewage treatment plants (DSTPs) this month, marking a major step in its effort to increase sewage treatment capacity and reduce pollution flowing into the Yamuna.

PWD and Water Minister Parvesh Verma told ***Millennium Post*** that the tendering process has been completed and the remaining contracts will soon be finalised. "Contracts for 13 decentralised sewage treatment plants have already been awarded, and the tendering process for all 29 projects has been completed. We are planning to award the remaining 16 contracts this month," he said.

The minister said projects that have already been awarded have completed the design stage and are awaiting final approvals before construction begins. "The designs for the awarded projects are ready. Once approved, work orders will be issued and construction will begin. Consultants have been appointed to monitor and facilitate the entire implementation process," Verma said.

He added that the government expects the execution phase to be completed within 18 months.

The DSTP project is a key component of the Delhi government's strategy to clean the Yamuna by treating sewage closer to where it is generated. Unlike conventional sewage treatment plants, which require extensive sewer networks to transport wastewater over long distances, decentralised plants are designed to serve clusters of nearby unauthorised colonies and localities where sewer infrastructure is either inadequate or absent.

Officials said the addition of all 29 DSTPs will create a combined treatment capacity of around 170 million gallons per day (MGD), helping prevent untreated sewage from entering drains that ultimately discharge into the Yamuna.

The initiative also supports the broader target of increasing Delhi's overall sewage treatment capacity to 1,500 MGD by 2028, in line with directions issued by Union Home Minister Amit Shah during a high-level review meeting on Yamuna rejuvenation in July last year.

The project has witnessed several delays over the past decade, largely due to difficulties in securing land for construction. Initially proposed in 2015 by the previous Aam Aadmi Party government, the plan originally envisaged 48 decentralised treatment plants. The number was later revised to 40, then 34, and has now been rationalised to 29.

Government officials, however, maintain that the reduced number of plants will not affect coverage, as the capacity of each proposed DSTP has been enhanced to serve a larger population.

The Delhi government is targeting completion of all 29 decentralised sewage treatment plants by January 2028, while the associated sewer network is expected to be completed by June 2028, significantly strengthening the city's sewage management infrastructure and contributing to the long-pending goal of cleaning the Yamuna.

YAMUNA MISSION

- PWD and Water Minister Parvesh Verma told ***Millennium Post*** that the tendering process has been completed and the remaining contracts will soon be finalised
- 'Contracts for 13 decentralised sewage treatment plants have already been awarded, and the tendering process for all 29 projects has been completed. We are planning to award the remaining 16 contracts this month'

REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

RATH YATRA

People take part in a procession of Lord Jagannath, Lord Balabadhra and Goddess Subadhra during the 59th annual Rath Yatra of Thyagraj Jagannath Temple, at Tyagraj Nagar, in New Delhi, on Thursday PTI

City marks Rath Yatra

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: Delhi Lieutenant Governor Sardar T.S. Sandhu on Thursday inaugurated the 48th Sree Jagannath Rath Yatra at the Lord Jagannath Mandir on Hauz Khas Village Road, New Delhi, in the presence of saints, Dharma Gurus and devotees of Lord Jagannath.

Calling it a privilege to participate in the annual procession, he congratulated the organisers for successfully conducting the 48th edition of the Yatra and said their sustained devotion and dedication had helped the tradition flourish in the heart of the national capital. As part of the ceremony, the Lieutenant Governor performed the sacred ritual of Chhera Pahanra, ceremonially sweeping the chariots of the deities with a broom before the procession commenced. He said the centuries old tradition symbolises that no one, regardless of position or status, is above service to the divine. According to him, the ritual conveys a timeless message of humility and selfless service, emphasising that true devotion lies in serving rather than in power or authority.

Describing the Jagannath Rath Yatra as one of India's most ancient and revered festivals, the Lieutenant Governor said it stands as a living symbol of the country's civilisational continuity and spiritual heritage. He noted that the festival has endured for centuries, drawing devotees from across the country and beyond while continuing to uphold the values of devotion, humility and selfless service. He also highlighted the unique significance of the festival, saying Lord Jagannath comes out of the temple once every year to grant darshan and blessings to all devotees, irrespective of their background or social standing. He said this tradition reflects a deeply egalitarian spirit, reinforcing the belief that divine grace is available equally to everyone.

The Lieutenant Governor observed that festivals such as the Rath Yatra strengthen the city's social and cultural fabric by promoting reflection, community bonding and collective devotion. Appreciating the efforts of devotees and volunteers in ensuring the smooth conduct of the celebration, he concluded by praying for the health, peace and prosperity of the people of Delhi and expressed hope that the spirit of devotion and service would continue to inspire the city.

Rain takes a break, humidity doesn't

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi continued to experience sultry weather on Thursday, with residents waking up to hot and humid conditions despite the ongoing monsoon season. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) has forecast a partly cloudy sky and strong surface winds of 20-30 kmph during the day, while indicating that light rainfall and thunderstorms are likely to return from Friday.

The maximum temperature is expected to settle between 37 degrees Celsius and 39 degrees Celsius, making for another uncomfortable day across the national capital. The minimum temperature was recorded at 30.2 degrees Celsius, remaining above normal and contributing to high humidity levels.

According to the IMD, isolated parts of Delhi are likely to witness hot and humid conditions through the day as monsoon activity over the region remains weak. However, weather conditions are expected to improve over the next 24 to 48 hours, with the possibility of thunderstorms accompanied by light rain from Friday onwards.

Air quality in the city remained in the "moderate" category on Thursday morning. Data from the CPCB showed the city's average AQI at 165 at 9 am. However, pollution levels varied significantly across different locations. Anand Vihar recorded an AQI of 350, placing it in the "very poor" category, while several other monitoring stations continued to report air quality in the moderate range.

The IMD said Delhi is among several north Indian regions expected to witness hot and humid weather, even as many other parts of the country receive widespread monsoon rainfall. While eastern, northeastern and central states are likely to experience heavy to extremely heavy rain, the national capital is expected to remain largely dry for another day before rainfall activity picks up.

Delhi okays ₹400-cr start-up policy

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a major push to innovation and entrepreneurship, the Delhi Cabinet on Thursday approved the Delhi Start-up and Incubation Policy, under which the government will invest more than Rs 400 crore over the next five years to build a robust start-up ecosystem across higher educational and technical institutions. The policy aims to provide financial assistance, incubation support and mentorship to aspiring entrepreneurs, with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta asserting that the initiative will help transform Delhi's youth into "job creators, not job seekers."

Announcing the decision, Gupta said the policy is designed to make Delhi one of the country's leading hubs for innovation and entrepreneurship. "The initiative is not just about helping people launch start-ups, but about transforming Delhi's youth from job seekers into job creators. We want to ensure that students, researchers, teachers, alumni and aspiring entrepreneurs with promising ideas never face a shortage of resources, mentorship or financial assistance to take those ideas forward," she said. The policy will be implemented across 11 state universities, 13 government-funded colleges, polytechnic institutes and Industrial Training Institutes (ITIs). Students from government schools will also be able to avail the policy's benefits through these institutions, and successful students will receive financial assistance. Eligible institutions will receive one-time financial assistance to establish incubation centres, along with annual operational support for mentoring, networking and innovation activities. Start-ups incubated under the scheme will receive milestone-based financial support covering prototype development, proof of concept, product development, market validation and commercialisation. The incubation centres will also provide entrepreneurs with modern infrastructure, expert mentoring, business advisory services, intellectual property support, access to laboratories and testing facilities, besides facilitating connections with investors and industry. As part of the policy, the government will also organise an Annual Delhi Start-up Youth Festival, bringing together innovators, educational institutions, start-ups, investors, industry representatives and policymakers. "The festival will serve as a platform to showcase new ideas, foster new partnerships and encourage young entrepreneurs to take their ventures forward," the Chief Minister said. Implementation of the policy will be overseen by the State Incubation Policy Monitoring Committee, comprising representatives from the government, educational institutions, industry and the start-up ecosystem to ensure transparent governance and performance-based financial support.

> "Youth will become job creators, not job seekers
> — CM GUPTA

City Briefs

ASSEMBLY SPEAKER PARTICIPATES IN RATH YATRA IN ROHINI

NEW DELHI: Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta on Thursday participated in the Gundicha & Bahuda Rath Yatra 2026 organised by the Oriya Samaj at Jagannath Mandir in Sector 11, Rohini. Calling the Rath Yatra a symbol of India's civilisational heritage, Gupta said, "The Rath Yatra of Lord Jagannath is a living symbol of India's civilisational continuity, embodying the timeless values of faith, inclusiveness, service and collective harmony." He said the festival strengthens national unity while promoting equality, compassion and public participation. Gupta also appreciated the Oriya Samaj for preserving and promoting the cultural traditions associated with Lord Jagannath.

DDA REVENUE JUMPS 120%

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) generated a revenue of Rs 1,020 crores through housing sales in the first quarter of the current financial year, officials said on Thursday. The DDA revenue marked a steep rise from the previous financial year, when the sales were recorded at Rs 462 crore, they said. "Driven by robust demand for housing across all categories, DDA sold 1,284 flats during the quarter while generating Rs 1,020 crores in revenue. This is clearly indicative of growing public confidence in its housing schemes," the DDA said. The rise in revenue is the result of continuous focus on re-imagining the sub-cities developed by the DDA, on part of LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu, which has resulted in the Authority recording strong housing sales in the first quarter of the Financial Year 2026-27. "Narela has emerged as the biggest contributor to this success, with 1,153 flats sold during the quarter, accounting for nearly 90 per cent of the total sales, which shows the increasing attractiveness of Narela as a preferred residential destination," the DDA said in a statement.

AAP SUSPENDS THREE COUNCILLORS FOR CROSS-VOTING IN MCD ELECTION

NEW DELHI: Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) on Thursday suspended three MCD councillors with immediate effect, a day after the party alleged cross-voting during the ward committee elections. The action was announced by Delhi AAP president Saurabh Bharadwaj on X. Among those suspended are Nirmala Devi (Sharma) in West Zone, Krishna Devi Raghav in West Zone and Sultana Abad from City SP zone. The party said the suspended councillors had cross-voted in the municipal corporation's elections. It also alleged that a chairman in the West Zone was elected through cross-voting. "In the West Zone, the chairman was elected through cross-voting and in the City SP Zone, councillors who cross-voted against the party have been suspended with immediate effect," Ankush Narang, AAP leader of opposition in the MCD said in a statement on X. The party said its message was clear that a "betrayal of the mandate and the party will not be tolerated". Asserting that strict action against those involved in anti-party activities would continue, it said, "Elections are not fought by an individual, but by the entire party."

Delhi speeds up revamp of 7,400 EWS flats at Bhalswa

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has accelerated the repair and expansion of over 7,400 Economically Weaker Section (EWS) flats at Bhalswa as part of its plan to provide upgraded housing to slum residents, Urban Development Minister Ashish Sood said on Thursday after inspecting the project site.

Sood visited the housing complex to review the ongoing repair and expansion work aimed at bringing the pre-built flats in line with the standards of the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (PMAY). The minister had earlier inspected the site in February and directed officials to increase the carpet area of the flats to provide beneficiaries with more dignified living conditions.

Addressing officials during the inspection, Sood said the government is committed to fulfilling "Modi Ki Guarantee" by ensuring that eligible families receive improved housing. "Under the Prime Minister's guidance, the size limits for these homes have been increased. In an effort to ensure the best utilisation of taxpayers' money, the government is extending the existing structures by at least four to five square metres," he said.

The minister reviewed the quality of construction, including the size of rooms and new flooring, to ensure the homes are spacious and suitable for families.

Referring to delays in the project, Sood blamed the previous government for procedural hurdles and inaction. "The era of shifting blame is over, and the current administration will execute the allotments systematically in phases," he said.

He said a final joint inspection of the project will be carried out with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta before the flats are allotted. "Following the Chief Minister's feedback, final guidance will be taken from the Union Home Minister and senior leaders," he added.

MIN INSPECTS RESTORED RAINWATER HARVESTING SYSTEM...

Govt ramps up rainwater harvesting drive; over 750 projects completed

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has intensified its rainwater harvesting campaign, with more than 750 rainwater harvesting (RWH) projects either completed or under execution across government institutions, as it seeks to improve groundwater recharge and strengthen the Capital's long-term water security.

PWD and Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh on Thursday inspected the restored rainwater harvesting system at Thyagraj Stadium and reviewed the progress of the city-wide programme launched in line with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's "Catch the Rain – Where it Falls, When it Falls" campaign.

Addressing the media, Singh said conserving rainwater has become critical as groundwater levels continue to decline across the city. "Prime Minister Narendra Modi has given the nation the mantra of 'Catch the Rain'. Rainwater harvesting allows rainwater to recharge the groundwater table, ensuring water availability throughout the year. Today, borewells are drying up because groundwater is being extracted faster than it is replenished. The Delhi Government has adopted the Prime Minister's vision as a mission and is working to make every government institution a model of water conservation," he said.

The minister said the government has undertaken the restoration of 1,000 existing rainwater harvesting systems and the construction of 500 new RWH structures in government offices, schools, hospitals, stadiums and other public institutions. According to the government, around 400 existing systems have already been restored, while work is underway on over 400 more, taking the total number of completed and ongoing restoration works to over 800. Of the target to build 500 new structures, nearly 100 have been completed and more than 250 are under construction. Separately, the Delhi Jal Board has taken up restoration of 611 existing RWH systems, completing work on 330, while 120 are under various stages of execution.

Singh said officials from the Delhi Jal Board and PWD are jointly inspecting government premises to ensure all existing systems are made functional and new ones are installed wherever required. He added that the government is also examining making rainwater harvesting mandatory for new borewell permissions. "Every restored rainwater harvesting system and every new structure strengthens Delhi's water security. This is not just an infrastructure project, it is an investment in the future of our city and the generations to come," he said.

11.21L CANDIDATES QUALIFY

Punjab, Haryana share NEET top honours

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Punjab's Aryan Gupta and Haryana's Panshul Bansal topped the NEET-UG for medical admissions as 11.21 lakh candidates qualified the entrance exam this year, the National Testing Agency announced on Thursday.

Gupta and Bansal scored 715 each out of 720. Their score was 29 marks higher than the 686 secured by the 2025 topper, when an unusually tough paper ensured that not a single candidate crossed 700.

While 19 candidates scored 700, 138 obtained 690 marks. More than 93 per cent of the 138 candidates scoring above 690 were appearing for NEET-UG for the first time.

A total of 1,492 candidates scored 650 or above, while 10,160 scored 600 or more, according to the National Testing Agency (NTA). More than 58 per cent of the qualifying candidates are women.

The crucial exam conducted on May 9 was cancelled by the NTA on May 12 amid allegations of paper leak. The CBI is investigating the matter.

The exam was re-conducted on June 21.

HIGHLIGHTS

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Last year, the results were announced on June 25. Allaying concerns about whether the re-exam will delay the admission schedule, the NTA clarified that the results have been declared on time so that the medical admission and counselling calendar for the candidates remains on track.

"The results were declared within time through re-engineering of the process, with stages designed to run in parallel rather than in sequence, and with the de-linking of the OMR sheet challenge from answer key release. Each stage was completed in full and made available for candidate view," the NTA said.

In 2024, 17 candidates initially secured perfect scores of 720 amid a major controversy over grace marks. After the Supreme Court-ordered revision of one disputed question, the number of candidates retaining the top score was reduced.

The number of qualifiers declined from 12.36 lakh in 2025 to 11.21 lakh this year, but the numbers appearing also fell from 22.09 lakh to close to 20 lakh. The overall qualification rate, therefore, remained broadly stable at around 56 per cent, despite the cancellation and re-test.

COVID: 12 infections, four deaths in Andhra between Jun 26–Jul 16

AMARAVATI: Andhra Pradesh Health Commissioner G Veerapandian on Thursday said 12 people were infected with Covid-19 virus across the state between June 26 and July 16, out of whom four with comorbidities succumbed to the virus.

He noted that the deceased persons suffered from severe comorbidities such as hypertension, diabetes, renal issues and others forms of illnesses.

"Sporadic Covid-19 cases were reported in the state. Between June 26 and July 16, 12 people contracted Covid-19 virus and four out of them succumbed," Veerapandian said in an official press release.

Out of the four deaths, he said three casualties were from Kadapa district and one from Kakinada.

According to the commissioner, Andhra Pradesh's first Covid-19 infection in 2026 was logged in Kadapa district on June 26 and between July 1 and 16, 11 more infections were reported.

The Health Department said two persons contracted the disease after mingling closely with infected people. AGENCIES

From Page 1

Monsoon Session

of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026 is listed for introduction, consideration and passing.

The Bill seeks to amend the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971 and sources said that the government wants to make any insult or obstruction to the singing of the National Song Vande Mataram a punishable offence through this.

Another Bill listed for introduction, consideration and passing is the Registration of Births and Deaths (Amendment) Bill, 2026. The Bill seeks to further amend section 13(3) of the Registration of Births and Deaths Act, 1969 (as amended in 2023) "in order to make provisions of delayed registration more stringent".

The pending Bills and those under review also include the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026. The FCRA Bill was introduced in the Lok Sabha on March 25. It will be up for consideration and passage in the upcoming parliament session.

The amendments seek to enhance transparency in dealing with funds coming to India.

The Viksit Bharat Education Establishment Bill, 2025, which was introduced in December 2025, was referred to a joint committee of both the Houses. Further consideration will take place following the submission of the committee's report in the Monsoon session, sources said.

The Income Tax (Amendment) Bill, 2026 will replace an earlier ordinance. This Bill is being introduced to strengthen India's sovereign debt market, attract global capital flows and enhance market liquidity amid global geopolitical instability, fluctuations in crude oil prices and supply chain disruptions.

The second ordinance which will be replaced is the Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Bill, 2026, which seeks to raise the sanctioned strength of Supreme Court judges from 33 to 37 (excluding the Chief Justice of India) to facilitate speedy disposal of pending cases.

Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises Development (Amendment) Bill, 2026: This Bill aims to promote 'ease of doing business' and trust-based regulations in the MSME sector, strengthening the mechanism for addressing delayed payments and granting greater powers to the states. WITH AGENCY INPUTS

LS admits

the Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Ordinance, 2026."

Under parliamentary procedure, such a resolution is moved when the government brings a bill to replace an ordinance. Former Union law secretary P K Malhotra said an ordinance remains valid for six months but must be approved by Parliament within six weeks, or 42 days, after a session begins, failing which it lapses.

The Union Cabinet had cleared the proposal in May before the ordinance was issued. Following the increase in sanctioned strength, five judges were appointed to the apex court. The bill requires only a simple majority and does not need a constitutional amendment.

The Supreme Court's strength was last increased in 2019 from 30 to 33 judges, excluding the CJI. The sanctioned strength is revised after the CJI recommends it to the Union law minister, following which the proposal is processed through the government before Cabinet approval. MPOST

Delhi HC orders

private doctors also visited him.

The court, however, insisted that government doctors should regularly assess his condition and intervene whenever necessary. "Life is precious," the bench remarked, while directing authorities to act on the basis of medical opinion.

The PIL, filed by Rakesh Kumar Saini, sought directions to authorities to intervene in Wangchuk's case, discuss the issue with him and ensure timely medical care. It also sought a direction for force-feeding the activist. The petition argued that while peaceful protest was a democratic and fundamental right, the state should not allow a citizen to voluntarily die of hunger due to inaction.

Wangchuk has been fasting since June 28 after joining the CJP protest at Delhi's Jantar Mantar over alleged irregularities in the NEET examination and the demand for Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation. The protest itself has continued for more than 25 days.

Doctors attending to Wangchuk said his condition had become increasingly serious. According to the latest medical bulletin issued by Dr Satish Lamba, the activist has lost more than nine kilograms since beginning his fast and now weighs 56.9 kg.

Lamba said Wangchuk had entered a critical stage of prolonged fasting. He explained that after the body's glucose reserves are exhausted, it starts consuming fat, followed by muscle tissue. Wangchuk's ketone level, which had reached 3-plus, had reduced to 2-plus after improved hydration, but his uric acid remained high, indicating muscle breakdown.

"The next stage can be alarming. Organs can be impacted. We are keeping him under 24x7 vigilance and hope it does not reach that stage. I urge the government to intervene as soon as possible because he is a precious gem and we do not want to lose him," Lamba said.

Despite the medical warning, Wangchuk remained firm in continuing the fast. In a video message released late Wednesday, he said medical tests had not indicated immediate danger and maintained that he could continue for many more days.

"My condition is not such that I will die in two-four days. Many medical tests have been conducted and the results are quite normal for an 18-day fast. An ECG was also done and it is not bad. I can continue for many more days. Yes, there is weakness and my muscles are getting weak, but my heart and core are still fine," he said.

Calling the movement "a real lesson in political science and democracy", Wangchuk appealed to people to register for the Parliament march through the campaign website or missed-call initiative. The CJP said around 1.5 lakh people had confirmed participation in the July 20 march.

The agitation also includes students affiliated with the All India Students' Association (AISA), some of whom are on indefinite hunger strike. AISA said the health of Neha, Manish and Aameen had reached severe stages. It claimed Aameen faced the risk of hypovolemic shock due to dehydration, Neha's blood sugar had fallen to around 49 mg/dl, and Manish had lost more than 10 per cent of his body weight.

Support for Wangchuk continued to grow across political parties and civil society. AAP national convenor Arvind Kejriwal visited Jantar Mantar along with party leaders, expressing solidarity with the protesters. "Every year, exam papers get leaked and youth pay the price. I appeal to the government to listen to the students and Wangchuk," he said, while also demanding Pradhan's resignation.

Samajwadi Party MP Dimple Yadav, accompanied by party leaders, and farmer leader Rakesh Tikait also met Wangchuk. Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah criticised the Centre for not engaging with him.

The Congress appealed to Wangchuk to end his hunger strike, saying "his concerns are our concerns" while continuing to seek the education minister's resignation. Congress general secretary K C Venugopal said the party shared Wangchuk's anguish over the "collapse of the examination system".

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee criticised the Centre for not initiating talks with the activist. She said it was difficult to understand why no government representative had met Wangchuk despite his prolonged fast and worsening health.

The Supreme Court Bar Association also appealed to Wangchuk to end his fast, saying the country needed him "alive, active and engaged" rather than risking his health. SCBA president Vikas Singh personally handed over the appeal during a visit to Jantar Mantar.

Music composer Vishal Dadlani, actors Sonakshi Sinha, Sayaji Shinde, Atul Kulkarni, comedian Vir Das, author Shobhaa De, Maharashtra Navnirman Sena chief Raj Thackeray, former Congress MP Priya Dutt, and economists Jean Dreze and Reetika Khera were among those who either visited the protest site or publicly expressed concern over Wangchuk's health while urging the government to engage with him.

Rath Yatra

died after being admitted. "The exact cause of death is being ascertained by the concerned authorities," the CMO said.

In a separate incident, another male devotee aged above 35 years suffered a cardiac arrest and died despite immediate medical treatment. The government said the two deaths were unrelated.

The CMO said many other devotees who experienced rain-related illness received treatment at hospitals and were later discharged. It added that the unprecedented gathering and continuous rainfall led to cases of fatigue, dehydration, suffocation and other minor health problems during the day.

The state government maintained that the festival remained "peaceful, orderly and well managed" and said there was no stampede or systemic failure in crowd management. It said coordinated efforts by the administration, security agencies, servitors and volunteers ensured the smooth movement of devotees, while essential services continued to function normally.

The CMO estimated that eight to nine lakh devotees from across India and abroad took part in the annual Rath Yatra.

Earlier, Inspector General of Fire Services Umashankar Dash said there was a heavy rush on the Grand Road, or Bada Danda, where the chariots travel towards the Shree Gundicha Temple. "We have rescued almost 100 people who felt suffocated in the crowd. We have taken them to temporary hospitals and ambulances. That has given relief to devotees," he told reporters.

BJD president and Leader of the Opposition Naveen Patnaik expressed grief over the deaths and wished a speedy recovery to the more than 100 injured devotees. He urged party workers to assist those in need and called on the government to ensure better crowd management and safety.

State Congress president Bhakta Charan Das blamed the administration for the deaths and urged steps to prevent such incidents in future.

Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi thanked servitors and the lakhs of devotees for their patience and cooperation. He said the government remained committed to improving infrastructure, public services and administrative preparedness so that devotees could participate in the festival safely and with dignity.

Last year, three people were killed and several others were injured in a stampede near the Gundicha Temple during the Rath Yatra.

SC suggests

It would unnecessarily increase the stress level of students. If you want to introduce a new language, then please do it at Class 5 or Class 6 level but not at Class 9 level," Justice Nagarathna told the Centre's counsel, asking her to convey the court's views to the government. She added that students begin facing academic pressure from Class 8 and that Class 9 is already demanding.

The bench clarified that it was not directly hearing a challenge to the CBSE's new language policy. That issue is being examined separately by another Supreme Court bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant, which recently declined to stay the notification.

Tamil Nadu has opposed the setting up of JNVs, citing concerns over the three-language policy followed by the schools. During the hearing, the state's counsel said its objection was linked to the three-language framework.

Justice Nagarathna observed that the policy does not make Hindi compulsory. "The State language has to be taught, English has to be taught and any third language. It doesn't say Hindi," she said. When advocate G Priyadarshini, appearing for respondent NGO Kumari Maha Sabha, submitted that the National Education Policy states that no language should be imposed on any state, the judge asked the Tamil Nadu government, "You don't want Hindi, but if it's Sanskrit, what is the issue?"

The state's counsel replied that the third language becomes compulsory only from Class 9. Reacting to this, Justice Nagarathna said, "No, that's very bad. Class 9 is very stressful. Why don't you introduce it in Class 6th."

Recalling her school days, she said students had the option of learning Kannada, Hindi or Sanskrit from middle school, adding, "The earlier, the better."

The bench also urged the state not to reject Central schemes simply because they originate from the Union government. It noted that discussions between the Centre and the state on Navodaya schools were continuing and listed the matter for further hearing on August 11. The court also observed that a new government had assumed office in Tamil Nadu and its policy approach remained to be seen.

US strike near Iran cancer

in their hands and some were in wheelchairs. Everyone went outside."

Iran's Foreign Ministry strongly criticised the attack. Spokesman Esmaeil Baghaei called the strike near the children's cancer hospital a "barbaric war crime" in a post on X, saying it caused "severe suffering and anxiety" for young patients and forced the emergency evacuation of 211 people undergoing chemotherapy.

"This constitutes a cowardly war crime against the most innocent of human beings, children who are bravely fighting for their lives," Baghaei said. He also accused countries that speak about human rights while ignoring attacks on hospitals of losing "every shred of moral credibility".

The Ahvaz University of Medical Sciences said every patient had been transferred to other hospitals and that treatment was continuing without interruption.

Tasnim News Agency, which is affiliated with Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC), published an image of the hospital entrance showing an IRGC logo and the words "Ground Forces" on the sign.

There was no immediate response from the United States. Washington has conducted several rounds of strikes in Iran's southern regions in recent days, saying they were intended to reduce Iran's ability to threaten commercial shipping in the Strait of Hormuz. AGENCIES

Over 500 Rohingya

The UN bodies said heavy monsoon rain and flooding made the sea crossing especially dangerous. Around 1.2 million stateless Rohingya remain in overcrowded camps in Bangladesh, unable to return safely to Myanmar, where the military remains in power and many Rohingya still face severe restrictions.

Aid cuts, shrinking food rations and continued conflict in Rakhine have pushed more Rohingya to attempt the risky journey to Malaysia. More than 6,500 fled by boat in 2025, with nearly 900 reported dead or missing, making it the deadliest year on the route.agencies

Govt proposes

original equipment manufacturers (OEMs) a predictable regulatory roadmap, allowing them to gradually introduce more fuel-efficient models.

For the first time, the draft introduces Carbon Neutrality Factors (CNFs) that recognise the carbon-neutral benefits of ethanol, biofuels and Compressed Bio-Gas (CBG). It proposes an 8% CNF for the current level of ethanol blending, while reductions for CBG and other biofuels will depend on prevailing blending levels. These reductions will be applied to declared tailpipe CO_2 emissions before compliance is assessed.

Manufacturers will also be able to claim compliance benefits of up to 9 gCO_2/km for approved fuel-saving technologies, subject to a maximum benefit of 1 gCO_2/km for each technology. The proposal continues volume-based super credits for Battery Electric Vehicles, Range-Extended Electric Vehicles, Plug-in Hybrid Electric Vehicles, Strong Hybrid Electric Vehicles and Flex-Fuel Vehicles while calculating fleet-average fuel consumption, with higher incentives continuing for fully electric vehicles than strong hybrids.

The draft proposes a credit and debit system under which manufacturers exceeding their targets can earn compliance credits that may be carried forward within compliance blocks. Companies missing their targets may meet obligations through carry-forward provisions, voluntary pooling with other manufacturers or by purchasing compliance credits from the Bureau of Energy Efficiency. Credits will be valued at Rs 2,500 each initially, with the price increasing by Rs 500 every year. Unused credits will expire at the end of a compliance block.

Compliance will be assessed in two phases, comprising an initial three-year block followed by a two-year block. Manufacturers selling fewer than 1,000 passenger vehicles annually will remain exempt, while companies failing to meet the norms will face penalties under the Energy Conservation Act. During consultations, some automakers sought a separate category for small cars, while others argued that revised emission calculations already provide sufficient relief for lighter vehicles. Industry discussions have largely supported the proposed framework, with SIAM president Shailesh Chandra earlier describing it as "balanced" and aligned with the goal of improving fuel efficiency while reducing emissions.

ISRO exit rules

The directive effectively rolls back an administrative change introduced in November 2020, which had allowed ISRO centre directors to approve resignations and voluntary retirement applications for scientists up to the Scientist/Engineer-SG level.

The latest order comes amid reports that between 100 and 120 scientists have resigned from ISRO in recent months, although the Department of Space has not officially confirmed the figure. According to reports citing ISRO sources, nearly 80 scientists have left the URSC, while around 20 departures have been reported from the VSSC. Officials also indicated that additional resignation requests are still under consideration, suggesting the total number could rise further.

Among those reported to have left are senior scientists linked to some of India's most significant space programmes. They include LVM3 Project Director Victor Joseph, the SpaDeX Project Director from URSC, and Aditya Rallapalli, a Chandrayaan-3 scientist who led the simulation team that generated nearly 25 terabytes of mission data through more than one lakh simulations to validate the spacecraft's lunar landing sequence.

ISRO Chairman V Narayanan acknowledged the resignations but said the organisation was prepared to manage the transition.

"Yes, a lot of people go, but that's part of every organisation. The move isn't only to retain, but also to ensure that important projects don't suffer all of a sudden. If someone is still going, someone else will take responsibility. We're taking care of it," he said.

Although the reported departures account for only a small portion of ISRO's workforce of more than 14,600 employees, officials are understood to be concerned about the loss of experienced personnel attached to flagship programmes such as Gaganyaan, Chandrayaan and SpaDeX. Replacing specialised expertise built over years of mission work is seen as a greater challenge than filling vacant posts.

Official data show around 700 employees resigned from ISRO between 2012 and 2024. The organisation is also recruiting for more than 1,050 scientific, technical and administrative posts and has undertaken cadre restructuring to regularise hundreds of project positions.

Responding to questions on the memorandum, Union Minister of State for Science and Technology Jitendra Singh said the decision was purely administrative.

"No, that is because... that is for administrative reasons so that the decision can be taken at a much mature level," Singh told reporters. He added that ISRO has a large workforce where "many have gone, many have come" and said there was "no controversy" surrounding the decision.

Referring to Gaganyaan, Singh said ISRO's work continues through institutional continuity. Even after retirement, former scientists continue contributing to important projects, ensuring that India's human spaceflight mission and other future programmes remain on course.

World Cup final

"We worked so hard to be here. The lads have given every bit of blood, sweat and tears. To fall short like we did is just gutting."

The defending champions will take on European champion Spain in the final on Sunday in East Rutherford, New Jersey. The best that South America has to offer against the best of Europe.

The loss for England will hurt a new generation of fans in a similar way to Diego Maradona's infamous handball goal in the 1986 World Cup quarterfinals and the penalty shootout loss in 1998 when David Beckham was sent off for kicking Diego Simeone.

The difference is there can be no sense of injustice this time, even if England had victory in its sights after Anthony Gordon scored the opening goal in the 55th minute.

The English were hanging on as the game wore on. England goalkeeper Jordon Pickford made vital saves while Mac Allister sent a header off the post as wave after wave of Argentina attacks came.

Messi had largely been kept quiet. But when he's on the field, anything seems possible.

He fed the ball to Fernandez to sweep in the equalizer from outside the box in the 85th minute. And two minutes into stoppage time, Messi sent in a cross for Martinez to head in the winner.

It almost felt inevitable. Especially given the amount of times Argentina has simply refused to give in at this year's World Cup. From Cape Verde to Egypt, Messi and Co. always seem to find a way.

"It is a show of the collectiveness, the brotherhood that we are in, the fight to the very end that we've got," Argentina coach Lionel Scaloni said. "We were ready to go home, sad, knowing that we had left everything on the pitch, but after they scored we really proved ourselves."

England, in contrast, came up short in the World Cup semifinals for the third time after losses to Germany in 1990 and Croatia in 2018. And it's another occasion in recent years when England's players have squandered a winning position in the later stages of a major tournament.

They led 1-0 against Croatia in the semifinals eight years ago and lost 2-1. They were up 1-0 against Italy in the European Championship final in 2021 and lost on penalties.

On Wednesday, England coach Thomas Tuchel's substitutions seemed to be more intent on holding on, rather than killing the game off with another goal.

"Argentina played with more risk, played with more rhythm, played with the feeling maybe that they have nothing to lose anymore, which freed them up and held us back because we played suddenly with a feeling that we have a lot to lose," Tuchel said.

Argentina is now one step away from history. Messi, now 39 and likely playing at his last World Cup, is one win away from further strengthening his case to be considered the greatest soccer player of all time.

"We're going to try to win, we're going to leave everything out there," Scaloni said. "It's very difficult to get people to understand what these players are showing. It's incredible. We are unique, truly, and it's not arrogance, it's from the heart. We are unique."

EDITORIAL

LEGISLATIVE PRUDENCE

As Parliament prepares for the Monsoon Session, the government's revised legislative agenda offers an important glimpse into its current governance priorities. The inclusion of five new Bills—ranging from national honour and civil registration to taxation, judicial capacity and MSME reforms—suggests an emphasis on administrative efficiency, institutional strengthening and symbolic nationhood. Equally significant, however, is what has been left off the agenda. The absence of two politically consequential constitutional amendment Bills, dealing with automatic disqualification from public office after imprisonment and the delimitation linked to women's reservation, reflects the government's recognition that legislative timing is often as important as legislative intent. In a session likely to witness intense political contestation, prioritising measures that promise broader consensus over those that risk prolonged confrontation appears to be a calculated parliamentary strategy.

Among the proposed measures, the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026, is certain to attract the greatest public attention. Extending legal protection to Vande Mataram by criminalising its intentional insult or disruption raises questions that go beyond patriotism. Few would dispute the importance of respecting national symbols that embody India's freedom struggle and collective identity. Yet any expansion of criminal law must satisfy the constitutional tests of necessity, proportionality and precision. The law must distinguish clearly between deliberate acts intended to insult the nation and legitimate expressions of dissent, artistic interpretation or inadvertent conduct. National honour is undoubtedly worthy of protection, but it is strengthened most effectively when laws are narrowly framed and fairly enforced rather than broadly worded in ways that invite subjective interpretation.

The Registration of Births and Deaths (Amendment) Bill addresses a far less visible but equally significant challenge. Reliable civil registration forms the backbone of public administration, influencing welfare delivery, health planning, demographic data and legal identity. India has made considerable progress in improving registration rates, yet delayed reporting continues to create administrative complications, particularly in rural and vulnerable communities. Stricter provisions may improve data integrity, but enforcement must be accompanied by greater accessibility, digital infrastructure and public awareness. Citizens should find compliance easier, not merely face harsher consequences for delays that often arise from logistical barriers rather than deliberate neglect. Administrative reform succeeds when it combines accountability with convenience.

The remaining legislative proposals point towards practical governance concerns. Amendments relating to income tax, judicial strength and MSME development address sectors central to India's economic trajectory. Expanding the sanctioned strength of the Supreme Court could help reduce mounting case backlogs and improve judicial efficiency, while reforms affecting micro, small and medium enterprises acknowledge the sector's pivotal role in employment generation and economic resilience. At the same time, Parliament will continue deliberations on previously introduced legislation, including amendments to the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) framework and the proposed Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhisthan Bill. Together, these measures indicate an effort to sustain legislative momentum across governance, economic policy and institutional reform without overloading the session with highly divisive constitutional questions.

Ultimately, the success of the Monsoon Session will depend less on the number of Bills introduced than on the quality of parliamentary scrutiny they receive. Laws that touch constitutional values, civil liberties or national identity deserve careful debate rather than hurried passage. Equally, reforms affecting taxation, justice delivery, education and business require bipartisan engagement if they are to produce lasting institutional improvements. By setting aside contentious constitutional amendments for the moment, the government appears to be prioritising legislative feasibility over political spectacle. Whether this reflects prudence or postponement will become clearer in the months ahead. For Parliament, however, the immediate responsibility remains unchanged: to ensure that every law enacted strengthens both the efficiency of governance and the constitutional balance between state authority and individual liberty.

ETERNAL BEACON

A Colossus of Sikh Awakening

A century after his martyrdom on July 17, 1926, remembering Sardar Teja Singh Samundri, whose quiet courage and unwavering principles reshaped the Sikh panth

MANJINDER SINGH SIRSA

THE WRITER IS SERVING AS A CABINET MINISTER IN THE GOVERNMENT OF DELHI AND NATIONAL SECRETARY OF THE BJP

His refusal to seek personal power, even while shaping the SGPC and confronting colonial rule, made him one of the most respected moral figures of modern Sikh history

When the name Sardar Teja Singh Samundri is spoken, it evokes not merely a political figure but a towering moral force whose life reshaped the spiritual and political landscape of the Sikh panth. The Teja Singh Samundri Hall, at the heart of the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC) in Sri Amritsar Sahib, stands as a singular testament to his stature; he remains the only individual in the SGPC's hundred-plus-year history to have an institution named after him a distinction earned not through wealth or political manoeuvring, but through the moral gravity of his character.

Early life

Born on February 20, 1882, in Rai Ka Burj village, Tarn Taran district, to Deva Singh and Nand Kaur, Teja Singh emerged from peasant roots in the heartland of Punjab. His formal schooling ended at the primary level, but he possessed profound mastery of Sikh religious texts and historical traditions. His three and a half years of service in the British Indian Army, rising to the rank of Dafadar in the 22nd Cavalry Regiment, instilled in him the organisational discipline and tactical acumen that would later revolutionise Sikh political mobilisation.

Building the Sikh future

Long before "nation-building" became a common phrase, Teja Singh Samundri held to a simple truth: education is the foundation of spiritual and social emancipation. He established two institutions of Khalsa learning: Sri Guru Gobind Singh Khalsa High School in Sarhali, Amritsar district, and a Khalsa Middle School in his native village. Under his initiative, the Khalsa Diwan Bar, a federation of educational and social welfare societies, grew into a network of schools across the Sandal Bar region of Lyallpur district, educating generations of Sikh youth in both modern knowledge and Gurmat principles. He was also among the founding architects of the Akali daily newspaper, recognising that the Sikh renaissance required both institutional power and the power of the written word to awaken consciousness across the Punjab.

Founding the SGPC

In 1920, Teja Singh Samundri became a founding member of the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee, at a time when Sikh gurdwaras lay under the grip of corrupt mahants who had become collaborators with British colonial power. He was renowned for spearheading the nonviolent Gurdwara Reform Movement against mahant control of Sikh shrines under British rule. He consistently refused formal authority, believing that movements decay when individuals overshadow institutions. This principle of "Institutional Humility"- the subordination of ego to organisational mission became the philosophical foundation of his entire life's work. According to Master Tara Singh, he was "a complete Gursikh," one who believed credibility began with personal restraint and leadership with moral example.

From village schools and social reform to the Gurdwara Reform Movement, Sardar Teja Singh Samundri turned Sikh principles into public action

Teja Singh's commitment to equality was not rhetorical. In villages around Amritsar and Tarn Taran, he challenged caste barriers by inviting Dalits to draw water from common wells and serve him publicly, an act of quiet social revolution in early twentieth-century Punjab. In an era when such gestures could invite severe social ostracism, Teja Singh's direct action against caste discrimination demonstrated that Sikh theology was not merely spiritual poetry but a blueprint for radical social transformation.

Morchas and mass movements

Even before these movements, in 1914, when the British government attempted to demolish the boundary wall of Gurdwara Rakab Ganj Sahib in Delhi, Teja Singh Samundri led a hundred-member jatha in fearless, peaceful protest, compelling the colonial authorities to withdraw their desecration. His moral authority was such that even imperial power bent before it. When the British locked away the keys to the Golden Temple's treasury, he mobilised thousands of Sikhs in Chabian Da Morcha, the Keys Agitation of 1921–22, accepting imprisonment rather than submission. In the subsequent Guru Ka Bagh Morcha of 1922, as unarmed Sikhs faced the brutality of British lathis while chanting "Satnam Waheguru," Teja Singh Samundri stood as a philosophical and spiritual pillar, demonstrating that nonviolence is not weakness but the ultimate expression of spiritual power.

When the SGPC faced a financial crisis threatening its legal appeal to the Privy Council, falling short by Rs 75,000, Teja Singh mortgaged 50 acres of his own ancestral land to bridge the gap. When the case was won after his death, his family refused reimbursement. In an era when public life is often shadowed by private gain, this episode stands in stark moral contrast.

Imprisonment and martyrdom

On October 13, 1923, Teja Singh Samundri was arrested along with 58 other Akali and SGPC leaders by the British government on charges of "waging war against the King-Emperor." Imprisoned in Lahore Fort, he was offered conditional release on multiple occasions but steadfastly refused to compromise on his core principles. By 1923, his stature was such that he was chosen as one of the Panj Piaras to initiate the kar sewa of the Golden Temple sarovar, the first such service since 1842. When he and eleven companions, including Master Tara Singh, refused conditional release, public outrage forced the unconditional release of the remaining prisoners. The British then attempted to divide Sikh unity through elections, a strategy that backfired when a wave of sympathy swept Punjab, and Samundri's group secured an overwhelming popular mandate.

While imprisoned in Lahore Fort, Teja Singh Samundri, alongside Master Tara Singh, Bhag Singh, Gurcharn Singh and Sohan Singh Josh, studied each clause of the Gurdwara Bill presented by Governor Malcolm Hailey. The bill met all the Akali demands and was signed into law as the Sikh Gurdwaras Act on July 28, 1925, by the Viceroy of India, legislation that bears the fingerprints of Teja Singh Samundri's principled negotiation and intellectual leadership.

On July 17, 1926, while still imprisoned in Lahore Fort, Sardar Teja Singh Samundri attained martyrdom following a heart attack. Master Tara Singh later wrote that Samundri did not become a martyr in death; his entire life was one of martyrdom. He described a man marked by sewa, love, devotion, wisdom and fearlessness, one without enmity, who gave away what he possessed before keeping anything for himself. For him, sacrifice was not an event, but a lifelong condition.

A century on

The Gurdwara Reform Movement of 1920–1926 stands as one of history's most successful nonviolent mass mobilisations, and Teja Singh Samundri was arguably its philosophical and moral spine. He converted what could have been a sectarian dispute into a paradigm of democratic governance, showing that moral authority, disciplined organisation and unwavering principle could overcome imperial coercive power. In an age of performative politics and impatient leadership, Sardar Teja Singh Samundri reminds us that quiet courage, sustained integrity and institutional vision can leave a deeper imprint than public noise. His was not a life of spectacle, but of conscience and that is why it still speaks.

The Teja Singh Samundri Hall stands as his monument, but his true memorial is written in the democratic institutions he helped create, the dignity he restored to millions of Sikhs, and the template he provided for how spiritual awakening can become a force for social and political transformation. He remains, in the hearts of the faithful, an eternal beacon for all who believe that conscience is the highest authority, and principle the truest power.

Sat Sri Akal — Victory to Truth Eternal.

Views expressed are personal

COVERT CALCULUS

The Politics of a 'Leak'

As Mossad's alleged Ahmadinejad operation dominates headlines, the timing of the leak may reveal more than the intelligence itself ever can

ASIF ULLAH KHAN

THE WRITER HAS WORKED IN SENIOR EDITORIAL POSITIONS FOR MANY RENOWNED INTERNATIONAL PUBLICATIONS

The claims surrounding Mahmoud Ahmadinejad and Mossad raise profound questions about evidence, espionage and psychological warfare

Every intelligence leak has two dimensions: what it reveals and what it is designed to achieve. *The New York Times's* story that Israel's Mossad secretly groomed former Iranian president Mahmoud Ahmadinejad to lead a post-Islamic Republic Iran is one of the most sensational intelligence stories to emerge from the Middle East in years. But before asking whether every allegation is true, it is worth asking why such a story emerged precisely as Iran enters a sensitive post-Khamenei transition.

That timing raises an intriguing possibility. Even if elements of the report are accurate, its disclosure could itself be part of an information campaign aimed at discrediting Ahmadinejad, deepening suspicion within Iran's ruling elite and reminding Tehran that Mossad's reach extends to the highest levels of the Islamic Republic.

If true, it would rank among the most audacious intelligence operations in Middle Eastern history. If not entirely accurate, or if selectively leaked, it could itself be part of a carefully crafted psychological operation.

Intelligence leaks rarely emerge in a political vacuum. They are often timed to achieve objectives beyond merely informing the public. They can discredit political figures, deepen mistrust within rival power centres, demonstrate the reach of an intelligence service or shape political narratives during periods of transition. In Iran, where the succession following the death of Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei has opened a new chapter in the country's politics, the timing of the story deserves as much scrutiny as its content.

The report paints an extraordinary picture. It claims Mossad chief David Barnea personally met Ahmadinejad in Budapest, maintained contacts through overseas meetings, extracted him from his residence during Israeli strikes, sheltered him in a safe house in Tehran and intended to install him as the leader of a transitional government after the collapse of the Islamic Republic.

The report emerged just as Iran navigates a delicate post-Khamenei transition. Intelligence disclosures rarely appear by accident during moments of political uncertainty

If accepted at face value, it reads more like the plot of a spy thriller than a conventional intelligence operation. That alone does not make it false. Intelligence history is full of astonishing operations that initially sounded implausible. Yet extraordinary claims require equally compelling evidence, and this story raises several questions that remain unanswered.

The first concerns Ahmadinejad himself. For much of his presidency, he was arguably Israel's most outspoken adversary. He questioned the Holocaust, championed Iran's nuclear programme and became synonymous with anti-Israel rhetoric. The report argues that he underwent a profound political transformation after leaving office and grew increasingly critical of the clerical establishment. That may well be true. But criticism of Iran's leadership is not the same as becoming willing to cooperate with Mossad. The public evidence presented so far does not bridge that considerable gap.

Even more puzzling is the question of political viability. Regime-change planners usually seek figures who possess broad legitimacy or at least the capacity to unite competing factions. By 2026, Ahmadinejad had alienated almost every major political constituency in Iran. The establishment no longer trusted him. Reformists viewed him with hostility because of the disputed 2009 election and the crackdown that followed. Even within conservative circles, he had become increasingly isolated after repeated clashes with Ayatollah Khamenei. If Israel truly hoped to shape a post-Islamic Republic government, why choose a politician whose domestic support appeared to have largely evaporated?

Another unanswered question concerns Mossad itself. According to the report, Mossad chief David Barnea personally travelled to Budapest to meet Ahmadinejad, reportedly even missing a high-level security meeting in Israel. Intelligence chiefs rarely conduct initial meetings with potential assets. Such contacts are normally delegated to experienced case officers to preserve operational security and plausible deniability. If Barnea indeed attended personally, it suggests Ahmadinejad was already regarded as an asset of exceptional importance. Yet the report does not explain how that level of confidence was established.

The operational details become even more difficult to reconcile. The report claims Mossad rescued Ahmadinejad after Israeli strikes and concealed him in a safe house inside Tehran. If he had become Israel's most valuable political asset inside Iran, why leave him in one of the world's most heavily monitored capitals rather than move him across the border? Keeping him inside Tehran would expose him to surveillance by the Revolutionary Guards, electronic monitoring and eventual capture. The report offers no convincing explanation for such an extraordinary operational decision.

Even stranger is the reported conclusion of the operation. According to the account, Ahmadinejad became disillusioned with the plan, simply left the safe house and was subsequently detained by Iranian authorities. If he was central to Israel's strategy for post-regime Iran, it is difficult to understand how such a valuable asset could simply walk away. Intelligence agencies invest enormous resources in protecting high-value assets. The report provides little insight into how this supposedly critical operation unravelled so easily.

Then there is Tehran's reaction — or rather, its lack of one. If Iran had genuinely uncovered a former president collaborating with Mossad, one might have expected televised confessions, criminal charges, relentless propaganda campaigns and wall-to-wall state media coverage. Instead, official silence prevailed. Ahmadinejad even appeared publicly at Ayatollah Khamenei's funeral. His office has since categorically denied the allegations, while Iranian authorities have neither confirmed nor comprehensively rebutted the report.

Finally, there is the question of sourcing. The New York Times is one of the world's most respected newspapers, and its national security reporting has often proved accurate. But this story rests almost entirely on anonymous Israeli, Iranian and American officials. No documents have been produced. No recordings, photographs or travel records have been made public. There is no independent corroboration of the alleged meetings. In intelligence reporting, anonymous sourcing is sometimes unavoidable. Yet the more extraordinary the claim, the greater the need for corroborating evidence.

None of this proves that the story is false. Intelligence operations often remain hidden for decades, and many of the most remarkable episodes in espionage history were initially dismissed as implausible.

But it does suggest that readers should approach the report with caution rather than certainty.

Perhaps the more revealing question is not whether Mossad really intended to install Ahmadinejad as Iran's next leader. It is why this story emerged now. If the objective was to destroy Ahmadinejad's remaining political credibility, sow suspicion within Iran's fractured elite or advertise the depth of Israeli intelligence penetration, then the leak itself may already have achieved its purpose — regardless of whether every detail of the operation can ever be verified.

In the shadow war between Israel and Iran, information is often as potent as missiles. Sometimes the most effective intelligence operation is not the one that remains secret, but the one that everyone is talking about.

Views expressed are personal

DGMA TO SHIPPING COS

'Don't deploy Indian seafarers on vessels moving via Hormuz'

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Directorate General of Maritime Administration (DGMA) has directed ship owners, ship managers and recruitment and placement service companies to avoid deploying Indian sailors on vessels travelling through the Strait of Hormuz until further orders amid the West Asia crisis.

In an advisory, the DGMA said masters of vessels operating in Persian Gulf, the Strait of Hormuz and adjoining waters shall maintain a heightened level of security vigilance.

They are directed to monitor navigational warnings, security advisories and updates issued by the competent authorities, and implement all applicable ship security measures, in accordance with International Ship and Port Security (ISPS) code.

"Ship owners, ship managers and Recruitment and Placement Service Licence (RPSL) companies are directed to avoid deploying Indian seafarers on vessels undertaking voyages involving passage through the Strait of Hormuz until further order," it said.

The advisory came after the attacks on two vessels this week-- MT Al Bahiyah and MT Mombasa -- in the Strait of Hormuz. They were carrying 30 Indian seafarers among a combined crew of 46. One Indian seafarer lost his life while another sustained injuries aboard MT Al Bahiyah. On MT Mombasa, nine Indian nationals were injured.

The government on Tuesday had asked the shipping authority to set up a dashboard for providing real-time information about Indian seafarers on each vessel operating in the region, irrespective of the ship's flag.

Shipping Minister Sarbananda Sonowal had asked DGMA to establish a comprehensive vessel-by-vessel operational dashboard to account for every Indian on each vessel, irrespective of its flag, operating in the Persian Gulf, Strait of Hormuz and Gulf of Oman.

Three boys play in the shallow waters of the Strait of Hormuz, as a plume of smoke rises from an explosion in the background, off Bandar Abbas, Iran, on July 13 AP/PTI

HIGHLIGHTS

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'CONFLICT OF INTEREST'

Ex-Manipur High Court Chief Justice under scanner over LPG dealership row

Controversy surfaced following an ownership dispute involving the agency

NEW DELHI: Former Chief Justice of the Manipur High Court, Justice (Retd) Siddharth Mridul, has come under scrutiny over allegations that he remained associated with an LPG distributorship, 'Kitchen Flame', during his 16-year judicial tenure.

The matter has assumed significance as judges are bound by their oath of office and judicial codes of conduct, which generally prohibit them from engaging in business activities or holding positions in government bodies, public sector undertakings or private entities that could create a conflict of interest or compromise judicial independence.

According to the allegations, Justice Mridul continued to be associated with the LPG agency even after being appointed a judge of the Delhi HC in March 2008 and later as Chief Justice of the Manipur HC in October 2023.

The controversy surfaced following an ownership dispute involving the agency. Two months ago, Monika Yadav, the widow of the agency's former manager, approached the Delhi HC seeking transfer of ownership rights of the distributorship in her name. Subsequently, in December 2025, a public complaint was filed alleging that the owner of the LPG agency was a sitting judge.

Following the complaint, BPCL reportedly issued several show-cause notices to Justice Mridul, alleging violation of service rules by engaging in business while holding judicial office without the requisite permission.

Taking the view that holding a constitutional office and running a business was contrary to applicable rules, BPCL suspended the dealership on July 6 after Justice Mridul allegedly failed to respond to the notices. Court proceedings later revealed that after the suspension of the dealership, Monika Yadav filed a fresh petition before the Delhi High Court alleging inaction by BPCL and pointing to lapses by the previous owner, Justice Mridul. AGENCIES

INSIGHT

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- Taking the view that holding a constitutional office and running a business was contrary to applicable rules, BPCL suspended the dealership on July 6 after Justice Mridul allegedly failed to respond to the notices

Guj: 'IAF corporal kills self'

KUTCH: An Indian Air Force (IAF) corporal allegedly shot himself dead with his service weapon at the Naliya Air Force Station in Gujarat's Kutch district, police said on Thursday.

No suicide note has been found yet, they said.

"The deceased has been identified as Corporal Bharatkumar Bhardwaj (27). He allegedly shot himself dead at around 5 pm on Wednesday using his service weapon, an AK-47 assault rifle," an official of the Kothara police station said.

The incident occurred inside the parking area of the Naliya Air Force Station when on-duty personnel heard gunshots and found Bhardwaj lying in a pool of blood. Three shots were fired from the AK-47 rifle allotted to the corporal, he said.

Police have filed an accidental death report and further investigation was underway, the official added. AGENCIES

Hooda targets BJP over hike in toll rates in Hry

CHANDIGARH: Congress leader and former Haryana Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda on Thursday criticised the "recent hike" in toll charges in the state, alleging that the BJP government was "looting" people by increasing toll rates.

Hooda said toll charges at plazas in Karnal, Kurukshetra, Hisar, Panipat and Jhajjar had been increased, adding to the burden on motorists already grappling with high fuel costs and taxes.

"Rates have been hiked for the second time in three months at all toll plazas, including the Thana toll plaza on the Hisar-Chandigarh National Highway. At the Ramayan toll plaza in Hisar, rates for cars, buses, trucks and commercial vehicles have been increased by Rs 5 to Rs 30," he said.

The Leader of the Opposition claimed that travelling within and outside Haryana had become more expensive and alleged that the state records the highest toll collection in the country. Citing figures shared by Union Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari in the Lok Sabha, Hooda said toll collection in Haryana increased by Rs 368.57 crore in October 2025 compared to the previous year, while Gujarat witnessed a decline of Rs 1,928.57 crore during the same period.

He further claimed that Haryana's per capita toll collection stood at Rs 917.1, the highest in the country, and that annual toll collection per kilometre was Rs 0.69 crore. MPOST

First half of 2026: '40 Maoists killed, 71 nabbed in CRPF ops'

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) has recorded major successes in anti-Maoist, anti-terror and anti-insurgency operations across Left Wing Extremism (LWE)-affected states, Jammu and Kashmir (J&K) and the North East during the first half of 2026, while also expanding welfare initiatives for its personnel and their families.

In Maoist-hit states, the force neutralised 40 Maoists, arrested 71 and facilitated the surrender of 336 cadres between January and June. Security forces also recovered 375 firearms, more than 8,300 rounds of ammunition, 3,211 improvised explosive devices (IEDs), explosives, grenades and Rs 2 crore in cash from Maoist camps.

The operations resulted in the killing of several top Maoist functionaries and the arrest of key leaders, including Ravindra Ganju, who carried a reward of Rs 20 lakh on his head.

In Jammu and Kashmir, counter-insurgency operations led to the killing of eight terrorists and the arrest of 24 overground workers and suspects. Security agencies also targeted several foreign terror networks, including Jaish-e-Mohammed and Lashkar-e-Taiba.

The CRPF has deployed over 232 companies in J&K to ensure security for the ongoing Amarnath Yatra, which had attracted more than 2.75 lakh pilgrims till July 13.

In the North East, joint security operations resulted in the arrest of 250 insurgents and anti-national elements. Forces recovered 289 weapons, nearly 5,000 rounds of ammunition and more than 1.65 tonnes of illicit drugs, besides dismantling several insurgent camps and bunkers in Manipur.

Alongside operational achievements, the CRPF has strengthened welfare measures by partnering with Jaypee Institute of Information Technology and Made Easy to offer scholarships and concessions to serving and retired personnel and their dependents.

It has also launched 'SAKSHAM', a school for special children in New Delhi, and enhanced support initiatives for families of martyrs and Veer Naris.

ED conducts multi-state raids in Rohingya-Bangladeshi infiltration case

NEW DELHI: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Friday carried out searches across several states in connection with a money laundering probe into the alleged illegal infiltration and rehabilitation of Rohingyas and Bangladeshi nationals in India.

The searches were conducted by the ED's Lucknow Zonal Office under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002, at residential premises of various accused persons in Kolkata, North and South 24 Parganas and Murshidabad in Bengal, Ballabhgarh in Haryana, Deoband in Uttar Pradesh, Delhi and other locations. According to the ED, a network of criminal elements was facilitating the illegal entry of Rohingyas and Bangladeshis through international borders, arranging their permanent stay in the country and providing forged Indian passports, Aadhaar cards, PAN cards and other identity documents.

The agency alleged that certain public charitable trusts registered under the Foreign Contribution Regulation Act (FCRA) and based in Delhi had links with UK-based entities that channelled funds to support the illegal migration of Rohingyas and Bangladeshis into India. The ED claimed that the migrants were provided financial assistance for employment, purchase of e-rickshaws and settlement in different States. The funds were allegedly routed in small amounts ranging from Rs 6,000 to Rs 10,000 to various beneficiaries.

Investigators further alleged that one criminal group operating from West Bengal's border districts facilitated illegal infiltration, while another group prepared forged documents and distributed them across the country.

During searches at Harora Al Jamiatul Islamia Darul Uloom in Kalikapur, West Bengal, the ED recovered Rs 40 lakh in cash and 180 grams of gold coins. MPOST

Haryana CM Nayab Saini reviews arrangements for PM's Jind visit

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Thursday reviewed preparations in Jind for Prime Minister Narendra Modi's proposed visit on Friday, during which the Prime Minister will flag off India's first hydrogen-powered train from the district.

Saini said all programmes scheduled during the Prime Minister's visit would be completely eco-friendly. The CM first visited Chaudhary Ranbir Singh University and took stock of arrangements for the various events planned in Jind. He later reached Jind Railway Station, where he reviewed preparations for the launch of the hydrogen train and issued necessary directions to officials.

During the inspection, Saini examined arrangements for the entry of the general public and VIPs, the executive lounge, cafeteria and railway track. He also reviewed passenger facilities at the station.

Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini reviews preparations for PM Narendra Modi's rally at Jind

The CM subsequently visited the Haryana Urban Development Authority ground, where the 'Viksit Bharat-Viksit Haryana' rally is scheduled to be held. He inspected seating arrangements, parking facilities and other preparations.

Saini directed officials to ensure that people attending the rally do not face any inconvenience and that adequate arrangements for drinking water and other basic amenities are in place.

Public Works Minister Ranbir Singh Gangwa, Haryana Vidhan Sabha Deputy Speaker Krishan Lal Middha, BJP state president Archana Gupta, Chief Secretary Anurag Rastogi and several senior administrative and police officials were present during the review meetings. MPOST

Mann hands over 2,800 ration depot licences

With new depots, ration reaches closer to people's homes, says Punjab CM

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Thursday handed over licences to 2,800 new ration depot holders and said this will ensure that ration reaches closer to people's homes across the state.

The move will benefit nearly 5.5 lakh ration card holders, and the government has allotted the new depots through an interview-based selection process while ensuring representation for all sections of society, officials said.

Addressing a gathering in Mohali, Mann said the opening of new ration depots will spare nearly 5.5 lakh ration card holders from travelling long distances or leaving work to stand in long queues for their monthly ration.

He said the government has also ensured equitable representation of all sections of society while issuing licences to the new ration depot holders.

"The allotment has been made in a fair and transparent manner while ensuring representation for every section of society. Out of the 2,800 new licences, 633 have been allotted to Scheduled Castes, 199 to Other Backward Classes, 181 to ex-servicemen, 39 to the families of freedom fighters, 156 to persons with disabilities and 17 to riot-affected families," he said.

Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann hands over the licence to a new ration depot holder

Mann said that under the Smart Ration Card Scheme, the state government is providing free wheat and 'Meri Rasoi' ration kits to 40 lakh families across Punjab.

"The earlier governments distributed ration depot licences on the basis of political recommendations. We have ended that practice by introducing an interview-based selection system to eliminate favouritism and ensure complete transparency," he said.

Targeting the Congress, Mann said it was deeply divided, and it lacks any vision for Punjab.

He accused the Congress leaders of fighting over a chair.

"One day they project one leader, the next day another. Their politics revolves only around the chair. One of their own leaders has publicly admitted that it costs Rs 500 crore to become the chief minister in their party. The obvious question is, where will such money come from?" he asked.

Mann said such money ultimately comes from the pockets of ordinary people, adversely affecting welfare-oriented governance.

"The money will be recovered from the people. When politics becomes so expensive, it is public welfare that suffers the most," he said. MPOST

MP CM bolsters GIS-2027 push, secures ₹20,193-cr investment proposals in Delhi

Bharat Tex-2026 and investor outreach generate commitments across textiles, defence, AI, semiconductors and renewable energy; nearly 27,600 jobs likely

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

NEW DELHI: Stepping up preparations for the Global Investors Summit (GIS)-2027, Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav on Thursday used two major investment platforms in New Delhi to showcase the state's industrial potential, attracting investment proposals worth Rs 20,193 crore with the potential to generate nearly 27,600 direct and indirect jobs.

Leading the state's investment outreach at Bharat Tex-2026 and the Interactive Session on Investment Opportunities in Madhya Pradesh, Yadav pitched the state as one of India's fastest-growing industrial destinations, highlighting its investor-friendly policies, robust infrastructure, skilled workforce and responsive governance. He also invited industry leaders, investors and global brands to participate in GIS-2027, scheduled to be held in January next year.

The combined investment proposals from the two events are expected to create employment opportunities for around 27,592 people, reinforcing the state's efforts to sustain the investment momentum built over the past two years through domestic and international roadshows.

Addressing investors, Yadav said Madhya Pradesh offers a conducive ecosystem backed by policy support, seamless approvals and expanding industrial infrastructure. He said the investment proposals, strategic partnerships and memoranda of understanding (MoUs) signed during the Delhi events would further strengthen the state's position among the country's leading investment destinations while contributing to the vision of Viksit Bharat-2047.

The textile sector emerged as a major attraction during Bharat Tex-2026, where a roundtable at Bharat Mandapam focused on textiles and apparel, the PM MITRA Textile Park, technical textiles, export promotion, skill development and investment facilitation. The discussions resulted in investment proposals worth Rs 1,592 crore, with an estimated employment potential of nearly 15,700 people.

> "Madhya Pradesh is not just offering investment opportunities; it is offering long-term growth partnerships
>
> - CM Mohan Yadav

The second leg of the outreach—the Interactive Session on Investment Opportunities in Madhya Pradesh—generated Rs 18,601 crore in investment proposals across sectors including defence manufacturing, data centres, transformer manufacturing, electronics, renewable energy, engineering and the toy industry. These projects are expected to create around 11,892 jobs.

During the session, the Madhya Pradesh Industrial Development Corporation (MPIDC) signed seven MoUs aimed at strengthening exports, e-commerce, global trade, MSMEs and industrial collaboration. The state also showcased investment opportunities in emerging sectors such as information technology, artificial intelligence, semiconductors, tourism and food processing.

Officials said the strong investor response in New Delhi reflects growing confidence in Madhya Pradesh's industrial ecosystem and is expected to provide a significant boost to the state's preparations for GIS-2027, where the government aims to attract large-scale domestic and global investments.

Nation Briefs

DEVELOPMENT OF INDIA'S HIGHEST LILIUM CULTIVATION FIELD STARTS IN LADAKH

LEH/JAMMU: The development of India's highest commercial Lilium cultivation field has commenced in Ladakh's Choglamsar area, as part of an initiative to establish Ladakh as a hub for premium floriculture, officials said on Thursday. More than 50,000 premium Lilium bulbs have been planted over the past three days at the flower field. Situated at an altitude of around 3,265 metres, it surpasses the country's existing highest flower field at Mana in Uttarakhand, located at 3,200 metres.

CONSUMER FORUM ASKS DEALER TO REPLACE FAULTY CAR WITH E20 MODEL

RAIPUR: A district consumer commission in Chhattisgarh has asked a Maruti Suzuki dealer to replace a car bought by a doctor with a new E20 petrol-compliant model after holding the dealer sold a vehicle made 16 months ago and failed to rectify recurring engine problems despite repeated repairs. The commission, in its July 14 order, held respondents (Maruti Suzuki and the dealer) committed deficiency in service and indulged in unfair trade practice by refusing to take back the defective vehicle.

VOWS TO HOLD CENTRE ACCOUNTABLE ON KEY ISSUES IN PARLIAMENT

'Cong to corner Centre over Ram temple donations, edu'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Thursday said it will corner the government on critical issues such as the alleged theft of donations from the Ram temple and "systemic corrosion" of education system during the upcoming Monsoon Session of Parliament.

The party also asserted that it will strongly oppose the constitutional amendment bills related to delimitation and dismissal of ministers and chief ministers during the session beginning July 20.

Senior Congress leaders, including party chief Mallikarjun Kharge, Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi and other senior leaders deliberated on key issues to be taken up during the session. The meeting was held at the 10, Janpath residence of Congress Parliamentary Party (CPP) chairperson Sonia Gandhi.

Among other Congress leaders who attended the key strategy meeting included AICC general secretary K C Venugopal, Congress' chief whip in Rajya Sabha Jairam Ramesh, P Chidambaram, K Suresh, Naseer Hussain, Manickam Tagore, Kumari Selja, Tariq Anwar, Shashi Tharoor and Manish Tewari among others.

In a post on X, Kharge said, "Chanda Chori -- Astha se Dhoka, Paper leaks and the systemic corrosion of education system, institutional capture, breaking of political parties, multiple scams and charges of corruption, backbreaking price rise, foreign policy failures and strategic blunders, the imposition of ethanol blending on 3.5 crore vehicle owners, unbridled deforestation, and the continued assault on the rights of SCs, STs, OBCs and minorities are among the critical issues on which the Congress Party will hold the Modi government accountable during the forthcoming Monsoon Session of Parliament."

These pressing concerns affecting the lives and aspirations of the people were deliberated upon during the meeting, Kharge said.

Addressing a press conference after the meeting, Ramesh said, "We have learnt that the Union Home Minister (Amit Shah) is making efforts to bring back the Delimitation Bill. The government failed to secure a two-thirds majority on 17th April and suffered a significant setback. It now wants to reintroduce the Bill."

This was discussed along with the Constitution amendment bill which seeks the removal of ministers in custody for 30 days over serious offences, he said.

TAKEAWAYS

» 'Congress Party has consistently maintained that it will strongly oppose the Delimitation Bill and will continue to do so'

» 'We will also make every effort to maintain the unity and solidarity of all Opposition parties. Similarly, we will firmly oppose the proposed Constitution Amendment Bill...'

"The Congress Party has consistently maintained that it will strongly oppose the Delimitation Bill and will continue to do so. We will also make every effort to maintain the unity and solidarity of all Opposition parties. Similarly, we will firmly oppose the proposed Constitution Amendment Bill related to the removal of ministers," he said.

There was also some discussion on the 'One Nation, One Election' on which a JPC has been constituted, Ramesh said.

"We will also oppose the Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan Bill in its entirety. It is possible that the Bill may be introduced during this session. There is also a possibility that the FCRA Amendment Bill will be introduced. We will oppose it as well. We had opposed it earlier, following which the government withdrew the Bill. However, we are now hearing that it may be brought back," Ramesh said.

Another important issue discussed was the proposed amendments to the National Food Security Act, 2013, which forms the basis of the Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana, he said.

"We are completely opposed to these proposed amendments, and if the Bill is introduced during this session, we will strongly oppose it. As far as the legislative agenda is concerned, I do not see any Bill before us that we can support," Ramesh said.

The Congress is strongly opposed to the two Constitution amendment bills, he said.

Ahead of the Monsoon session beginning July 20, the INDIA bloc will meet on Monday to finalise its strategy. The Opposition plans to challenge the government's proposed delimitation bill and raise issues including the NEET paper leak, alleged Ayodhya Ram temple donation irregularities, rising oil prices and the Indo-US trade deal.

PM to unveil, lay foundation of projs worth Rs 5,470 crore

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHANDIGARH: Prime Minister Narendra Modi will inaugurate and lay the foundation stone of rail and road infrastructure projects worth Rs 5,470 crore during his Punjab visit on July 17, officials said on Thursday, adding that the scheduled event will take place in Jalandhar.

The projects are aimed at strengthening connectivity, improving passenger convenience and accelerating economic development in the region.

This will be PM Modi's second visit to Jalandhar after he visited the Dera Sachkhand Ballan in February this year.

PM Modi's visit assumes significance as the BJP is preparing to fight the 2027 Punjab Assembly polls on its own.

Director General of Police Gaurav Yadav visited the Jalandhar Cantonment railway station on Thursday to review security arrangements. The district administration has declared a 'no flying zone' in Jalandhar in view of the visit.

During his Friday visit, PM Modi will inaugurate 75 redeveloped railway stations under the Amrit Bharat Station Scheme from the Jalandhar Cantonment railway station.

Developed at a cost of about Rs 1,570 crore, these stations have been transformed into modern, passenger-friendly facilities. Redeveloped in the spirit of 'Virasat Bhi, Vikas Bhi', the stations incorporate elements reflecting local culture, heritage and architecture.

POLL PUSH

» PM to inaugurate 75 redeveloped railway stations under the Amrit Bharat Station Scheme from Jalandhar Cantt

» Security has been tightened, with Jalandhar declared a 'no flying zone' and the DGP reviewing arrangements

» The visit comes as the BJP prepares to contest 2027 Punjab Assembly elections independently

Among them, the four redeveloped railway stations in Punjab are Jalandhar Cantonment, S A S Nagar (Mohali), Sri Muktsar Sahib and Sri Anandpur Sahib.

Besides, Modi will also inaugurate the Daulatpur Chowk-Kartoli new rail line, constructed at a cost of about Rs 830 crore as part of the Nangal Dam-Talwara-Mukerian New Rail Line Project.

This project will significantly strengthen rail connectivity between Punjab and Himachal Pradesh, benefiting the districts of Hoshiarpur and Una, officials said.

The new rail line will provide connectivity to important religious destinations such as Shri Anandpur Sahib and Maa Chintpurni Temple, while enhancing access to remote areas by providing passengers with a faster, safer and more reliable mode of transportation, they said.

Modi will also flag off the Kartoli-Ambala train service, which will improve connectivity across Punjab, Haryana and Himachal Pradesh.

He will also flag off the Amritsar (Chheharta)-Varanasi train service, establishing a direct rail link between two of India's most revered spiritual and cultural centres.

The PM will inaugurate and lay the foundation stone of national highway projects worth over Rs 3,070 crore.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will inaugurate sections of the Delhi-Amritsar-Katra Expressway and lay the foundation stone for the Southern Ludhiana Bypass in Punjab on Friday.

Earlier in Chandigarh, he will launch healthcare and road projects worth over Rs 4,700 crore, including new facilities and a critical care block at PGIMER.

PM speaks to Amir of Qatar

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday spoke to Amir of Qatar, Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani, and conveyed his heartfelt condolences on the passing of the Father Amir, Sheikh Hamad bin Khalifa Al Thani.

The prime minister also said the departed leader's enduring legacy will continue to guide the two countries for further strengthening the strategic partnership.

The Father Amir died on July 12 at the age of 74. Following his death, the central government had declared one-day national mourning on July 13 as a mark of respect, with the national flag flown at half-mast throughout the country. "Spoke with H.H. Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani, the Amir of Qatar and conveyed heartfelt condolences on the passing of H.H. the Father Amir, Sheikh Hamad bin Khalifa Al Thani.

"Recalled his deep affection for India, his warmth towards the Indian community in Qatar and his steadfast commitment to India-Qatar relations. His enduring legacy will continue to guide our two countries as we further strengthen our Strategic Partnership," Modi said in a post on 'X'. MPOST

Kharge writes to PM on bill involving delimitation, seeks all-party meeting

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Thursday wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi over reports that the government is now planning to reintroduce a Constitution amendment bill that would involve delimitation, urging him to convene an all-party meeting to discuss the revised proposals.

In his letter to the PM, Kharge said during March and April, he had been writing to Minister of Parliamentary Affairs Kiren Rijiju, requesting that the Union government convene an all-party meeting to discuss its proposals regarding delimitation, etc.

"Unfortunately, these requests had not been accepted. The Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026, then failed to secure the required 2/3 majority in Lok Sabha on 17 April, 2026 by a clear margin," he said.

"I have been reading in media reports that the Union Government now proposes to reintroduce a revised (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026 during the forthcoming Monsoon Session of Parliament. I would, once again, request you to convene an all-party meeting to discuss the government's revised proposals on delimitation, etc., and give us adequate time to study them in detail before they are introduced in Parliament," Kharge said.

The Congress chief's letter comes days after it emerged that the government is learnt to be working on multiple formulations to increase the number of Lok Sabha seats for all states by 50 per cent to assuage the concerns of southern states, as it seeks to operationalise a fresh draft of the Constitution amendment bill on women's quota law.

The draft is being readied keeping in mind the concerns of the southern states that a population-based delimitation exercise would shrink their political power in the Lok Sabha.

The first Bill failed to clear the Lok Sabha test on April 17, as the government could not muster the two-thirds majority required to pass it. The Modi government had said that it wanted to get the Bill passed as it wanted to advance the enforcement of the women reservation law. As of now, the ruling NDA has around 300 MPs in the Lok Sabha with three vacancies. It needs 360 votes to achieve the two-thirds mark.

Under the current law, reservation for women would not be enforceable before 2034, as the process is tied to the completion of the delimitation exercise post the 2027 Census.

To implement it from the 2029 Lok Sabha elections, changes were needed in the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, or women's reservation law. According to the government's plan, Lok Sabha seats will be increased to a maximum of 850 from the current 543 to "operationalise" the women's quota law before the 2029 parliamentary polls following a delimitation exercise to be carried out based on the last published census.

Chhattisgarh clears 'Ease of Doing Business Bill' to simplify approvals

RAIPUR: The Chhattisgarh legislative assembly on Thursday passed a bill aimed at reducing bureaucratic hurdles, lowering compliance costs and creating a more business-friendly environment for investors, particularly micro, small and medium enterprises.

Commerce and Industry Minister Lakhan Lal Dewangan introduced the Chhattisgarh Ease of Doing Business Bill, 2026, in the House, where it was passed with a partial amendment after a discussion.

Participating in the debate, senior BJP MLA and former minister Ajay Chandrakar described the legislation as a forward-looking measure that would prepare the state for future economic challenges.

He said the introduction of a comprehensive legislation reflected a proactive government that is ready to respond to changing global economic conditions.

Chandrakar said investment-driven employment generation would become increasingly important as the rapid adoption of artificial intelligence (AI) was expected to reduce jobs in both governments and private companies.

'Govt should organise seminar after framing the rules to familiarise officials, legislators...'

Referring to job cuts by global firms, he said Chhattisgarh needed to create an ecosystem that could generate employment through industrialisation, stabilise markets and ensure optimal utilisation of resources.

Describing the bill as a landmark reform, Chandrakar said scholars of public administration would study it as an example of how red tapism could be eliminated through legislative measures.

He also suggested that the government organise a large seminar after framing the rules to familiarise officials, legislators and industry stakeholders with the new system.

The BJP MLA said the bill provides for a high-level empowered committee to be chaired by the chief minister. He suggested making a minor change in the terminology without altering the objective of the provision.

Chandrakar said the designation of the Chief Secretary as the "Convener" of the committee should be replaced with either "Chief Executive Officer (CEO)" or "Secretary" of the committee.

The term "Convener" sounded more political than administrative, he said.

Congress MLA Daleshwar Sahu opposed the bill, and said the legislation should be introduced only after thorough deliberation and consultation.

He argued that the proposed law, which initially covers 43 categories of services, lacked adequate justification and would not simplify existing procedures.

Sahu said the executive council and executive committee proposed under the legislation had been assigned limited powers and were unlikely to bring any significant improvement in the current approval process. The Bill introduces deemed approvals, self-certification and risk-based inspections across 43 services, aiming to ease compliance and benefit over 15 lakh MSMEs in Chhattisgarh. MPOST

Par panel on health discusses functional proficiency of regulatory institutions

NEW DELHI: A parliamentary panel on Thursday discussed the functional proficiency of regulatory institutions under the Health Ministry in connection with the conduct of the NEET-UG examination by the National Testing Agency (NTA).

Representatives of the NTA and domain experts gave their presentation before the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Health and Family Welfare headed by Samajwadi Party MP Ram Gopal Yadav.

Sources said the committee heard the views on the conduct of NEET-UG exam and suggested steps to improve upon the functioning of the NTA.

The panel has asked the authorities concerned to submit the report in writing too, the sources added.

The NEET row has already been discussed by two other parliamentary panels, which had summoned top officials of the Health and Higher Education ministries, besides officials of the NTA, National Medical Commission (NMC) and the CBI which is probing the NEET paper leak case.

The Parliamentary Committee on Health and Family Welfare also discussed in detail the issue of affordability and accessibility of healthcare facilities in public and private sectors during the meeting.

A power point presentation on 'One Nation - One Entrance Test', SmartInsta Test-AI (SITAI) by Balaveera Reddy, a former chairman, Board of Governors, National Institute of Technology Karnataka (NITK) Surathkal and former vice chancellor of Visvesvaraya Technological University (VTU), Karnataka, was also made during the meeting.

Oral evidence of the secretary, National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA), chairpersons of the Quality Council of India (QCI) and National Accreditation Board for Hospitals (NABH), besides the DCGI, Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) was also heard during the meeting on the issue of 'Affordability and Accessibility of Healthcare Facilities in Public and Private Sector'.

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Health discussed the NEET examination process and the functioning of regulatory bodies, becoming the third parliamentary panel to examine the issue following allegations of a paper leak and the exam's cancellation. PTI

SC directs states to frame policy for early release of aged & terminally ill prisoners

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday directed all the states and Union territories to formulate a policy within three months for early or premature release of prisoners who are of advanced age or are terminally ill.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta said the policy should clearly define the eligibility criteria and procedural framework for consideration of release and in particular, it should provide a clear and uniform definition of "terminal illness".

The bench delivered its verdict on a plea filed by the National Legal Services Authority (NALSA) seeking to release on bail a group of prisoners who are terminally ill or are above 70 years of age.

"All states and Union territories shall within a period of three months from the date of this judgment formulate and notify a comprehensive policy for early or premature release of prisoners who are of advanced age and/or are terminally ill," Justice Mehta said while pronouncing the verdict.

Policy to be framed in consultation with the respective State Legal Services Authorities: Court

The bench said the policy should be framed in consultation with the respective State Legal Services Authorities so as to ensure institutional coordination and effective identification of eligible prisoners.

It said the policy should prescribe a time-bound, transparent and accessible procedure for submission, examination and disposal of applications seeking early or compassionate release.

The bench asked the Centre to provide necessary technical support, digital infrastructure and capacity-building assistance to the states and Union territories to facilitate effective compliance with the court's directions.

The top court directed the Centre, states and Union territories to file compliance affidavits before it within six months, indicating the status of compliance. The detailed judgement is awaited.

In May last year, the apex court agreed to hear NALSA's plea and sought responses from the Centre and others.

The plea urged the top court to issue directions to facilitate the release of prisoners aged above 70 years and those suffering from terminal illnesses. It said terminally ill prisoners and those of advanced age required specialised care and individual attention and it may not be possible for the prison authorities to provide, considering the extent of overcrowding in jails. NALSA had said as of December 31, 2022, India's prison occupancy rate stood at 131 per cent, severely straining infrastructure and impacting the quality of medical care and dignified living conditions within jails.

India's 1st Hydrogen Train sets the stage for sustainable railway travel

'Indigenous proj features 10-coach train, dedicated refuelling station...'

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: India is all set to welcome a new era in the history of railways through its maiden Hydrogen Fuel Cell Powered Trainset today, which will act as a harbinger of India's journey to more sustainable rail travel. The train, set to run on the Jind-Sonipat track of Northern Railway, is much more than just another innovation. It has witnessed many advancements since its inception, from steam locomotive trains powered by coal and diesel to an almost completely electrified system.

This train arrives during a time when Indian Railways has already electrified over 99 per cent of its Broad Gauge track in the past decade. With Indian Railways having reduced its dependency on imported diesel, hydrogen fuel is set to become the next big thing, especially in those areas where overhead electrification may not always be the best option.

Unlike traditional electric trains - which depend on overhead electrical wires for energy, the Hydrogen Fuel Cell Trainset produces electricity using an electrochemical process in which hydrogen combines with oxygen in what is known as Proton Exchange Membrane (PEM) fuel cells, thus producing electricity to run the trains' traction motors without any harmful emissions other than water vapour and heat.

It means that the train carries its own power source just like how steam and diesel trains used to. The only major difference is that there is no need for burning fossil fuels since the energy conversion process does not involve combustion of any kind.

The train is made up of two Hydrogen Driving Power Cars placed at both ends and eight trailer coaches, thus being the first hydrogen-powered passenger train of 10 coaches in India. Both Hydrogen Driving Power Cars produce 1,200 kW (1,600 hp), which is enough to enable the train to run at 110 kmph as the design speed, whereas its operational speed on the Jind-Sonipat route is 75 kmph.

The train will carry 2,600 passengers, thus being much larger than any other hydrogen passenger train that operates anywhere else around the globe. The majority of hydrogen trains that operate in Europe and Asia have just two to four coaches each.

The inaugural run will connect Jind and Sonipat in the state of Haryana on an 89-kilometre stretch from Gohana, Jind City, Pandu Pindara Junction, Bhambhewa and Mohana among other intermediate stops. This route has been chosen to test the performance of the hydrogen-fuelled passenger trains and their safety in normal railway operations.

The train has the support of an infrastructure, which is described by the Indian Railways as India's first hydrogen railway ecosystem. The railway, further, in Jind has set up the biggest railway hydrogen generation and refuelling station in the country. Hydrogen gas is generated through electrolysis of water using electricity in a process that involves separation of the water molecule into hydrogen and oxygen.

Designed to international safety standards, the indigenous hydrogen train features leak detectors, automatic shutdown systems and comprehensive monitoring. Developed under the National Green Hydrogen Mission, the project marks India's entry into hydrogen-powered rail transport and could pave the way for similar trains on heritage railway routes.

Sales of petrol & diesel surge in first half of July

Petrol sales by IOC, BPCL & HPCL climbed 22.9% to 1.63 MT during July 1-15 against 1.33 MT in a year ago period

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Petrol and diesel sales by India's three state-run fuel retailers rose sharply in the first half of July, helped by below-normal monsoon rainfall that boosted fuel demand from farmers and motorists, preliminary sales data showed on Thursday.

Petrol sales by Indian Oil Corp (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corp Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corp Ltd (HPCL) climbed 22.9 per cent to 1.63 million tonnes (MT) during July 1-15, compared with 1.33 MT in the corresponding period a year earlier.

The volume was also 26.7 per cent higher than 1.29 million tonnes sold during the first half of July 2024 and 38.6 per cent above the level recorded in the same period of 2023. Compared with the first half of June, however, petrol sales fell 4.4 per cent from 1.71 million tonnes.

Diesel sales, a key indicator of economic activity in India, rose 20.9 per cent year-on-year to 3.46 million tonnes in the first fortnight of July from 2.87 million tonnes a year earlier.

The volume was 18.4 per cent higher than in the corresponding period of 2024 and 13.9 per cent above the first half of July 2023. On a month-on-month basis, diesel sales declined 12.1 per cent from 3.94 million tonnes in the first half of June.

Fuel sales typically moderate with the onset of the monsoon, which reduces demand for running agricultural irrigation pumps as well as slows vehicular movement. But this year, the monsoon rains arrived late, which led to farmers using diesel to run pumps to irrigate farms. Month-on-month, the sales in July is lower because June is typically the time when holiday travel picks up due to school and college holidays.

Jet fuel (ATF) sales inched up marginally by 0.7 per cent to 315,400 tonnes during July 1-15, but were 10.3 per cent lower than 351,400 tonnes sold in the first half of June.

Liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) sales continued to fall, dropping 17.5 per cent to 1.14 million tonnes.

LPG sales have been on a decline since the onset of the West Asia crisis disrupted supplies, leading to the imposition of consumption restriction in certain sectors like hotels and restaurants.

The curbs were lifted this month, and sales saw a 1.7 per cent rise over 1.12 million tonnes consumed in the first half of June, the data showed.

The volume was also 26.7% higher than 1.29 million tonnes sold during first half of July 2024 & 38.6% above the level recorded in the same period of 2023

HIGHLIGHTS

- Diesel sales rose 20.9% year-on-year to 3.46 MT in first fortnight of July from 2.87 MT a year earlier
- The volume was 18.4 per cent higher than in the corresponding period of 2024 and 13.9 per cent above the first half of July 2023
- ATF sales rose by 0.7% to 315,400 tonnes during July 1-15, but were 10.3% lower than 351,400 tonnes sold in the first half of June

Markets end flat, profit-taking in blue-chip stocks offset gains in IT

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty closed almost unchanged on Thursday, as profit-taking in blue-chip stocks such as HDFC Bank and Reliance Industries offset gains in IT shares amid geopolitical tensions.

The 30-share BSE Sensex edged up 1.44 points to settle at 77,186.87. During the day, it climbed 394.26 points, or 0.51 per cent, to 77,579.69 but pared gains towards the end of the session.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dipped 5.75 points, or 0.02 per cent, to end at 24,072.75.

Fluctuating oil prices and weak Asian market trends also weighed on domestic equities, according to an expert.

Among Sensex shares, InterGlobe Aviation, HCL Technologies, Bajaj Finance, Maruti, Mahindra & Mahindra and Tech Mahindra were the major winners.

Eternal, Bharat Electronics, Bajaj Finserv, HDFC Bank and Axis Bank were among the laggards.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, dipped 0.39 per cent to USD 84.62 per barrel.

In Asian markets, South Korea's Kospi tanked 6.37 per cent. Japan's Nikkei 225 index and Shanghai's SSE Composite index also settled lower, while Hong Kong's Hang Seng index ended higher.

"Indian equities concluded largely subdued as investors remained cautious amid geopolitical uncertainties, fluctuating oil prices, and weak Asian market trends," said Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited.

Meanwhile, cooling US inflation eased rate concerns and offered downside support, he added.

The BSE SmallCap Select index declined 0.21 per cent and MidCap Select index dipped 0.07 per cent.

Among sectors, Consumer Durables jumped 1.13 per cent, followed by Focused IT (0.58 per cent), IT (0.58 per cent), Auto (0.30 per cent), Services (0.22 per cent), FMCG (0.22 per cent), Commodities (0.17 per cent) and Telecommunication (0.14 per cent).

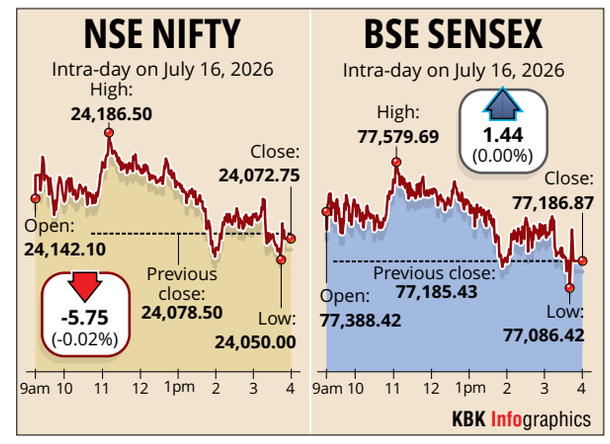
Financial Services, Industrials, Private Banks index, Utilities, Bankex, PSU Bank, Top 10 Banks, Realty and MidSmall Private Banks Quality Tilt were the laggards.

"Investor sentiment remained subdued amid mixed cues from the global peers. While geopolitical tensions in the Middle East kept the undertone cautious, better quarterly earnings on the domestic front helped limit the downside," Ajit Mishra – SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

Markets in Europe were trading lower. US markets ended higher on Wednesday.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth Rs 735.83 crore on Wednesday, according to exchange data.

On Wednesday, the Sensex climbed 130.49 points, or 0.17 per cent, to settle at 77,185.43. The Nifty went up 26.45 points, or 0.11 per cent, to end at 24,078.50.



Fluctuating oil prices and weak Asian market trends also weighed on domestic equities

Rupee falls 17 paise to 96.42 against dollar

MUMBAI: The rupee depreciated for the fourth straight day, shedding 17 paise to settle at 96.42 against the US dollar amid volatility in global crude oil prices and a stronger greenback as the West Asia crisis intensified.

FII outflows put further pressure on the local unit, forex traders said.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 96.28 against the greenback and traded in a range of 96.22-96.42 during the session. It settled at 96.42, down 17 paise from its previous close.

The local unit had on Wednesday settled 9 paise lower at 96.25 against the US dollar.

Crude oil prices remain elevated amid back-and-forth strikes by the US and Iran across West Asia. Renewed threats to the Strait of Hormuz have shredded the interim deal to end the Iran war and could tip the region back into all-out war.

The dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading marginally up by 0.02 per cent at 100.50. PTI

Gold steady for 2nd day, silver falls to ₹2,24,500/kg

NEW DELHI: Gold prices stayed steady for the second straight session at Rs 1,46,300 per 10 grams in the national capital on Thursday, while silver declined Rs 1,500 amid subdued global trends.

The yellow metal of 99.9 per cent purity traded flat at Rs 1,46,300 per 10 grams, according to the All India Sarafa Association.

However, silver remained under pressure for the fourth consecutive session, declining Rs 1,500 to hit an over two-week low of Rs 2,24,500 per kilogram from Wednesday's closing level of Rs 2,26,000 per kg.

The white metal was last quoted around these levels on June 29, when it traded at Rs 2,24,000 per kg.

It has fallen Rs 12,500, or 5.3 per cent, in the last four sessions, from Rs 2,37,000 per kg recorded on July 10.

Traders said gold continued to move in a narrow range on balanced local demand, while silver remained under pressure due to sustained profit-booking and subdued industrial buying.

In the global markets, spot gold slipped $29.54, or nearly 1 per cent, to trade at $4,030.84 per ounce, while silver declined 1.7 per cent to $56.79 per ounce. PTI

BHEL posts net profit of ₹376.71 crore in Q1

NEW DELHI: State-owned BHEL on Thursday posted a consolidated net profit of Rs 376.71 crore in the June quarter, supported by increased income.

It had clocked a loss of Rs 455.50 crore in the corresponding first quarter of the preceding 2025-26 fiscal, the company said in an exchange filing.

During April-June, the company's total income rose to Rs 7,911.86 crore from Rs 5,658.07 crore in the year-ago period.

In Q1FY27, BHEL expenses stood at Rs 7,415.62 crore as against Rs 6,269.78 crore in the same quarter a year ago.

The major share of revenues (Rs 5,919.50 crore) came in from the power segment, higher from Rs 3,898.86 crore a year ago.

BHEL is one of the largest engineering and manufacturing companies of its kind in India engaged in design, engineering, construction, testing, commissioning and servicing of a wide range of products and services with over 180 product offerings to meet the ever-growing needs of the core sectors of the economy. PTI

It had clocked a loss of Rs 455.50 crore in first quarter of the preceding FY26

RBI bars banks from selling back immovable assets to borrowers

MUMBAI: The RBI on Thursday said a bank which has acquired an immovable asset in an exceptional case as part of a recovery process cannot sell it back to the borrower or related parties. Regulated entities (banks), in normal course, are not expected to come into possession of non-financial assets in lieu of their regular lending operations.

However, in exceptional cases, where the exposures become non-performing and legal or contractual remedies have been invoked, regulated entities may, as part of a recovery strategy, acquire ownership of an immovable asset furnished as collateral security.

In order to provide clarity on the prudential treatment of such specified non-financial assets, including non-banking assets, acquired by a bank through various mechanisms, the RBI has issued prudential norms.

"A bank shall dispose of the specified non-financial asset within the maximum period of disposal as envisaged in the bank's policy, subject to a maximum period of seven years," the central bank said, adding that the lender should make all efforts to dispose of the specified non-financial asset at the earliest through a public auction.

Earlier in May, the RBI had issued draft norms in this regard for stakeholder feedback.

One of the pieces of feedback was that borrowers may be allowed to buy back the property. "This could create moral hazard and dilute credit discipline by allowing defaulting borrowers a preferential opportunity to regain the asset," the RBI said while not agreeing with the suggestion.

On valuation of such assets, the RBI (Commercial Banks – Resolution of Stressed Assets) Third Amendment Directions, 2026 said that upon acquisition, specified non-financial assets should be recorded in the balance sheet at the lower of the net book value of the extinguished exposure or the distress sale value arrived at by at least two independent external valuers.

Further, specified non-financial assets (SNFA) put to the bank's own use should cease to be classified as an SNFA from the date of being put to use and shall be recorded under the accounting head 'fixed assets' or under any other relevant accounting head. The directions will come into force with effect from October 1, 2026. PTI

RBI's financial inclusion index rises 4.48% in FY26

MUMBAI: Reserve Bank's FI-Index, which captures the extent of financial inclusion in the country, rose 4.48 per cent during the year ending March 2026, the central bank said on Thursday.

The Reserve Bank of India had constructed a composite Financial Inclusion Index (FI-Index) in consultation with concerned stakeholders, including the government. The annual index was first published in August 2021 for the fiscal year ending March 2021.

"Index for the year ending March 2026 has since been compiled. The value of FI-Index for March 2026 stands at 70.0 vis-à-vis 67.0 in March 2025, with growth witnessed across all sub-indices," the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) said.

The improvement in the FI-Index this year is mainly on account of an uptick in usage, reflecting the deepening of financial inclusion, it added.

The FI-Index has been conceptualised as a comprehensive index incorporating details of banking, investments, insurance, postal, as well as the pension sector, in consultation with the government and respective sectoral regulators.

It captures information on various aspects of financial inclusion in a single value ranging between 0 and 100, where 0 represents complete financial exclusion, and 100 indicates full financial inclusion.

The index comprises three broad parameters — Access (35 per cent), Usage (45 per cent), and Quality (20 per cent), with each of these consisting of various dimensions, which are computed based on a number of indicators. PTI

'India's Grade A industrial, warehousing supply to reach 45-50 mn sq ft by end-2026'

Delhi NCR & Chennai drive over 45% of demand during H1 2026

NEW DELHI: India's Grade A industrial and warehousing supply is likely to reach 45-50 million square feet by the end of 2026, supported by a strong development pipeline and positive investor sentiment, according to a Colliers report.

The report said infrastructure-led development and expanding domestic manufacturing are expected to support demand for industrial and warehousing space through 2026.

"Looking ahead, a strong development pipeline and upbeat investor sentiment are expected to drive Grade A supply to 45-50 million sq ft by the end of 2026," said Vimal Nadar, National Director and Head of Research, Colliers India. He said developers remain confident about the sector's long-term growth despite global uncertainties.

According to the report, industrial and warehousing demand remained strong in the first half (H1) of 2026, with leasing across the top eight cities rising 12 per cent year-on-year to nearly 22 million square feet. Delhi NCR and Chennai together accounted for over 45 per cent of the total demand during the period.

The report said leasing in the second quarter stood at around 11 million square feet, down 1 per cent from the previous quarter due to supply chain disruptions caused by the ongoing conflict in West Asia. However, it added that demand is likely to improve in the coming quarters if global volatility remains limited.

Third-party logistics (3PL) companies remained the largest occupiers during H1 2026, accounting for 30 per cent of total leasing.

Engineering firms followed with a 21 per cent share, while e-commerce companies accounted for 16 per cent. The electronics segment also recorded nearly two-fold annual growth, indicating growing diversification in demand.

On the supply side, new completions rose 27 per cent year-on-year to about 25 million square feet during H1 2026, exceeding demand. Delhi NCR and Mumbai together accounted for more than 40 per cent of the new supply. Overall vacancy levels increased to 17.2 per cent as supply outpaced absorption. ANI

Jharkhand's bamboo-steel bottles, mugs draw crowds at Bharat Tex

NEW DELHI/RANCHI: The Jharkhand Pavilion continued to draw strong footfall on the third day of Bharat Tex 2026, being held from July 14–17 at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi. Among the standout attractions are the bamboo-steel insulated bottles and mugs developed by the Anjeneya Bamboo Cluster of Baharagora, East Singhbhum, which have generated significant interest among buyers, industry professionals and trade visitors for their blend of sustainability, functionality and contemporary design.

The eco-friendly bamboo and stainless-steel bottle keeps beverages hot or cold for 12–14 hours, while the bamboo-steel mug, fitted with a food-grade plastic lid, maintains temperature for 3–4 hours. Combining natural bamboo with modern insulation technology, the products offer a sustainable alternative to conventional drinkware and have been widely appreciated by visitors at the exhibition.

The participation of the Anjeneya Bamboo Cluster reflects Jharkhand's commitment to promoting 'Local to Global' by showcasing the state's traditional craftsmanship through innovative, market-ready products.

Alongside Tassar silk, GI-tagged products, handloom and handicrafts, bamboo-based innovations are helping position Jharkhand as an emerging hub for sustainable and value-added products in global markets.

The cluster is also leveraging advanced manufacturing capabilities, including laser cutting, laser engraving, CNC routing and customized design solutions, to create internationally competitive bamboo décor, furniture & lifestyle products. MPOST

Higher oil imports drive widening trade deficit despite resilient exports: Equirus Securities

Research says oil imports remain the principal driver of the wider trade deficit, while electronics exports continue to outperform

NEW DELHI: India's widening merchandise trade deficit in June reflects an import-led expansion rather than weakening export competitiveness, with higher oil imports accounting for nearly half of the monthly deficit, according to an analysis by Equirus Securities.

The research notes that merchandise exports remained healthy during June, but imports continued to outpace exports. Merchandise exports rose 15.5 per cent year-on-year to $40.4 billion, while imports increased 31 per cent to $70.8 billion, widening the merchandise trade deficit to $30.4 billion from $28.2 billion in May and $19.1 billion a year ago. During the first quarter of FY27, the merchandise trade deficit reached $86.8 billion, around 28 per cent higher than the corresponding period last year, as stronger domestic demand and commodity price pressures kept imports elevated.

According to the report, petroleum imports remained the principal driver of the wider trade deficit. Petroleum, Oil and Lubricants (POL) imports increased 40 per cent year-on-year to $19.3 billion, while the net oil deficit rose 55 per cent to $14.4 billion, contributing nearly half of the merchandise trade deficit in June. Fertiliser imports also increased sharply ahead of the Kharif season, reflecting stronger demand and higher global fertiliser input prices.

Gold imports moderated to $2.0 billion, declining 42 per cent month-on-month as both global prices and demand softened. After adjusting for the correction in gold prices, implied import volumes contracted by around 35 per cent during the month.

However, the non-oil, non-gold trade deficit widened to $14.0 billion, up 77 per cent year-on-year, indicating that underlying consumption and re-export demand remained firm.

The report identifies electronics as one of the strongest performing export categories during the month. Engineering goods exports increased 20.7 per cent year-on-year, gems and jewellery exports rose 34.6 per cent, chemicals exports grew 19.4 per cent and electronics exports increased 18.9 per cent. According to Equirus Securities, India's position as the chosen substitute to China in the electronics supply chain continues to strengthen. Readymade garment exports, however, declined 11.3 per cent year-on-year and continued to face the impact of disruptions across GCC markets, which account for around 11 per cent of India's apparel exports.

The research also notes that the services cushion is moderating. The services surplus eased to $15.1 billion in June from $21.5 billion in January 2026. Services exports grew by around 3 per cent during June and declined 1 per cent sequentially, while average services export growth during the first quarter of FY27 moderated to 6 per cent from 10 per cent in the corresponding period last year.

On the geographical front, exports to the United States remained broadly flat during the first quarter of FY27, while exports to Vietnam, China and Indonesia recorded strong growth. According to the report, the spillover from the West Asia crisis remained evident, with exports to Iran, Kuwait and Qatar declining sharply, while exports to the UAE and the Netherlands, both important re-export hubs, also moderated. The report notes that the shift towards Asian markets is increasingly being driven by manufacturing exports, including smartphones to China, engineering products to Vietnam and pharmaceuticals to Indonesia.

Looking ahead, Equirus Securities believes that lower global crude prices could reduce pressure on the oil import bill if prices remain around current levels. Softer gold imports could provide additional support. MPOST

CLOSER LOOK

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- Fertiliser imports also increased sharply ahead of the Kharif season, reflecting stronger demand and higher global fertiliser input prices
- However, the non-oil, non-gold trade deficit widened to $14.0 billion, up 77 per cent year-on-year

India-UK CETA: 1st zero-duty coffee, jewellery shipments reach UK shores

'A few consignments have already arrived under CETA, which basically covers about 99% of all tariff lines under which India exports to the UK'

LONDON: The first zero-duty consignments of Indian jewellery and coffee have landed in the UK following the implementation of the landmark India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA).

The pact came into force on July 15.

The India-UK CETA was celebrated at the High Commission of India in London with a display of some of the key products already reaping the benefits of the low or no-tariff regime under the India-UK free trade agreement (FTA).

"A few consignments have already arrived under the CETA, which basically covers about 99 per cent of all the tariff lines under which India exports to the UK, and therefore we expect that the benefits will be significant," said P Kumaran, the Indian High Commissioner to the UK.

Nysa Creations, a London-based importer of jewellery, and Odisha's Kruti Coffee, which is set to launch its first UK cafe soon, were among the businesses proudly displaying their products that are set to benefit from CETA.

'We expect to double India-UK trade in goods and services, which is currently about 65 billion dollars, up to 100 billion dollars in the next four years by 2030,' said P Kumaran, the Indian High Commissioner to the UK

"We expect to double India-UK trade in goods and services, which is currently about 65 billion dollars, up to 100 billion dollars in the next four years by 2030; and CETA is expected to play a huge role in promoting greater awareness of the opportunities and also to help our businesses compete more effectively in each other's markets.

"We think that this will help promote the strength of industries, manufacturing ecosystems on both sides, the ability for both to generate more employment and therefore provide larger benefits to societies in both countries," Kumaran said.

The agreement's entry into force (EIF) was marked with a special "CETA EIF" cake-cutting ceremony alongside officials from the UK's Department for Business and Trade (DBT).

It also witnessed the formal launch of a new Indian High Commission LinkedIn social media facilitation forum, which will serve as a dedicated platform to help businesses, exporters, importers and investors leverage its full benefits.

"It is a milestone moment for Kruti Retail Ventures as our coffee consignment is the first Indian coffee consignment to the UK under CETA, despatched from Kolkata for the opening of our first international cafe in London on August 1," said co-founder Jeeta Mona, who presented a symbolic Kruti Coffee tin to officials at India House.

According to DBT estimates, CETA is forecast to increase bilateral trade by 25.5 billion pounds annually in the long run, while boosting India's GDP by 5.1 billion pounds and the UK's GDP by 4.8 billion pounds by strengthening supply chains, supporting jobs and opening new opportunities for businesses across both countries.

The event also spotlighted a toolkit collated by the Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FICCI) as a guide for Indian businesses navigating the post-CETA trading regime in the UK.

'India-UK CETA: A Guide to UK Import Requirements for Indian Exporters' consolidates information on key UK standards and regulatory requirements to support India's small and medium enterprises (SMEs) with their expansion plans in Britain. AGENCIES

Highlights

- 'CETA is expected to play a huge role in promoting greater awareness of opportunities & help our businesses compete more effectively'
- 'According to DBT estimates, CETA is forecast to increase bilateral trade by 25.5 billion pounds annually in the long run'
- 'It will boost India's GDP by 5.1 billion pounds & UK's GDP by 4.8 billion pounds by strengthening supply chains, supporting jobs'

CBDT launches AIS feature to help taxpayers report foreign assets

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: To improve services for taxpayers and to encourage voluntary tax compliance, the Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) has introduced a new feature that allows eligible taxpayers to view information on their foreign assets and income through the Annual Information Statement (AIS) available on the Income Tax Department's e-Filing portal.

As per reports from government sources, the program has been initiated as a way of facilitating taxpayers so that they can provide accurate information about their foreign assets and income while filing tax returns. The government said that this facility would help taxpayers fulfil their obligations, but it would not be a scrutiny process for them.

Financial account details regarding India's tax residents are provided to India by more than 100 partner countries under the Automatic Exchange of Information (AEOI) arrangement and other international agreements regarding the exchange of financial information. Each year, details of the past year begin flowing to the Income Tax Department from September onwards.

According to government officials, the AIS presently has foreign asset and income details of Calendar Years 2022, 2023, and 2024. Details for Calendar Year 2025 are supposed to be disclosed after receiving them from partner countries from September to October 2026.

'The program has been initiated as a way to facilitate taxpayers so that they can provide accurate information about their foreign assets, income while filing tax returns'

The information to be shared as part of the AEOI can include particulars of foreign bank accounts, custodian accounts, financial investments, interest income, dividends, and other specified financial income reported in partner countries on an internationally recognised standard of information exchange.

Nonetheless, it is important to note that the information available on the AIS is not comprehensive and is only information obtained by the Income Tax Department through international exchange mechanisms. Taxpayers should still be accountable for providing complete and accurate information about their foreign assets and income from foreign sources in the Schedules FA and FSI of their Income Tax Return forms, regardless of the information available on the AIS.

Sources from the government mentioned that this facility makes it possible for taxpayers to view the information in a secure manner by logging into their own e-Filing accounts and reaching the AIS section via the Compliance Portal. This can be done by viewing the information in the "Foreign Assets Information" report and downloading the same in PDF format for the concerned year. Viewing of such information is limited to only the taxpayer concerned in a secure manner.

As part of the launch, the Income Tax Department has started sending SMS and email alerts to the taxpayers regarding this service. They have been informed about the importance of declaring foreign assets and foreign-sourced income in case of need, when filing Income Tax Returns for Assessment Year 2026-27.

The CBDT has also motivated taxpayers to seek assistance from "Kar Saathi," an AI-driven virtual assistant provided by the Department at the e-Filing website for assistance in choosing the correct return form, understanding their reporting obligations regarding foreign assets and income and for any tax-related help.

Government sources say that this is part of a larger plan by the CBDT to utilise technology for delivery of taxpayer-centric services and to ensure voluntary compliance using non-intrusive means. With timely provision of information which is already available with the Department to taxpayers, the government aims to avoid reporting mistakes and enhance the ease of filing income tax returns.

I-T dept raises Cost Inflation Index to 384 for FY27

NEW DELHI: The income tax department has increased the Cost Inflation Index for the current fiscal for calculating long-term capital gains arising from the sale of immovable property, securities and jewellery.

The Cost Inflation Index (CII) is used by taxpayers to calculate gains from the sale of capital assets after adjusting inflation.

The Cost Inflation Index for FY 2026-27 is 384, as per a notification of the Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT).

The CII for fiscal 2025-26 was 376.

AMRG Global Managing Partner Rajat Mohan said the annual notification of the Cost Inflation Index reflects the government's commitment to maintaining an objective inflation-adjustment mechanism wherever indexation benefits continue under the new tax framework.

It provides taxpayers, valuers and tax professionals with clarity for computing the indexed cost and reduces interpretational disputes, Mohan added.

CII or Cost Inflation Index is notified under the Income-tax Act, 1961 every year.

It is popularly used to calculate "indexed cost of acquisition" while calculating capital gains at the time of sale of any capital asset. PTI

Tech Mahindra June quarter net profit rises 28.4% to ₹1,465 crore

NEW DELHI: IT company Tech Mahindra on Thursday reported a 28.4 per cent rise in consolidated net profit for the June quarter at Rs 1,465 crore, and expressed confidence about the demand environment.

India's fifth-largest IT services firm said growth in the June quarter was broad-based, led by manufacturing and financial services, with strong momentum also in healthcare and retail.

Tech Mahindra management expressed confidence about a "sustained" performance through the rest of the year, provided the macroeconomic situation does not change dramatically.

The company said its strong order book, long-standing client relationships and robust

first-quarter performance give it confidence in sustaining growth through the remainder of the year and outperforming the peer average.

Tech Mahindra's revenue from operations was up 17.7 per cent at about Rs 15,712 crore during the quarter just ended.

In dollar terms, the Q1FY27 revenue at $1,660 million came in 2.2 per cent higher sequentially and was up 6.1 per cent on a year-on-year basis in reported terms.

"We have delivered an extremely strong quarter, clearly industry-leading growth, way ahead of our consensus estimates. So clearly, we're seeing a positive demand environment from the company perspective...all the hard work that has gone into capability building, hiring talent, winning new clients, winning in consolidation deals is paying off for us," Mohit Joshi, CEO and Managing Director, Tech Mahindra, said during Q1 results briefing.

Tech Mahindra cited the three-year turnaround plan it had presented in April 2024 with clear goals and measurable markers for success and said it is seeing increased benefits of investments and actions taken over the past years. PTI

ITC Hotels Q1 net up 36% to ₹181.91 crore, to acquire GHK Hospitality & Infra at ₹155 crore

NEW DELHI: ITC Hotels Ltd on Thursday reported a 36 per cent rise in consolidated net profit to Rs 181.91 crore in the first quarter ended June 30, 2026, amid the West Asia conflict-led disruptions casting their shadow on the Indian hospitality sector.

The company, which posted a consolidated net profit of Rs 133.71 crore in the corresponding period of the last fiscal, said its board has approved the acquisition of GHK Hospitality & Infrastructures Ltd at an enterprise value of Rs 155 crore.

Consolidated revenue from operations in the first quarter stood at Rs 936.02 crore as compared to Rs 815.54 crore in the year-ago period, ITC Hotels Ltd said in a regulatory filing.

Total expenses in the first quarter were higher at Rs 750 crore, compared with Rs 674.9 crore in the same period a year ago, the company said.

During the quarter under review, the hotel business clocked revenue of Rs 881.06 crore as compared to Rs 800.57 crore in the year-ago period, while the new branded residences vertical clocked a revenue of Rs 37.77 crore, it added.

Room revenue grew 8 per cent YoY led by strong performance in the retail segment, offsetting the high base effect in the MICE and Weddings segments in the previous year, the company said.

India's hospitality sector entered Q1 FY27 under the shadow of West Asia conflict-led disruptions. April witnessed broad-based demand softness across key markets, driven by uncertainty around air travel, as reflected in weak foreign tourist arrivals.

As travel sentiment improved, occupancy and room rates witnessed a swift recovery in May and June '26, underscoring the structural resilience of the demand environment, the company said.

On the acquisition of GHK Hospitality & Infrastructures, ITC Hotels said the transaction would allow it to expand its owned-asset portfolio in Ahmedabad across all market segments through an established hotel currently operated by it under an operating services agreement.

GHK owns a hotel, 'Welcomhotel Ahmedabad', with 130 keys located along Ahmedabad's prominent Ashram Road, overlooking the scenic Sabarmati Riverfront, the company said.

"The acquisition of this hotel will mark another milestone in pursuit of the company's growth aspiration by adding another owned property in one of the fastest growing urban centres of India," ITC Hotels Ltd Managing Director, Anil Chadha said.

He further said, "Transitioning this established 130-room property from a managed contract to full ownership allows us to unlock greater value from the asset." Ahmedabad continues to be one of India's most dynamic commercial and industrial centres, supported by significant infrastructure investments, strong long-term demand fundamentals, and a diversified demand base, Chadha said. PTI

Wipro Q1 net profit nearly flat at ₹3,352 cr, flags resilient but uncertain macro environment

NEW DELHI: IT major Wipro on Thursday reported almost flat consolidated net profit of Rs 3,352 crore in the April-June quarter of FY27, in a macro environment described by the management as "resilient" but marked by uncertainties influencing client decisions.

Its revenue from operations grew 10.6 per cent to Rs 24,478.6 crore in Q1 FY27 from Rs 22,134.6 crore in Q1 FY26.

Sequentially, the profit declined 4.2 per cent while revenue inched up marginally by 1 per cent.

"The macro environment remains resilient. But of course, there are uncertainties which continue to shape decision-making for our clients. Technol-

ogy investments, however, have not slowed. They have become more focused. Spending today is measured with more rigour and longer decision cycles.

"As the landscape evolves, clients are focused on net productivity and require a tighter linkage between their investments and their outcomes. Despite selective client spending, our pipeline remains healthy. We continue to see strong engagement across our markets and industries," Wipro CEO and MD Srini Pallia said.

The company's revenue from the flagship IT services segment stood at $2,614.5 million during the quarter under review, marking a 1 per cent rise year-on-year but a 1.4 per cent decline sequentially.

For the second quarter ending September 30, 2026, Wipro expects its IT services revenue to be in the range of $2,574-2,627 million. This translates to a sequential guidance of -1.5 per cent to +0.5 per cent in constant currency terms.

Total bookings for the April-June quarter stood at $3,370 million. Large deal bookings reached $1,626 million, registering a 12.9 per cent sequential growth in constant currency, driven by 13 large deal wins.

The management highlighted that the Banking, Financial Services and Insurance (BFSI) sector is seeing good momentum in the Americas, while the Energy, Manufacturing, and Resources (EMR) space remains a "tough spot".

The IT services operating margin for the first quarter contracted to 16 per cent.

Chief Financial Officer Aparna Iyer attributed this 1.2 per cent year-on-year decline to the incremental impact of salary increases effective March 1, 2026, alongside ongoing investments in AI. Pallia termed the margin dip "short-term volatility". PTI

NSE to launch derivatives on Nifty India FPI 150 Index from August 12

NEW DELHI: The National Stock Exchange (NSE) on Thursday said it plans to launch derivatives contracts on the Nifty India FPI 150 Index from August 12 after receiving approval from capital markets regulator Sebi.

In a statement, the exchange said it will introduce futures and options contracts on the index in the equity derivatives segment.

Initially, the NSE will offer three serial monthly index futures and index options contract cycles.

The cash-settled contracts will expire on the last Tuesday of the expiry month.

The Nifty India FPI 150 Index tracks the performance

of the top 150 stocks selected from the Nifty 500 based on six-month average foreign investible free-float market capitalisation. The index is designed to ensure accessibility and investability for foreign investors.

The weight of each constituent is determined by its foreign investible free-float market capitalisation.

As of June 2026, the financial services sector had the highest weight in the index at 26.15 per cent, followed by oil, gas and consumable fuels at 10.03 per cent and healthcare at 7.51 per cent.

The index was launched on August 16, 2025, with a base date of October 3, 2022, and a base value of 1,000. It is rebalanced every quarter based on foreign investible free-float methodology.

NSE Chief Business Development Officer Sriram Krishnan said the launch of derivatives on the Nifty India FPI 150 Index will complement the exchange's existing index derivatives product suite. PTI

Jio Financial Services Q1 profit more than doubles to ₹830 crore

NEW DELHI: Jio Financial Services Ltd (JFSL) on Thursday reported more than twofold jump in consolidated net profit to Rs 830 crore in the first quarter ended June 2026. The company had earned a consolidated net profit of Rs 325 crore in the same quarter a year ago.

The company's total income rose more than three times to Rs 2,005 crore as against Rs 619 crore in the June quarter of the previous year, JFSL said in a regulatory filing.

Interest income expanded to Rs 962 crore as compared to Rs 363 crore in the same period a year ago.

Total expenses increased to Rs 1,016 crore from Rs 261 crore in the same quarter of last year.

Jio Financial Services, carved out from Reliance Industries Ltd, is engaged in the business of investing and financing, insurance broking, payment bank and payment aggregator and payment gateway services.

Its subsidiaries Jio Payments Bank Limited and Jio Payment Solutions Limited achieved operational turnaround in Q1 FY27.

Another arm Allianz Jio Reinsurance Ltd establishes initial market footprint, with Rs 266 crore in gross written premiums during its first full quarter of operations.

Jio Insurance Broking Limited, the other subsidiary, facilitated premium of Rs 238 crore, up 1.6 times over the same quarter a year ago, it said. NBFC arm Jio Credit Ltd's Assets Under Management (AUM) rose to Rs 30,667 crore, up 2.6 times on an annual basis. PTI

Paytm board to consider maiden bonus issue on July 20

'The board will decide the bonus issue ratio and record date, subject to necessary approvals'

NEW DELHI: One 97 Communications Ltd, the parent of digital payments platform Paytm, will consider its first-ever bonus share issue as its board meets on July 20 to approve the proposal alongside the company's June quarter (Q1 FY27) results.

The board will decide the bonus issue ratio and record date, subject to necessary approvals, the company said in a stock exchange filing on Wednesday.

The proposed bonus issue follows a landmark FY26 for Paytm, which reported its first full-year profit after tax of Rs 552 crore, compared with a loss of Rs 663 crore in the previous fiscal. EBITDA also turned positive at Rs 502 crore from a loss of Rs 1,506 crore a year earlier.

A bonus issue, which grants additional shares to existing shareholders in proportion to their holdings, is generally seen as a sign of confidence in a company's financial strength and future growth. It could also improve affordability for retail investors, as Paytm shares have largely traded above Rs 1,000 and touched a 52-week high this month.

Unlike dividends or share buybacks, a bonus issue does not require cash outflow, allowing the company to retain its cash balance of Rs 13,315 crore for future expansion.

Paytm's turnaround came despite challenges, including the winding down of Paytm Payments Bank and the withdrawal of government incentives.

Analysts say regulatory concerns have also eased, with Goldman Sachs recently describing the regulatory environment as stable.

In FY26, revenue rose 22 per cent to Rs 8,437 crore. Merchant payment GMV increased 27 per cent year-on-year to Rs 6.5 lakh crore in the March quarter, while consumer UPI transaction value grew 46 per cent.

Revenue from financial services distribution climbed 52 per cent to Rs 2,593 crore, supported by lower indirect expenses and continued investments in artificial intelligence.

Management expects FY27 revenue growth to outpace FY26 while keeping expense growth under control. AGENCIES

CLOSER LOOK

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- The bonus issue could also improve affordability for retail investors, as Paytm shares have largely traded above Rs 1,000 and touched a 52-week high this month

FIFA World Cup final set with Messi facing Yamal for the title

Argentina seek its fourth title while Spain look for its second title, after winning in 2010

NEW YORK: The best offense. The best defense.

The World Cup final is set, and fittingly, a clash of styles awaits. Lionel Messi — the most prolific goal scorer in the tournament's history — and defending champion Argentina will take on Spain's defensive juggernaut on Sunday in East Rutherford, New Jersey.

Spain beat France in one semifinal on Tuesday; Argentina, the comeback king of this tournament, rallied to beat England 2-1 in the other semifinal on Wednesday.

Argentina is seeking its fourth title and is looking to become the first back-to-back World Cup champion since Brazil pulled off the feat in 1958 and 1962. Spain is looking for its second title, after winning in 2010.

Argentina leads the tournament in goals scored — 19.

Spain leads the tournament in fewest goals allowed — one.

Something will have to give on Sunday, when the biggest World Cup ever — a 48-team, 104-match extravaganza spread out over the U.S., Canada and Mexico — comes to an end.

It's not Finalissima. It's going to be better.

South American champion Argentina and European champion Spain were supposed to meet in Doha, Qatar, in late March in Finalissima, a showdown between the teams led by Messi and Lamine Yamal in a prequel of the World Cup.

That game never happened. Security became an issue because of unrest in the Middle East, with Iran intensifying its attacks on neighboring countries at that time in retaliation to the aerial attacks by United States and Israel in a war that is still ongoing. The game was called off.

So, instead of playing at Lusail Stadium, the site of the epic 2022 World Cup final where Messi and Argentina won on penalty kicks over France and Kylian Mbappé, they'll play just outside of New York in soccer's biggest game.

It'll be a showdown of soccer's present versus soccer's future, not to mention a showdown of the teams that held the top two spots in FIFA's world rankings entering the World Cup — Argentina at No. 1, Spain at No. 2. AGENCIES

Argentina's Lionel Messi (10) celebrates after their win in the World Cup semifinal football match AP/PTI

Spain's Lamine Yamal (19) controls the ball during the World Cup quarter-final match between Spain and Belgium AP/PTI

Streaking

Both teams enter the final with impressive unbeaten streaks

SPAIN is carrying a 37-match unbeaten streak across all competitions and friendlies into the final, having won 28 of those matches with nine draws. Its last loss was 1-0 to Colombia in March 2024.

ARGENTINA is unbeaten in its last 13 World Cup matches, with 11 victories and two draws since falling to Saudi Arabia to open group play at the 2022 tournament.

	Record	Goals	Goals against	Group stage	Knockout stage
Spain	Six wins, one draw, zero losses	13	1	Drew with Cape Verde 0-0, beat Saudi Arabia 4-0, beat Uruguay 1-0	Beat Austria 3-0, beat Portugal 1-0, beat Belgium 2-1, beat France 2-0.
Argentina	Seven wins, zero draws, zero losses	19	7	Beat Algeria 3-0, beat Austria 2-0, beat Jordan 3-1	Beat Cape Verde 3-2, beat Egypt 3-2, beat Switzerland 3-1, beat England 2-1.

Indian selectors unlikely to pick Rohit beyond Lord's ODI

NEW DELHI: The third ODI between India and England at Lord's on Sunday could be Rohit Sharma's final game in international cricket with the national selection committee unlikely to pick the white-ball great beyond the ongoing series in the UK.

In the last eight ODIs, Rohit has totalled only 241 runs at an average of 30.1 and a strike-rate of 88.6 with one half-century.

Chairman of selectors Ajit Agarkar is in Cardiff as the touring selector and it is pretty clear that they are not looking at the 39-year-old double ICC trophy winning India skipper for the next year's ODI World Cup.

"The national selectors are keen that Yashasvi Jaiswal who scored two hundreds in three innings get a longer rope. There are around 20 games and Jaiswal needs to be given those 20 games.

"No one can tell Rohit to retire but this is very clear that going forward for the home series vs West Indies in September, the selectors would like to look forward. Rohit's future is a decision that he needs to take," a senior BCCI source privy to selection matters told PTI on conditions of anonymity. It must be mentioned that head coach Gautam Gambhir and Agarkar are on the same page that Virat Kohli is an automatic choice given his form and fitness but not Rohit.

It is understood that if Rohit is persisted with beyond England, then there is no way that Jaiswal, the next in queue, would miss out on a precious game time.

While the sources close to selection committee maintained that they didn't want Rohit to decide after playing two of the five Tests in England, those who are privy to Rohit's version vouched that he never intended to play only two games and had made himself available for the whole series. AGENCIES

Rohit Sharma

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Changes to WC formats make sense but associate teams need more: Ashwin

The 2027 ODI World Cup will be a three-stage competition

NEW DELHI: Indian spin great R Ashwin on Thursday said the structural changes made to the ODI and T20 World Cup formats to include more teams make sense but for the game to become truly global, the ICC needs to add the lower rung sides into every bilateral series.

Following the revamp announced by the ICC on Wednesday, the 2027 ODI World Cup will be a three-stage competition and the 2028 T20 World Cup's Super 8 phase will be expanded to accommodate 10 teams to achieve "greater context and consequence".

Ashwin said the world body is planning in the right direction but needs to do more.

"The ICC's changes to the fixture format for the 2027 ODI World Cup and 2028 T20 World Cup make sense from a competitiveness standpoint. But if the final goal is to grow the game, there needs to be a stronger pathway for emerging nations," Ashwin posted on 'X'.

"Teams like the Netherlands, Scotland, Nepal, USA and Ireland need more meaningful matches (FOR EXAMPLE: getting added as the third team into every bilateral series), not just qualification tournaments.

"Let's not forget, that collective growth will make this sport a spectacle at the Olympics," he added. AGENCIES

Indian bowler R Ashwin

Mithali backs Smriti for ODI captaincy, Shafali for T20

NEW DELHI: Smriti Mandhana is more suited to lead India in the longer formats after Harmanpreet Kaur's tenure ends while the much younger Shafali Varma can be handed the reins of the T20 side following another pre-mature exit from the World Cup, former captain legendary Mithali Raj said. Harmanpreet, 37, led India to a pathbreaking ODI World Cup title last year but under her leadership, the team has not been able to crack the code in ICC events in the T20 format, dating back to 2018.

The selectors may finally move on from her following the Asian Games in Japan in September-October.

In an interview with PTI, women's cricket icon Mithali said time has come to groom more leaders in the national set up, she also wants more clarity over players' roles in the side and improvement in the fitness department that is adversely impacting India's pace attack and fielding, which was way below par in the recent T20 World Cup.

"Yes, we did not qualify for the semifinals for the second time in a row but that cannot be the only reason or criteria to come to conclusion that you need to change the leader. Because I believe that there are few boxes that one need to actually see if the player ticks those boxes.

"One is, of course, the fitness, I feel is very important. Harman in the last two, three years, you see the physio quite often on the ground, every game, when she's playing, there are few games that she was unavailable. So, you obviously would want your captain to be fit and available for all games. And unfortunately, all of us age, so she's not the fittest," said Mithali. AGENCIES

Harshit's fitness under scanner post injury

NEW DELHI: Harshit Rana's hamstring injury in his first series after coming back from a knee surgery has raised concerns over his fitness regimen as top sources revealed that the burly fast bowler gained weight during his rehabilitation which probably contributed to the latest breakdown.

According to sources, the 24-year-old Rana was found to be "overweight" on his comeback for the T20I leg of the UK tour and was eventually ruled out due to the hamstring injury after playing just five T20 games -- two versus Ireland and three against England. AGENCIES

STUNS WORLD NO. 5

Sindhu enters Japan Open quarterfinals

TOKYO: Two-time Olympic medallist PV Sindhu produced one of her best performances of the season to outclass world No. 5 Han Yue of China in straight games and storm into the quarterfinals of the Japan Open Super 750 badminton tournament here on Thursday.

The world No. 10 Indian needed just 35 minutes to register a commanding 21-16, 21-14 win over the higher-ranked Chinese shuttler in their second-round contest.

After a sluggish start, the unseeded Sindhu found her rhythm midway through the opening game.

The former world champion then completely dominated the second game, racing to an 8-0 advantage before comfortably sealing the contest.

With the victory, Sindhu improved her head-to-head record against Han to 8-1.

The 31-year-old will next face familiar rival Nozomi Okuhara of Japan, who received a walkover after top seed An Se-young of South Korea withdrew from their second-round match.

Sindhu is now India's lone survivor in the tournament after the mixed doubles pair of Tanisha Crasto and Dhruv Kapila bowed out in the pre-quarterfinals.

The Indian duo fought hard before losing 20-22, 17-21 to top seeds Feng Yan Zhe and Huang Dong Ping of China in their round-of-16 clash in 47 minutes. AGENCIES

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Notice No.:NCR-PRYJ/FZD/COMM/EOI/2026 **Dated: 13.07.2026**

Expression of Interest (EOI)

Expression of interest from interested firms/agencies/proprietors for the participation in e-auction to setup, operation and maintenance of various type of commercial activities like Banquet/Event Management purpose, Food Park, Fun Park cum Gaming Zone, Turf Sports facilities and other Commercial activities, in proposed area situated in proposed area available of Closed Goods Shed near Firozabad Railway Station for a period of 15 Years.

Details of The Proposed EOI

Details of the Proposed Area.	**Assets Name**	Firozabad Railway Goods Shed
	Total Area	Approx 9000 SQMT
	Any Structure or Room	At present, five old structures exist in the area proposed for commercial utilization, comprising one room (4 x 4 sq. m), two covered sheds (19.70 x 11.20 sq. m and 26.70 x 9.70 sq. m), and two open sheds (56.00 x 11.20 sq. m and 23.70 x 9.70 sq. m). These structures were previously used for stacking/loading and unloading of goods.
	District	Firozabad
	State	Uttar Pradesh
	For ready reference, a Sketch Plan and some Photos of the proposed area is enclosed with the EOI as **Annexure-I.** **Removal of Existing Railway Assets:** Some Railway assets (Track, Junction Box etc.) are presently lying at the proposed site. The Railway shall remove/relocate these assets at its own cost prior to handing over the site to the successful Licensee.	
Proposed Scope of Work	interested firms/agencies/proprietors may utilize the proposed area for development and operation of various commercial activities such as:- ➢ **Banquet/Event Management Purpose** ➢ **Food Park,** ➢ **Fun Park cum Gaming Zone,** ➢ **Turf Sports facilities,** ➢ **Any other Commercial activities to be proposed by proponent/ licensee and approved by Railway,** **Subject to the following conditions:** **a)** The Licensee shall develop the proposed facilities only on a temporary basis using modern/modular construction. No permanent structure or permanent civil construction shall be erected or carried out by the Licensee, except for the boundary wall and flooring, which may be constructed as requirement or safety purpose on permanent basis with the prior approval of the Railway. **b)** From the perspective of asset protection and proper operation of the facility, the Licensee shall be permitted to execute only the boundary wall, flooring works, and toilet/bathroom facilities along with water storage facilities as permanent structures. Such permanent works shall be undertaken only after obtaining the prior written approval of the Railway, i.e., the Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager (Sr. DCM). **c)** The license for the proposed work shall be granted for a period of 15 (Fifteen) years. **d)** Water and electricity connections shall be provided by the Railways on a chargeable basis, as per applicable rules. The Licensee shall be permitted, at its own option, to obtain electricity and water connections from the local Civil Authority/Utility Service Provider. Wherever a No Objection Certificate (NOC) is required for obtaining such connections, the same shall be issued by the Railway.	
The total area proposed for commercial utilization is approximately: 9,000 Square Meter		
Tenure of the Proposed Work: 15 Years		
Last date and time for submission of EOI: On or before 28.07.2026 up to 15:00 hrs.		
Proposals can be submitted at the following address	**Email:sdcm@ald.railnet.gov.in** Hard copy to reach on or before 28.07.2026 up to 15:00 hrs at: Sr. DCM (Coaching), Prayagraj, Divisional Railway Manager's Office, North Central Railway, Nawab Yusuf Road, Civil Lines, Prayagraj-211001	
For the detailed notice and participation guidelines, please visit the official website or contact	**www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in.** or Interested applicants/firms/agencies/proprietors may visit the office of the Sr. DCM (Coaching), Divisional Railway Manager's Office, Prayagraj Division, Uttar Pradesh-211001, or contact the Chief Commercial Inspector at 7525001455/7525001449 for any queries or clarifications during working hours.	

Interested firms/agencies/proprietors for the participation in e-auction may submit the duly filled application along with complete information as required, in accordance with the EOI documents and attached documents.

Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager
North Central Railway, Prayagraj Division

1624/26(K)

North central railways | www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in | @CPRONCR

YAMUNA EXPRESSWAY INDUSTRIAL DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY

First Floor, Commercial Complex, P-2, Sector Omega-1, Greater Noida, Janpad Gautam Budh Nagar -201308 (U.P.)
Toll Free No. 18001808296, Website: www.yamunaexpresswayauthority.com

Reference N.: Y.E.A./ नियोजन /126/2026 **Date: 16.07.2026**

PUBLIC NOTICE

Environmental Clearance (EC) has been granted for the project **"Proposed Electronics Manufacturing Cluster (EMC) at Sector 10, YEIDA, Jewar, Gautam Budh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh" by Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority (YEIDA),** vide **EC Identification No. EC26B3813UP5958354N dated 22nd June 2026** issued by State Level Environment Impact Assessment Authority (SEIAA), Uttar Pradesh.

Copies of the Environment Clearance letter are available with MOEF&CC/SEIAA and may also be seen on the Ministry's portal https://parivesh.nic.in and YEIDA's Official Website.

Additional Chief Executive Officer
Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority

यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण के अधिसूचित क्षेत्र में प्राधिकरण द्वारा स्वीकृत मास्टर प्लॉन के अतिरिक्त प्लॉटिंग / हाउसिंग / कॉलोनी या किसी भी प्रकार का अन्य निर्माण पूरी तरह से अवैध है। सामान्यजन इस प्रकार की खरीदफरोख्त से पूर्णतः सचेत रहें तथा कॉलोनाइजर के भ्रामक विज्ञापनों से बचें। अधिक जानकारी के लिए प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट www.yamunaexpresswayauthority.com देखें।

NORTHERN RAILWAY

NOTICE FOR E-AUCTION

Senior Divisional Commercial Manager/FS, Delhi Division, Northern Railway, in terms of Railway Board letter no. 2022/TC(FM)/10/04 dated 13.06.2022, invites bids through e-Auction **(www.ireps.gov.in)** for the contract of Parking cum management of vehicles (as per their type and class as mentioned in the additional special conditions) and Stacking of Parcels at Hazrat Nizamuddin Railway Station (NZM) towards Sarai Kale Khan Side for total area measuring 4674.5 square meters is invited for a period of three (03) years through E-Auction in IREPS module as per detail and schedule given below:-

S. No.	Date & time of e-Auction	Assets to be auctioned
1.	22.07.2026 at 11:00 Hrs.	The contract of Parking cum management of vehicles (as per their type and class as mentioned in the additional special conditions) and Stacking of Parcels at Hazrat Nizamuddin Railway Station (NZM) towards Sarai Kale Khan Side is invited for total area measuring 4674.5 square meters for a period of three (03) years through E-Auction in IREPS module. Bifurcation of total proposed area measuring 4674.5 square meters (as per the site map uploaded) is as under: **1.** Near Relay Hut-2 with area measuring 213.39 square meters. **2.** At platform no. 8 Okhla end near parcel office with area measuring 1462.74 square meters. **3.** Area adjoining to PF-8 from loco gate to main entry/exit with area measuring 2998.37 square meters.

Important Notes:

1. For more information, requirement and various aspects regarding these e-Auctions, interested bidders are advised to visit **https://www.ireps.gov.in/html/helpdesk/learning_centre.html** (E-Auction leasing section).
2. **Earnest Money Deposit (EMD):** 10% of the total contractual bid value to be deposited online during the auction. EMD of the successful bidder will be retained as Security Deposit.
3. Railway Administration reserves the full and absolute rights to short terminate these contracts at any point of time and/or for taking any decision regarding the discontinuation/continuation of these contracts with modified/additional terms and conditions depending upon the situations.
4. Prospective bidders are advised, in their own interest, to visit Delhi Sarai Rohilla Station to analyse the scope of work before bidding.

2456/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

millenniumpost CLASSIFIEDS

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Asgar Ali S/o Laddan R/o 32/97, Gali No. 10, Bhikam Singh Colony, Vishwas Nagar, Shahdara, Delhi-110032 have changed my daughter's name Hiba Alvi in place of Hiba. Kindly consider my daughter's correct name as Hiba Alvi for all purposes in future.

I, Asgar Ali S/o Laddan R/o 32/97, Gali No. 10, Bhikam. Singh Colony, Vishwas Nagar, Shahdara, Delhi-110032 have changed my son's name Ateeb Alvi in place of Ateeb. Kindly consider my son's correct name as Ateeb Alvi for all purposes in future.

I, Aslam S/o Laddan R/o 32/97, Gali No. 10, Bhikam Singh Colony, Vishwas Nagar, Shahdara, Delhi-110032 have changed my daughter's name Aaliya Alvi in place of Aaliya. Kindly consider my daughter's correct name as Aaliya Alvi for all purposes in future.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Kushal S/o** Rajender Kumar **R/o** H. No. 64, Goyala Khurd Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 287/2021 U/s 25/54/59 ARMS Act PS: Paschim Vihar West, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Kushal** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Kushal** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Kushal** accused of **FIR No. 287/2021 U/s 25/54/59 ARMS Act PS: Paschim Vihar West, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **23.09.2026.**

By Order
Sh. Ankit Karan Singh
M M - 08, Room No. 30
Tis Hazari Courts New Delhi

DP/9763/OD/2026
(Court Matter)

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform all concerned that Ms. Pooja Singh (also known as Ms. Pooja Pratap Ujala, D/o Mr. Rudal Singh) is no longer associated with SUNO FOR LIFE and is not authorized to represent or conduct any business on its behalf, effective immediately.

Business Details:
Trade Name: SUNO FOR LIFE
Legal Name: Bhanu Pratap Ujala
GSTIN: 07AAMPU4590M1ZT

Any communication, commitment, transaction, or representation made by her in the name of SUNO FOR LIFE, including through the email addresses poojaujala@gmail.com and sunoforlife2024@gmail.com, shall not be binding on the organization. SUNO FOR LIFE shall not be responsible for any dealings conducted through these email addresses.

By Order,
Management
SUNO FOR LIFE, Saket, Delhi

पंजाब नैशनल बैंक .....भरोसे का प्रतीक (A GOVERNMENT OF INDIA UNDERTAKING) punjab national bank ...the name you can BANK upon!

ASSET RECOVERY MANAGEMENT BRANCH SOUTH DELHI, 4th FLOOR, 7 PNB HOUSE, BHIKAJI CAMA PLACE NEW DELHI-110066 EMAIL: cs4168@pnb.bank.in

SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8 (6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described immovable properties mortgaged /charged to the Secured Creditor, the constructive/physical/ symbolic possession of which has been taken by Authorized Officer of the Bank/Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is where is", " As is what is", and "Whatever there is" on the date as mentioned in the table herein below, for recovery of its dues due to the Bank/ Secured Creditor from the respective Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s). The reserve price and the earnest money deposit will be as mentioned in the table below against the respective properties

SCHEDULE OF SALE OF THE SECURED ASSETS

Sr. No.	Name of the Branch / Name of the Account / Name and Addresses of the Borrower/Guarantors Account	Description of the Immovable. Properties Mortgaged/ Owner's Name (mortgagers of property)	E) Dt. Of Demand Notice u/s 13(2) of SARFAESI ACT 2002 / F) Amount as per demand notice / G) Possession Date u/s 13(4) ofSARFAESI ACT 2002 / H) Nature of Possession Symbolic/Physical/Constructive	A) Reserve Price (Rs. in Lacs) / B) EMD / C) Bid Increase Amount	DATE/ TIME OF E-AUCTION	Details of the encumbrances known to the secured creditors	Name & Contact No. of Authorized Officer/ nodal Officer
1.	**PNB B/o ARMB Bhikajicama place** **Mr. Vinod Kumar Sharma S/o Late Sh. Devi Ram Sharma** H NO-53 Sri Nagar Colony Sindhora Kalan Ashok Vihar New Delhi-110052	**All Part and Parcel of Property at House NO-53 Basement Upper Ground Floor and 3rd floor at Srinagar Colony Sindhora Kalan Ashok Vihar New Delhi-110052 Measuring 150 Sq Yards**	E) 26.09.2019 F) Rs. 56.06 lakhs plus further interest & Other charges G) 11.03.2020 H) Symbolic	A) Rs.244.80 lakhs B) Rs.24.48 lakhs C) Rs.100000/-	**04.08.2026** 11.00 am to 04.00 pm	There is no SA filed / stay on sale of property	Sh. Sunil Kumar Dash 9437322902

BRIEF TERMS AND CONDITIONS OF E-AUCTION SALE: The sale shall be subject to the Terms & Conditions prescribed in the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002 and to the following further conditions. 1. The auction sale will be "online through e-auction" portal **https://baanknet.com (2) Platform (https://baanknet.com)** for e-Auction will be provided by e Auction service provider **M/s PSB Alliance Pvt. Ltd. having its Registered office at Unit 1, 3rd Floor, VIOS Commercial Tower, Near Wadala Truck Terminal, Wadala East Mumbai-400037 (Helpdesk Number +91 8291220220,** The intending Bidders/ Purchasers are required to participate in the e-Auction process at e-Auction Service Provider's website **https://baanknet.com** This Service Provider will also provide online demonstration/ training on e-Auction on the portal. **(3)** The Sale Notice containing the General Terms and Conditions of Sale is available / published in the following websites/ web page portal. **(1) https://baanknet.com (2) www.pnbindia.in (4)** Payment of sale consideration by the successful bidder to the bank will be subject to TDS under Section 194- 1A of Income Tax Act 1961 and TDS is to be paid by the successful bidder only at the time of deposit of remaining 75 % of the bid amount / full deposit of BID amount. **(5)** The properties are being sold on **"AS IS WHERE IS BASIS" and "AS IS WHAT IS BASIS" and "WHATEVER THERE IS BASIS". (6)** The particulars of Secured Assets specified in the Schedule herein above stated to the best of the information of the Authorized Officer, but the Authorized Officer shall not be answerable for any error, misstatement or omission in this proclamation. **(7)** Notice under Section 13(8) of the SARFAESI Act, and with Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 has been issued in all the above cases **(8)** For detailed term and conditions of the sale, please refer **https://baanknet.in & www.pnbindia.in.**

Date: 14.07.2026, Place : New Delhi **AUTHORIZED OFFICER, PUNJAB NATIONAL BANK , SECURED CREDITOR**

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Procurement Tender Notice No. 26/32 Dt. 14.07.2026

E-Procurement Tender Notice

On behalf of the President of India, **The Principal Chief Materials Manager, North Central Railway, Prayagraj, (An ISO 9001:2015 certified unit)** invites the following E-Procurement Tenders.

Tender No. : 63265643 | **Qty. : 3000 MT**

Short Description : Manufacture and supply of 53-S grade Ordinary Portland Cement to BIS specification IS-269, 2015 as amended up to date of tender opening.

Tender Opening Date : 07.08.2026

Tender No. : 30262124 | **Qty. : 25118 Set.**

Short Description : NON ASBESTOS BASED ORGANIC BRAKE PADS FOR LHB TYPE COACHES.

Tender Opening Date : 11.08.2026

Tender No. : 30262030A | **Qty. : 163 NOS.**

Short Description : SECONDARY SPRING (OUTER) FOR GENERATOR SIDE-1

Tender Opening Date : 18.08.2026

Note : The complete information of above tenders can be seen and downloaded from **IREPS** website i.e. **https://www.ireps.gov.in.** Fory any change/ corrigendum in tender, please visit this website regularly. No. separate corrigendum/change will be published in news paper. **1612/26 (C)**

North central railways www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @ CPRONC

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE No. ELG-09-J07-2026-27 **Date : 13-07-2026**

E-TENDER NOTICE

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer (General) N. C. Railway, Agra on behalf of President of India invites "Open Tender" through on line only (E-Tendering) for the following works.

Tender No. : ELG-09-J07-2026-27

Name of work with its location & Completion Period : Electrification work in connection with Re-development of office-cum rest room complex at Shivaji Bridge, New Delhi. **Completion period : 08 months**

Approx. Cost of the work : Rs. 6184318.32

• For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website **www.ireps.gov.in.** • Tenders can only be submitted through web portal **www.ireps.gov.in** up to **15:00 hrs.** on **10-08-2026.** **1620/26 (AS)**

North central railways www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @ CPRONCR

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.PC/84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Ashok Mehra, S/o Deep Chandra R/o Flat No.85A, Ground Floor, Pocket, C-1, Mayur Vihar, Phase-3, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.220/2025 dt. 06.05.2025 u/s 420/467/468/471/ 120B/34 IPC, P.S. Gazipur, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Ashok Mehra** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Ashok Mehra** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Ashok Mehra** of **FIR No.220/2025 dt. 06.05.2025 u/s 420/467/468/ 471/120B/34 IPC, P.S. Gazipur, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **20.08.2026.**

By Order,
Amit Rana
Judicial Magistrate First Class-06, East District
Court No.12, Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/9767/ED/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person, namely, **Md. Izaz, S/o** Md Ishrafil**, R/o** Gali Tant Wali, Motia Khan, Sadar Bazar, Delhi, **Also At**: Satdhara Ward No 1, Rajnagar, Distt. Madhubhani, Bihar, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No.: 26/2017, U/s: 324/341/34 IPC, P.S.: Sadar Bazar, Delhi,** and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused person, **Md. Izaz,** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person, **Md. Izaz,** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person, **Md. Izaz, FIR No.: 26/2017, U/s: 324/341/34 IPC, P.S.: Sadar Bazar, Delhi,** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **05.09.2026.**

By Order
Sh Kartik Taparia
Judicial Magistrate First Class-06
Room No 247, Central,
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/9773/N/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSONS

(See Section 82 Cr.PC)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **(1) Raja @ Faiyaz S/o Izaz Ahmed, R/o H.No.2425, Gali No. 21, Baljeet Nagar, Delhi and (2) Amit @ Ganja S/o Daulat Singh, R/o H.No.252, Near Gujjar Chowk, Bhalswa Dairy, Delhi** have committed (or are suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 501/2021, u/s 323/341/506/34 IPC, P.S. Hari Nagar, Delhi** and it have been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Raja @ Faiyaz and Amit @ Ganja** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Raja @ Faiyaz and Amit @ Ganja** have absconded (or are concealing themselves to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Raja @ Faiyaz and Amit @ Ganja** of **FIR No. 501/2021, u/s 323/341/506/34 IPC, P.S. Hari Nagar, Delhi** are required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **22.08.2026.**

By Order
Ms. Moksha Bains
Judicial Magistrate First Class-11, (West)
Room No. 31, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/9677/WD/2026

New Okhla Industrial Development Authority

Administrative Building, Sector-96, NOIDA-201301 (U.P.)
Website : www.noidaauthorityonline.in

E-TENDER NOTICE

E-Tenders are invited from eligible firms/contractors for the following job against which bids can be uploaded and same shall be opened/downloaded as per schedule mentioned. The details and conditions of all tenders are available on Noida Authority's official website : **www.noidaauthorityonline.in** & **https://etender.up.nic.in.** Please ensure to see these websites for any changes / amendments & corrigendum etc.

A) (Rs. 1.00 Lacs to 30.00 Lacs)

S. No.	Job No.	Sale Start Date	Sale End Date	Tender Opening Date and Time
1.	**Job No.-06/ E-TENDER/SPO/ 2026-27** Name of Work - Procurement of winter uniform fabric, **Estimated Cost Rs. 19,19,522.00**	17.07.2026	23.07.2026 upto 5:00 PM	24.07.2026 11.00 AM

Office : Sector - 39, Noida **Store Purchase Officer, NOIDA**

CLEAN, GREEN, SAFE & SECURE NOIDA

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Meera, W/o Dalip Kumar, R/o Gali No. 03, Prahlad Vihar, Sector-25, Rohini, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 337/2022, U/s 33 D.E. Act, P.S. Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Meera** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Meera** has absconded (or is concealing herself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Meera** accused of **FIR No. 337/2022, U/s 33 D.E. Act, P.S. Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **10.09.2026.**

By Order - Ms. Bharti Beniwal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05, North
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/9770/ON/2026

UNION TERRITORY OF JAMMU & KASHMIR

OFFICE THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PWD R and B DIVISION BAKSHI NAGAR JAMMU

Short e-NIT No.37of 2026-2027 Dated:-13-08-2026

For and on behalf of the Lieutenant Governor, Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir e-tenders are invited on percentage basis from approved and eligible Contractors registered with Union Territory of J&K, CPWD, Railways, MES and other State/Central Governments for each of the following works :-

S. No	Name of Work	Name of Division	Advertised Cost (Rs. Lakh)	Cost of document (in Rs.)	Earnest Money (in Rs.)	Time Allowed for complete-on	Time and date of opening of tender	Class of Contractor
1	Balance work of existing Auditorium at IGGDC Jammu	PWD (R&B) DIVISION BAKSHI NAGAR Jammu	19.36	600	2% of Advertised Cost	90 Days	23-07-2026 (12.00 Pm)	"A,B&C"
2	Construction of retaining wall behind Principal residence quarters Guest House at IGGDH Jammu	PWD (R&B) DIVISION BAKSHI NAGAR Jammu	9.72	600	2% of Advertised Cost	90 Days	23-07-2026 (12.00 Pm))	"A,BC,&D"
3	Construction of entry gate in front of Block A of IGGDH Jammu	PWD (R&B) DIVISION BAKSHI NAGAR Jammu	13.15	600	2% of Advertised Cost	90 Days	23-07-2026 (12.00 Pm)	"A,B,C&D"

Position of AAA / TS : Accorded

The Bidding documents Consisting of qualifying information, eligibility criteria, specifications, Drawings, bill of quantities (B.O.Q), Set of terms and conditions of contract and other details can be seen / downloaded from the departmental website http://jktenders.gov.in as per below schedule :-

1	Date of Issue of Tender Notice	13-07-2026
2	Period of downloading of bidding documents	From 13-07-2026 to 22-07-2026 upto 1800 Hrs
3	Date, Time and place of pre-bid meeting	-
4	Bid submission Start Date	13-07-2026
5	Bid Submission End Date	22-07-2026 upto 1800 Hrs
6	Date & time of opening of Technical Bids (Online)	23-07-2026 on or after 1200 Hrs in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Bakshi Nagar Jammu
7	Date & time of opening of Financial Bids	To be notified after technical bid evaluation is completed

1.Bids must be accompanied with cost of Tender document in shape of e-challan through Treasury indicating Treasury Voucher No. & date, e-NIT No. and name of work duly crediting to MH 0059 (Revenue) favoring Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Bakshi Nagar Jammu and upload the same i.e treasury challan / receipt, Earnest money/Bid security in shape of CDR/FDR/BG pledged to Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Bakshi Nagar Jammu The CDR/FDR/BG shall be valid for 45 Days beyond the bid validity period. The original instruments in respect of cost of documents, EMD and relevant documents of L1 be submitted to the Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Bakshi Nagar Jammu at the time of allotment.

2. The electronic bidding system would not allow any late submission of bids after due date and time as per server time. Bidders may modify their bids by uploading their request for modification before the deadline for submission of bids. For this, the bidder needs not to make any additional payment towards the cost of tender document. For bid modification and consequential re-submission, the bidder is not required to withdraw his bid submitted earlier. The last modified bid submitted by the bidder within the bid submission time shall be considered as the bid. For this purpose, modification/withdrawal by other means will not be accepted. In online system of bid submission, the modification and consequential- submission of bids is allowed any number of times. The bidders may withdraw his bid by uploading their request before the deadline for submission of bids; however, if the bid is withdrawn, the re-submission of the bid is not allowed. No bid shall be modified or withdrawn after the deadline of submission of bids.

3. The date and time of opening of Financial-Bids shall be notified on Web Site www.jktenders.gov.in and conveyed to the bidders automatically through an e-mail message on their e-mail address. The Financial-bids of responsive bidders shall be opened online in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Bakshi Nagar Jammu The date for same shall be intimated separately.

4. The bids for the work shall remain valid for a period of 120 days from the date of opening of Technical bids.

5. The earnest money shall be forfeited, If :-

a) Any bidder/tenderer withdraws his bid/tender during the period of bid validity or makes any modifications in the terms and conditions of the bid.

b) Failure of Successful bidder to furnish the required performance security within specified time period after issue of letter of acceptance.

c) Failure of successful bidder to execute the agreement on same day of allotment of work contract as per Chief Engineer PW (R&B) Department

d) Jammu's Circular No. CEJ/G/12660-87 dated 07-10-2021.

6. Instruction to bidders regarding e-tendering process.

6.1 Bidders are advised to download bid submission manual from the "Downloads" option as well as from "Bidders Manual Kit" on website www.jktenders.gov.in to acquaint bid submission process.

6.2. To participate in bidding process, bidders have to get 'Digital Signature Certificate (DSC)' as per Information Technology Act-2000. Bidders can get digital certificate from any approved vendors.

6.3. The bidders have to submit their bids online in electronic format with digital Signature. No financial bid will be accepted in physical form.

6.4. Bids will be opened online as per time schedule mentioned above.

6.5. Bidders must ensure to upload scanned copy of all necessary documents mentioned in NIT and SBD with technical bid online.

No: - EE/R&B/BN/ 317-26
Dated:- 13-07-2026
DIP No:DIP/J-5872/26

Sd/-
(ER. SANDEEP GUPTA)
Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division
Bakshi Nagar

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 (2)(ii) Cr.Pc.

Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Asha D/o Lalla Ram** R/o H.No. 1133, Peepal Wali Gali, Motia Khan, Paharganj, Delhi have committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence under case **FIR.No.80/2016 u/s 33/38/58 Delhi Excise Act & 279 IPC has been registered at P.S. Nihal Vihar Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said, **Asha** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, **Asha** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, **Asha** under case **FIR No. 80/2016 u/s 33/38/58 Delhi Excise Act & 279 IPC.** registered at **PS. Nihal Vihar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **17.08.2026**

By Order
Ms. Komal Garg,
Ld.MM-03, West, Room No.292,
Tis Hazari Court Delhi

DP/9754/OD/2026
(court notice)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person(s) **Aakash @ Wasi, S/o:** Sh. Ganesh **R/o:** 2247, Transit Camp, Anand Parvat, **Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 369/2019, U/s: 392,397,411,34 IPC, PS: Patel Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Aakash @ Wasi,** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Aakash @ Wasi,** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Aakash @ Wasi,** of **FIR No. 369/2019, U/s: 392,397,411,34 IPC, PS: Patel Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **17.08.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Saumya Chauhan
Additional Sessions Judge (FTC)
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/9704/CD/2026
(Court Matter)

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

No.:JHS/W/T/Tender General/162-163 **Date : 14.07.2026**

E- Tendering Tender Notice

Divisional Railway Manager (Works) N.C. Railway, Jhansi for and behalf of President of India invites sealed " Open Tender" through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.

S. No.: 1, E-Tender No.: JHS-ENGG-C-2026-162, **Description of work:** PRN-CNB section: Rehabilitation / Repair ,seepage protection & other associated ancillary works in LHS/RUB/bridges under ADEN/CNB jurisdiction.

Approx Cost: ₹ 1,93,29,607.76 | **Earnest Money:** ₹ 3,86,600.00

S. No.: 2, E-Tender No.: JHS-ENGG-C-2026-163, **Description of work:** BINA-JHS section: Rehabilitation/repair, seepage protection & other associated ancillary works in LHS/RUB/bridge under ADEN/LAR juridiction.

Approx Cost: ₹ 1,71,98,748.01 | **Earnest Money:** ₹ 3,44,000.00

Date of closing Tender: For S.No.: 1 & 2:- 07.08.2026 at 15:00 hrs.

Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter: For S.No.: 1 & 2:- 06 Months.

Note: (1) Tender online can be submitted up to **15:00** hrs on **07.08.2026**. **(2)** For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website **www.ireps.gov.in** **1618/26 (MG)**

North central railways @CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

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PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Ashu** S/o Mangal R/o BB-83, Gali No. 03, Bakriyan Basti, Nabi Karim, Paharganj, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 599/2021 U/s 356/379/411/34 IPC, PS Sadar Bazar, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Ashu** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Ashu** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Ashu** in **FIR No. 599/2021 U/s 356/379/411/34 IPC, PS Sadar Bazar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **13.10.2026**.

By order
Sh. Kartik Taparia
Judicial Magistrate First Class -06
Room No. 247, Central
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/9777/N/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person, namely, **Malook Nagar, R/o:** H.No. D-13 Defence Colony, New Delhi, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 633/2016, U/s 420/406/120B IPC,** registered at **P.S.: Vikaspuri, Delhi,** and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused person, **Malook Nagar**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person, **Malook Nagar,** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said, accused person, **Malook Nagar, FIR No. 633/2016, U/s 420/406/120B IPC,** registered at **P.S.: Vikaspuri, Delhi,** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **24.08.2026.**

By Order
Sh. Vinod Kumar
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05
South-West Distt., Room No.9,
Dwarka Court, Delhi

DP/9638/WD/2026
(Court Matter)

NORTHERN RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE

The Dy. Chief Engineer/Const., Northern Railway, Shakurbasti, Delhi for and on behalf of the President of India invites e-tender under Single Packet System for the under noted work:-

Name of work and location	P.Way linking and other allied works such as Assembling, laying, linking & dismantling of B.G Railway track, points & crossing, traps, leading of P.Way material & PRC sleepers, AT Welding and IN-SITU glued joints in c/w 3rd line work between Delhi Kishanganj to Shakurbasti under Dy. CE/C/SSB
Completion period of the work	15 (Fifteen Months)
Approx. Cost of work	Rs. 7.37 Cr
Earnest Money amount (to be deposited Online)	Rs. 14,74,900.00
Sale /availability of tender document on Railway Web site	Tender documents will be available on IREPS web site i.e **www.ireps.gov.in** from 27.07.26 to 10.08.26 upto 15.00 hrs
Last date/Time of upload of tenders	10.08.26 upto 15.00 hrs Tender documents can be uploaded by the tenderer on IREPS web site w.e.f 27.07.26 to 10.08.26
Date & Time for submission of E-tender and opening of tender	10.08.26 at 15.00 hours (immediately after closed of uploading of tender
Opening of Tender	10.08.26 at 15.00 hours (immediately after closed of uploading of tender

Tender Notice No. 422-ACS-C-SSB Date: 15.07.26 **2447/2026**

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person, namely, **Rakesh Malhotra, S/o:** Pawan Malhotra, **R/o:** Flat No. 221-A, Pocket-A-5, Block, Paschim Vihar, West Delhi, has commited (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No.: 81/2025 U/s 33/38/58(D) Delhi Excise Act,** registered at **P.S.: Jaffarpur Kalan, Delhi,** and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused person, **Rakesh Malhotra,** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person, **Rakesh Malhotra,** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said, accused person, **Rakesh Malhotra, FIR No.: 81/2025 U/s 33/38/58(D) Delhi Excise Act,** registered at **P.S.: Jaffarpur Kalan, Delhi,** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **10.09.2026.**

By Order
Sh Pankaj Rai
Judicial Magistrate First Class-09
South-West Distt., Room No. 314
District Court Dwarka, Delhi

DP/9623/DW/2026
(Court Matter)

He also spoke warmly of his co-star Shah Rukh Khan's impact on Indian cinema

'They don't make movies like Kal Ho Na Ho anymore'

Actor Saif Ali Khan revisited some of his most celebrated performances

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Saif Ali Khan, one of Hindi cinema's most versatile actors, recently sat down with 'IMDb' for an exclusive segment, where he revisited some of his most celebrated performances, decoding the choices behind them and sharing candid anecdotes from the sets of these classics.

Talking about how he came to play Langda Tyagi in 'Omkara', Khan recalled a remarkable coincidence involving his mother, veteran actress Sharmila Tagore and director Vishal Bhardwaj. Shortly after his mother encouraged him to explore Shakespearean roles 'like Othello', his phone rang. "It was Vishal Bhardwaj, saying, 'I'm thinking of doing Shakespeare'. I was like, 'What?' And he was like, 'Yes, Othello'," he recalled. Khan also added a light-hearted detail about the casting conversation, revealing, "Vishal came over and he started telling me about this. I said, 'Should I play Othello?' And he said, 'No,

no. You're too handsome to play him.'"

Reflecting on 'Love Aaj Kal', the actor made a case for the film to be revisited by audiences. "'Love Aaj Kal' is a slightly underrated film. I think it's a very good film. It didn't get very good reviews," he said. Speaking about director Imtiaz Ali's writing, he observed, "He almost creates these slightly emotionally unhinged, not very sorted out people, which is, like so many of us, when we are in love." Khan also revealed a behind-the-scenes creative discussion around the film's climax, sharing, "He wanted a different end where we, again, miss each other. When Jai finally comes back to Meera, she's pregnant and he's missed it all. So, we pushed Imtiaz for a happier ending. And he said no for the longest time. Then in London, Dinesh and I went and knocked on his door and said, 'Imtiaz, come on'. Finally, he said, 'Yeah, okay, maybe you guys have a point'. And I was like, 'Thank God.'"

On 'Kal Ho Na Ho', Saif reflected on the film's lasting legacy: "I don't know if they will make movies like 'Kal Ho Na Ho' anymore, because now we make more movies set in our own country. But there was this whole NRI wave going on at that time, with Shah Rukh riding it with a surfboard." He also spoke warmly of his co-star Shah Rukh Khan's impact on Indian cinema, stating, "Working with Shah Rukh Khan closely with that kind of energy and swapping it and experiencing that kind of stardom; that world; what he's done for Indian cinema and taken us to such respectable heights internationally."

Discussing 'Tanhaji: The Unsung Hero', Khan offered an honest take on his role as Udaybhan, saying, "With this film, a bit like 'Omkara', I was like, 'Okay, I just have to have fun. And I don't have anything to do, because Ajay is playing Tanhaji'. But Tanhaji, like a very respectable hero, is a little bit - not flat - but he's a little bit quiet also. He's not a very spiky, dramatic kind of person. So, he's underplayed and the film's going on. So, to make it fun and to make it work, Udaybhan's character has to do the heavy lifting."

Looking back at 'Parineeta', Khan credited producer Vidhu Vinod Chopra for pushing him toward lead roles. "Vidhu Vinod Chopra used to encourage me and say, 'You're a great actor and you should stop playing second leads, okay? You should focus on, hold out, wait and play the lead in a movie. I'm going to offer you something soon'. And then sure enough, the offer came in," he recalled.

'Go on a hunger strike for a day'

Actor Atul Kulkarni observed a day-long fast at his home on Thursday to support education reformer and climate activist Sonam Wangchuk in his hunger strike to protest against exam paper leaks.

Wangchuk has been on an indefinite hunger strike after joining the Cockroach Janata Party's (CJP) protest demanding education minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation over alleged irregularities in the NEET examination.

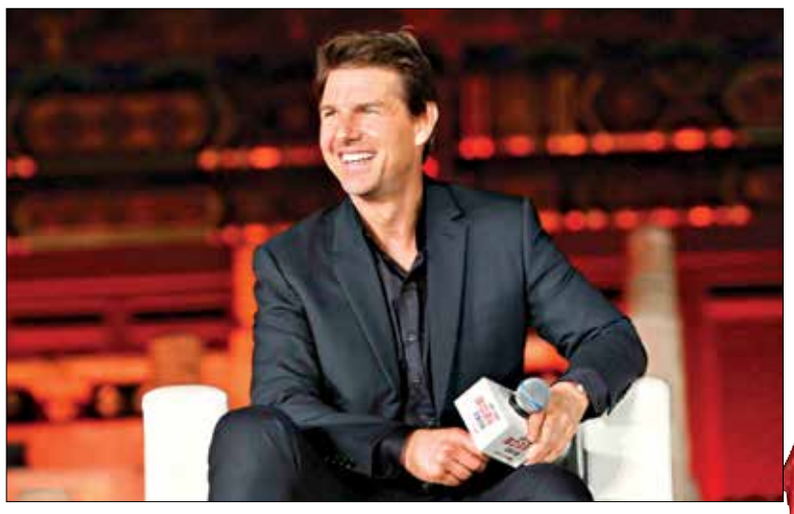
The 'Rang De Basanti' star shared a video on social media on Wednesday evening to extend his support to Wangchuk. "I will go on a hunger strike on June 16. There are two reasons for this: I want to connect with the pain that Sonam Wangchuk ji and his companions are going through and an appeal to our government to express their sensitivity. Sonam ji and his companions believe that there are some serious and painful reasons and for that they have certain demands. It is clear that our government believes that those demands are not justified," Kulkarni said on 'Instagram'.

Atul Kulkarni observed a fast for a day on July 16 to support Sonam Wangchuk in his hunger strike

The actor then urged fans and followers to connect to Wangchuk by observing a one-day fast. "Go on a hunger strike for a day. I once heard a gentle and wise person say that it is important for pain to have a relationship with pain. So, let us connect pain with pain. Let us begin a movement and try to do a one-day fast," he said.

From the film fraternity, '3 Idiots' star Omy Vaidya, Zeenat Aman, Soni Razdan, Shabana Azmi, Anurag Kashyap and Abhay Deol have extended their support to Wangchuk while urging him to end his fast of 19 days. PTI

'Tone is something that you have to discover'



Hollywood star Tom Cruise said working with Oscar-winning filmmaker Alejandro G Inarritu on 'Digger' challenged him to discover new layers in his character continually.

Cruise headlines the film as Digger Rockwell, an oil baron whose company's actions trigger an ecological disaster with the potential to spark a nuclear war. Speaking about developing the character alongside Inarritu, the actor said the role evolved through constant collaboration.

"It's just layers; you're just finding it and Alejandro G Inarritu always was very deliberate about what he wanted with the character. He showed me this thing and I was just like, 'Oh, my God, this guy's got cojones,'" Cruise said.

The actor said finding the film's distinctive tone was an organic process. "Tone is something that you have to discover. You don't just read it. You've got to feel your way through it. You've got to look at the lens and he's developing it. We just had a lot of fun finding those layers. He and I both together; it just happens," he added.

Tom Cruise said Alejandro G Inarritu pushed him to discover new layers in 'Digger'

'Digger' is billed as an original comedy with disaster elements from the 'Birdman' and 'The Revenant' filmmaker. The film also stars Riz Ahmed, John Goodman, Sandra Hüller, Michael Stuhlbarg and Jesse Plemons. Robert John Burke, Emma D'Arcy, Burn Gorman and Sophie Wilde round out the cast. PTI

'Never saw him outside that space'

Tilottama Shome on Akshaye Khanna's quiet nature on 'Ikka' sets

Tilottama Shome opened up about working with Akshaye Khanna in 'Ikka'. In an exclusive interview with IANS, she shared insights into the actor's reserved nature and his dedication to staying connected with his character on set.

"His character also demanded that kind of energy. Every actor has a different process. Some actors are laughing and joking until the director calls action and then they instantly switch into character. Others prefer to stay quiet and mentally prepare themselves. Akshaye came to the set carrying the emotional energy of his character and remained in that zone throughout the shoot. I never really saw him outside that space," she shared.

'Akshaye came to the set carrying the emotional energy of his character,' she says

Speaking about working with Sunny Deol, Tilottama stated, "Sunny sir is a very introverted person and so am I. People often assume actors are naturally extroverted because we face the camera, but that's not always true. What I loved about him was that even in his silence, there was tremendous warmth. Sometimes a person's silence can make the atmosphere uncomfortable, but his silence made everyone around him feel relaxed. Whenever we spoke, he was always kind, respectful and extremely generous. He is a true gentleman, something that feels increasingly rare today."

In 'Ikka', directed by Siddharth P Malhotra, Tilottama essayed the role of Madhura Banerjee, a determined public prosecutor who faces off against Sunny Deol's character, Arjun Mehra, a defence attorney, in the courtroom drama. In an interesting twist, Shome's character delivered Sunny Deol's iconic 'Dhai Kilo Ka Haath' dialogue in the film. AGENCIES

5 WOMEN-LED ACTION COMEDIES THAT PACK PUNCHES & PUNCHLINES

These women prove that saving the day doesn't have to be all doom and gloom

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Whether they're dodging bullets, cracking impossible cases or taking down criminals with a perfectly timed one-liner, these women prove that saving the day doesn't have to be all doom and gloom. Equal parts thrilling and entertaining, these films and series swap brooding heroes for fearless protagonists who can throw a punch, deliver a punchline and steal every scene they're in. If you're looking for stories where badass women steal the spotlight with a generous dose of humour, these action comedies deserve a spot on your watchlist.

Ride or Die (Prime Video)

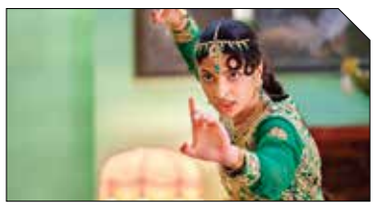
'Ride or Die' follows lifelong best friends Debbie (Octavia Spencer) and Judith (Hannah Waddingham), whose seemingly ordinary friendship is upended when Debbie discovers that Judith has secretly been working as an international assassin. After a mission goes disastrously wrong, the two are forced to go on the run across Europe, pursued by dangerous criminals, fellow assassins and law enforcement. Packed with explosive action, hilarious banter and an unlikely duo at its heart, it is a fun, high-stakes adventure that proves friendship can survive even the wildest of circumstances.

Enola Holmes 3 (Netflix)

'Enola Holmes 3' sees the brilliant young detective return for another thrilling mystery, balancing clever deductions with daring escapes, hand-to-hand combat and her signature wit. As Enola (Millie Bobby Brown) takes on her most challenging case yet, she must outsmart dangerous adversaries while continuing to forge her own path outside the shadow of her famous brother, Sherlock Holmes. Blending mystery, action and humour, the film once again showcases why Enola is one of modern cinema's most charming and fearless women on screen.

Polite Society (Prime Video)

'Polite Society' follows Ria Khan (Priya Kansara), a martial arts-loving teenager who sets out to stop her older sister's wedding after becoming convinced something isn't quite right. Teaming up with her friends, Ria embarks on a wildly entertaining mission filled with inventive fighting sequences, laugh-out-loud moments and delightfully unexpected twists. Featuring a memorable supporting performance from Akshaye Khanna, the film blends action, comedy and heartfelt family dynamics into a fresh, high-energy celebration of sisterhood and self-belief.



'Ride or Die' is a fun, high-stakes adventure that proves friendship can survive even the wildest of circumstances

Wingwomen (Netflix)

'Wingwomen' stars Adèle Exarchopoulos as Alex and Mélanie Laurent as Carole, two master thieves and lifelong friends preparing for one last heist before leaving their dangerous lives behind. But when the mission spirals out of control, the duo must rely on their chemistry, quick thinking and fearless instincts to stay one step ahead of everyone chasing them. Stylish, witty and fast-paced, the French action comedy blends slick heist thrills with sharp humour, making for an effortlessly entertaining watch.

Birds of Prey & the Fantabulous… (JioHotstar)

'Birds of Prey and the Fantabulous Emancipation of One Harley Quinn' puts one of pop culture's most iconic anti-heroines front and centre. After breaking free from the Joker, Harley Quinn (Margot Robbie) finds herself in the crosshairs of Gotham City's most dangerous criminals and is forced to team up with a group of equally fearless women to protect a young girl from a ruthless crime lord. Bursting with over-the-top action, razor-sharp humour and Harley's trademark energy, the film cements her status as one of cinema's original badass female action icons.

Whether they're solving mysteries, pulling off impossible heists or taking down criminals with a punchline, these women prove that sometimes action is better when it's paired with a healthy dose of humour!